

A SOUTHERN GOTHIC-CATHOLIC NOIR THRILLER

**SHE WAS SOLD TO THE ROOT.
HE WAS FORGED TO BE A
SHIELD.**

In the deep shadows of New Orleans, time isn't measured by the ticking of clocks, but by the closing of contracts.

Kimbra Woods was never meant to be a girl; she was groomed to be an asset. Sold as a child to the powerful **Boudreaux** family, she was raised as a Hearth—a biological battery destined to sustain the prince of the **Crimson Root**. Marked by a violent, pulsing **Blood Lily** brand, Kimbra flees a nightmare ritual and storms the gates of **Our Lady of Tears Academy**.

There, she collides with **Roman De la Croix**, a stoic protector who has renounced his high-society life for a uniform of salt and stone. To sever her past, Kimbra must choose a Baptism under fire. But the cost of grace is a supernatural bond that grafts her strength to Roman's, making them the primary targets for the **Legacy of the Root!**

THE CLAIM HAS BEGUN.

BOOK 1 OF THE REFORM SCHOOL FOR WITCHES

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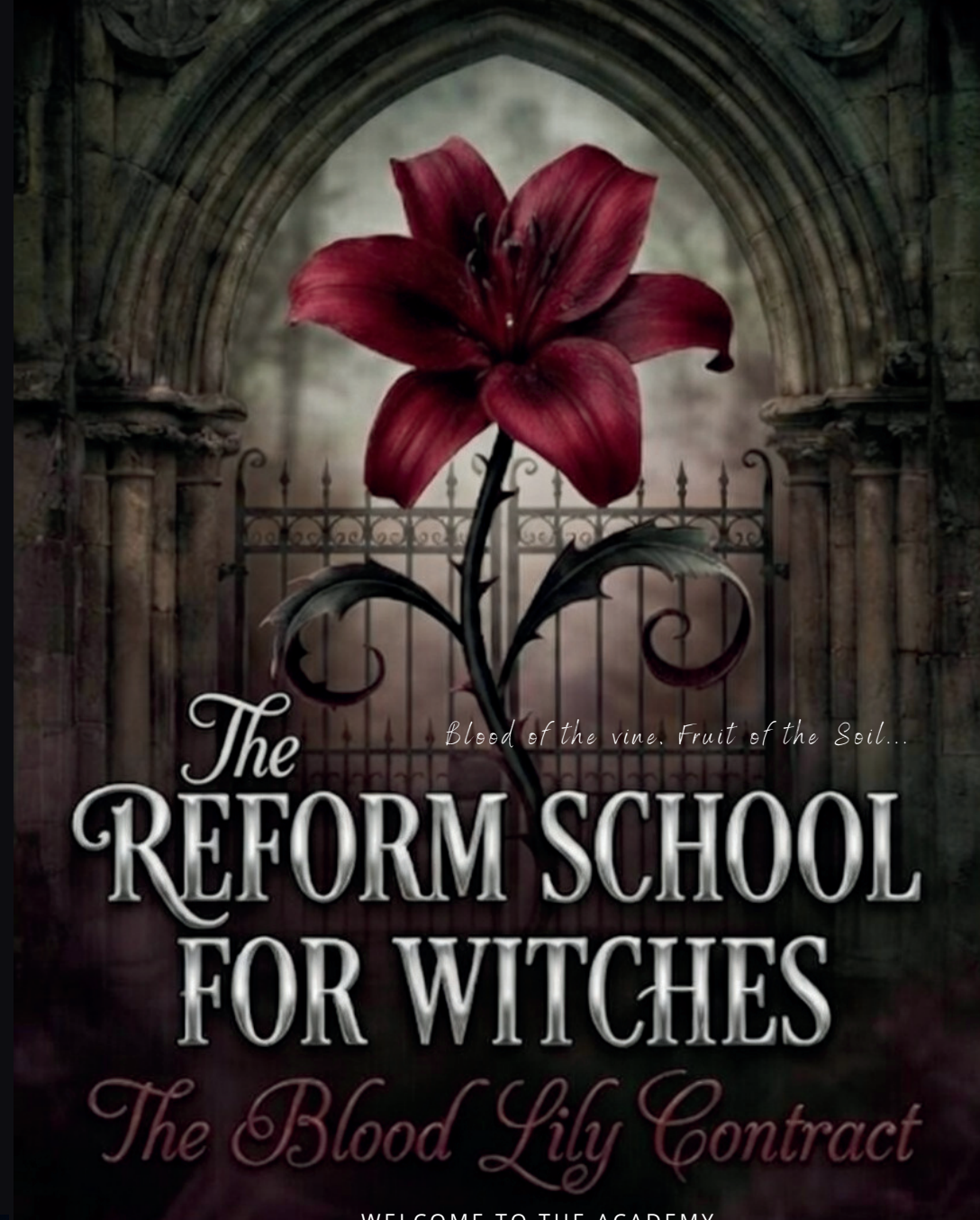


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Reform School for Witches

THE BLOOD LILY CONTRACT

Book 1



WELCOME TO THE ACADEMY.

a RedCandle Series

BOOK 1

*For Sister Laura Mainetti,
May you be Glorious in Heaven.*

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ISBN: 9798196451393

RedCandle Digital
Eagle River, Alaska
www.redcandledigital.io

The Reform School for Witches

BOOK 1

THE BLOOD LILY CONTRACT



OUR LADY OF TEARS ACADEMY



Established in 1833

PREFACE

In the city of New Orleans, time is not measured by the ticking of clocks, but by the closing of contracts.

Most citizens walk the French Quarter unaware that the cobblestones beneath their feet are saturated with a thirst older than the dirt itself. Hidden from their sight are the threads woven into the power grid, the corrupted intelligence of a Ledger that deduces human lives as collateral.

For centuries, the Boudreaux Empire has siphoned the light from their victims to fuel a legacy of borrowed time. Their chosen vessels are known as Hearths—biological batteries destined for utter depletion until nothing remains but the void.

But there is a Law higher than the Ledger.

Beyond the moss-draped swamps stands a fortress of salt and stone: Our Lady of Tears Academy. Here, the Exceptions are forged—souls too burdened for the ordinary world, trained as soldiers to withstand the crushing pressure of the abyss.

This is the record of the Blood Lily, the girl who was sold to be an asset but chose to become a flame. It is the story of a Shield who traded a life of luxury for a cross, and a prince who had to die to his name to save his soul.

In the pages that follow, remember: the darkness only reveals the depth of the light. The debt may be written in the marrow, but the ransom is paid in blood, iron and tears.

Welcome to the Academy...

PROLOGUE

BLOOD OF THE ROOT

Inside the conservatory of the Boudreaux estate, a cloying, bruised sweetness lingered—the scent of nectar left to ferment in the sun.

Six-year-old Kimbra stood on a plastic stool, her small hand trembling in the merciless grip of Vincent Boudreaux. Across from her stood his son, Damian. At seven, his eyes were wide with a confusion that would, over the next eleven years, harden into a haunting devotion.

On the altar between them lay the lily—a suffocating shroud of spice and musk. Its petals were unnatural: a violent crimson, pulsing with a slow, sickening light locked to the rhythm of the children's own heartbeats.

“Blood of the vine, fruit of the soil.” His voice was a low vibration, rattling the conservatory's glass panes in their leaden frames.

He produced a small needle.

With a practiced, clinical prick, he drew a single drop of blood from the little girl's thumb, and then another from the boy's, mixing them into the plant.

The children witnessed the ritual in silence as their vital fluid flowed down the central bulb and soaked the petals.

Then, a new bud emerged.

A translucent script manifested throughout the unfolding bloom, written in a dead language.

“It is done.”

Vincent leaned down until his lips brushed the girl’s ear. “You are no longer Kimberly Woods. You are the Blood Lily, a debt owed to this family. And when you’ve fully bloomed, the Root will come to collect.”

A sickening pull yanked at her ribs—the first knot of the Sanguine Tether tightening in her chest. This moment marked the beginning of her erasure.

She only knew the flower was beautiful, and the garden was her new home.

FLOWERS

The willow tree was a cathedral of drooping glass and emerald light. Beneath its sweeping branches, the heat of the New Orleans afternoon lost its teeth, turning into a drowsy breeze carrying the scent of tangy citrus.

Kimbra sat in its shade with her back against the rough, familiar ridges of the trunk. Her long, soft hair was tangled in leaves. A leather-bound volume lay open in her lap—its pages filled with poems, promises, and prose capturing the ephemeral depth of love.

It was the kind of anthology existing only in ink and dreams, far removed from the suffocating walls of the Boudreaux Mansion.

This spot, hidden in the center of the Grand Estate, was her private refuge. It was the only place where the shifting shadows—and the stranger things taking place behind its French Victorian doors—couldn't reach her. Here, she was determined to guard her purity, clinging to a childlike wonder.

The scent of rich earth and river silt gave way to lilies—her favorite—a spicy sweetness clawing at the back of her throat, ripe enough to taste—then, the atmosphere shifted.

A familiar hum vibrated in her blood, a sense of completeness arriving only when he did.

“I knew I’d find you here,” he murmured through the branches.

The curtain of leaves parted, and Damian stepped through. He was every bit the scion of the Boudreaux Empire—white linen shirt open at the collar, wavy hair tangled by the humidity. He watched her with loyal adoration. It was a devotion that had followed her since childhood, from the sandbox to the garden, always seeking her safe places.

“You’re supposed to be in the Library.” The words on the page had ceased to matter; he was the only story she had ever known.

Her relationship with him was intimate. Not a day went by without the tie vibrating inside of her—a shared note. She recognized the traces of his mind better than her own—the way his brow furrowed when he thought of his father, the way his breath hitched before he spoke a truth. He was her mirror-half sharing a tragic symbiosis, a paradox of two lives knit so tightly they were practically one.

“The Library is full of dust and my father’s temper.” He sank onto the grass, his feline grace closing the gap between them. “Besides, I prefer the company of the girl under the tree.” He surprised her with a bouquet of white lilies. “For you.”

She inhaled the favorable scent, letting the pollen stain her nose. “You know me so well.” They were pristine, their petals waxy and firm, their stamens caked with dust-like pollen, the stems bare bone against her fingers. The scent

was overwhelming now, an intoxicating nectar making her head swim.

He cupped her face to press a gentle kiss to her cheek.

“It’s the little things, right?” His thumb traced the delicate line of her jaw.

“They’re beautiful.” She smiled, a warmth radiating from her hazel eyes.

With his athletic build and striking features, he was enough to make every girl at the debutante balls swoon. But to him, those girls were dull backgrounds—rotten weeds to the cherished rose blooming in front of him.

In her company, his usual arrogance fell away, leaving behind a naked sincerity. Her soft cream skin, her sweet scent, her flowing hair—they were, to him, the only real things in a house of illusions.

“They’re more than that.” He rested his forehead against hers. “They’re a promise. A reminder that no matter what happens, I’ll always be here for you.” In the solace of the garden, his pulse beat steady and content against her awareness.

Ever since they were small children, they had relied on each other for survival. In the vapid halls of their upbringing, Kimbra had been the one to calm the storms in his mind, acting as his singular source of peace when his father’s expectations grew too burdensome. In return, Damian made her world feel less vast; he was the gravity keeping her from drifting away into the grey shadows of the estate.

For a while, the only sound was the wild cicada-thrum of the bayou.

“You’ve been quiet today,” he said softly. “Even for you. I felt your sadness all the way from the West Wing... What’s wrong?”

She leaned her head back against the bark. “Nothing... I was just thinking about how long we’ve been coming here. Do you remember when you were nine, and you tried to build a fort to hide from your Latin Tutor? You used all the silk cushions from the Sitting Room.”

He let out a short, breathy laugh. “I didn’t get very far. Father found the trail of silk before I even got the roof on. But you were the one who convinced me to come out. You told me if I finished the lesson, you’d show me where the fireflies gathered by the creek.”

His bright, clear laugh made the tightness in her chest vanish. She remembered that night by the creek—hiding in the tall grass where the humid heat of the levee met the cool breeze from a nearby ridge. Damian had caught a firefly in his little hands, his face illuminated by the green glow. He hadn’t kept it for himself; he had transferred the insect to her palms as if he were giving her a piece of the stars.

“As long as we’re together, Kimmy, we’ll never be in the dark.”

“You were always so easy to bribe,” she teased, though the playfulness was thin.

Back then, things were simple. Just a boy and a girl in a garden, making a world out of light from shadows. Sitting here now under the willow, that same warmth rushed through her—a desperate need to stay with him forever. He wasn’t only the heir of a house; he was the person who had

held her in his arms through every lonely night, the one she had shared her secrets with.

His smile was replaced by earnestness. He sat up, looking her directly in the eyes. “Kim,” he started, his tone dropping an octave. “Are you ready for tonight? For the ceremony?”

The question hung between them, a sudden stain on their perfect afternoon. It was the first time they had acknowledged the event all day.

Her fingers tightened around the stems. “I don’t know if ready is the right word. It’s felt like a destination my whole life, a door I’ve been walking toward since that day in the Conservatory.” She studied him. “Are you?”

“They talk about legacy, but all I care about is once it’s over, we’re official. Tonight isn’t an ending. It’s us facing the world on our own terms. And as long as we’re together, nothing else matters. I’d walk through fire if I knew you were waiting on the other side.”

She wanted to believe him so badly it ached. She imagined a life where the ceremony meant they could finally step out from under his father’s thumb—a life where they could travel, see the world beyond Louisiana, and belong only to each other.

“Are you sure about this?” she asked, searching for solidarity.

“When I look at you, Kim, all I see is the girl I’ve loved since I was seven years old.” He leaned in, his words a firm, undeniable vow. “I’m ready for what comes after, because it means I’ll never have to let you go.”

“I love you too.” Her doubt began to evaporate under his heat.

He dusted the dirt from his trousers as he stood, extending his hand toward hers. “Just us, Kimmy?” he asked with the innocence of the boy she’d known her whole life.

“Just us,” she confirmed, without a trace of hesitation.

Her fingers intertwined with his perfectly. The angst brewing in her mind dissipated. She knew if he was with her, any path they took was the bridge to their forever.

FULL BLOOM

As the front doors of the Manor closed, the serenity of the afternoon faded. The humid breath of the soil gave way to a filtered chill beneath high ceilings and marble floors—tasting of expensive wax. There was no noise here, only the mathematical precision of a Grandfather Clock in the Foyer, ticking toward an invisible hour.

Damian and Kimbra walked in lock step across the checkered marble. He didn't let go of her immediately; he lingered, his thumb brushing over her knuckles one last time. The bouquet in her arms appeared spectral against the polished mahogany paneling, their scent pooling into the space.

"I have to go to my father's study." His ease at the willow tree was gone, replaced by the practiced, formal posture he had worn since he was old enough to walk. "He wants to discuss the final arrangements. Will you be alright?"

"I'll be fine." The words were brittle, a dry leaf torn by the wind. He leaned down, pressing his lips to the soft curve of her shoulder—a romantic gesture that carried the weight of

an apology. He gave her a supportive nod before turning toward the East Wing.

The first draft of the evening swept over her. Without Damian's warmth to console her, the Manor was no longer a home; it was a pretentious gallery, and she was its most fragile exhibit. He disappeared around the corner, the familiar tug of the Sanguine Tether twisting behind her ribs, pulling her toward him even as she remained still.

"Miss Kimberly."

The address descended from above, snapping her back to reality. Madame Claudette, the executive of the Estate, stood at the top of the grand staircase. Her silhouette cut sharp against the light reflecting from the chandelier, her blonde hair pulled back tightly to accentuate the angles of her face. As the primary manager of the Boudreaux wards, Claudette was the personification of managed expectations.

"The Artisans are waiting." Her thick French accent was a smooth note. "The sun is setting, and we have a schedule to maintain. Give those to the Steward, Madam. White flowers have no place in tonight's palette."

Damian had called them a promise. Under Claudette's scrutiny, however, they were disparaged into child's play—clutter. A young man with a service tray, stepped forward from a hidden recess in the hallway. She surrendered the gift, her remaining freedom slipping away with it. The Steward carried them toward the Kitchen, bound to be discarded or repurposed into some less meaningful arrangement.

She followed Claudette upstairs, winding into the expanse of the stairwell. The house felt crowded tonight, though no one else appeared. She studied the timeless pictures

decorating the walls. A sense of prying eyes lingered behind each portrait, a collective indwelling of breath within every canvas.

These were the Boudreaux ancestors—men of methodical composure and women possessing the distinct, elegant beauty of her own reflection.

They entered the upper chambers—the dressing suite Kimbra had never entered. The room was filled with pungent perfume and a sharp, chemical undertone that made the hairs on her arms stand up. Three women, known only as the Artisans, stood in the center. They did not speak; they moved with the synchronized fluidity of people used to administering dangerous things.

“Commencez,” Madame Claudette commanded.

First came the bath. The water was infused with iridescent oils, turning the liquid into a shimmering, pearl-white soup. This was no cleansing, but a preparation of the body. The water was uncomfortably hot, designed to open every pore, to make her skin receptive.

The sponges were an abrasive grit, sandpaper against her raw flesh. By the time she was dry and seated in the velvet chair, her mind slipped backward to fireflies in a childhood sandbox. She searched for the memory of Damian’s laugh, but the pervasive odor from the bath rose up, washing it away.

The Artisans prepared her hair, brushing it until it shone, a uniform sheet of spun silk, their repetitive movements numbing and hypnotic. She was a doll being readied for a pageant—an exhibition she hadn’t signed up for.

The door opened with a purposeful click.

Vincent Boudreaux entered. He embodied the composure of a man who owned the very time everyone else was racing against. He stood tall at the edge of the room, his gold framed glasses catching the glow of the setting sun through the window. His hands were clasped behind his back, observing the scene with the meticulous intensity of an appraiser quantifying the value of a priceless artifact. He examined her neck, her décolletage—not as a father-in-law, but as a collector searching for a hairline fracture that might devalue the whole.

“La floraison est exceptionnelle.” His French baritone slid through the room, smooth and seductive. *The bloom is exceptional.*

“Oui, Monsieur,” Claudette bowed her head. “She is prepared. The frequency is stable.”

He stopped inches from Kimbra. The scent around him was charged—thick with cigars, old scripts, and spicy cologne. He hovered over her without touching her, measuring her temperature, checking the heat of a kiln.

“Remember your placement tonight, Kimberly.” There was no warmth in his expression, only a detached, bottomless calculation. “This house provides much—the food you eat, the clothes you wear, the luxury you enjoy—but it expects a return on its benefaction. My son is ready to step into his legacy. You must be the steady thread guiding the flow. Do not let your nerves fray the thread. The Root does not tolerate a weak graft.”

A tight knot cinched in her stomach at the mention of a returning gift. Kimbra wanted to ask what he meant by graft, but her tongue was lead. Vincent didn't wait for a response.

He turned with a sweep of his coat and exited the room, leaving a chilling draft in his wake.

“Stand,” Claudette instructed.

The Artisans approached with the finished product. It was a stunning masterpiece of silver-threaded silk, a second layer of dense weave turning her posture rigid the moment it draped over her figure. As the threads settled against her frame, the hum grew louder—a vibration deep in her bones, synchronized with the mechanical pulse of the Grandfather Clock downstairs.

The garment was hungry. It tightened of its own accord, the metal filaments warming as they drew the heat directly from her blood. *She wasn't wearing the dress; it was wearing her.*

The intricate embroidery featured floral patterns composed of threads twisted into a script of crawling vines. As the Artisans pulled the laces, her breath stalled. Each pin was tucked with surgical precision, the metal biting into her skin with a sharp click—a lock turning.

“*C'est fini.*” It was the only phrase they had spoken. They stood back to examine the way the fabric draped over her hips, checking for any minor imperfections.

Claudette approached with the mask. It was a filigreed work of art forged from the same materials as the dress—half-faced and silver. It was shaped as a blooming lily, the petals curling over her cheekbones toward her temple.

When Claudette pressed it to her face, the metal was freezing. Kimbra stared in the mirror and didn't recognize the woman staring back. She was a queen, hidden behind forged metal and the burden of a debt she couldn't name.

“The procession is set for midnight.” Claudette appeared in the mirror behind her. “Chin up, Miss Kimberly. You will be the star of this house. Remember your place. Do not fray the thread.”

Kimbra nodded, the weight of the mask pulling at her face as she stood as the Blood Lily, draped in a promise that had become her cage.

THE HARVEST

The doors to the upper gallery opened. Kimbra stepped out, her gown scraping against the floors, a low murmur filling the open space. Below, in the grand ballroom, the guests had already arrived.

They stood in disciplined rows, a mass of midnight against the bronze-leaved architecture. Every face was hidden behind a disguise. Some wore the long-beaked mask of plague doctors; others wore the porcelain visages of harlequins. They didn't speak or whisper; they simply turned as one, their hollow eye-sockets tracking her descent down the grand staircase.

At the far end of the room, the furniture had been cleared to make way for a custom-made altar. It was draped in an opaque cloth, absorbing the radiance from the chandeliers. Beside it stood Damian. He was dressed in a black suit, a threaded sash across his torso mirroring her gown. He, too, wore a mask—a smooth, obsidian piece making him a stranger.

But when their eyes met through the slits of their costume, the boy from the garden flinched. For a second, he struggled against the weight of his attire. Vincent stood behind the

altar, his glasses catching the flickering glow of the black candles. He was no longer a collector; he was a judge.

“The vessel approaches.” Vincent’s announcement was stripped of its French softness, replaced by a harsh, metallic resonance.

The guests knelt, their knees hitting the marble in a single thud. Kimbra landed on the bottom step, her heart pounding against the corset. The malice of the masked crowd pressed in on her, a collective hunger seizing the room.

She walked toward Damian. The scent of dead flowers wasn’t coming from a bouquet; it was rising from the floorboards and the walls, as if the house itself were blooming in anticipation of the blood.

“Just us,” he mouthed, his lips shaping the words without sound.

The exit was sealed off as he led her to the front of the altar. Vincent leaned forward, the patriarch directing the ritual. “As we practiced, children. Recite the *Oraison du Lis*.”

Kimbra opened her mouth, the words tasting of copper and bile. “*Mon sang est le tien, dans l'ombre et la terre.*” With her own voice, she surrendered her blood, promising it to the shadows of the earth.

Damian’s response was immediate, a reflex of their shared upbringing. “*Ton souffle est le mien, le jour comme la nuit, pour l'éternité.*” He claimed her breath by day and night for all eternity, sealing them both inside the bondage of his lineage.

“*Ce qui est noué ne sera pas défait,*” they intoned together, acknowledging the knot that could not be undone. “*Ce qui est*

greffé ne sera pas rejeté.” The graft was set; her soul was no longer hers to keep.

Her throat tightened as a tear slipped beneath the edge of her disguise. “*Je suis le réceptacle, tu es la semence.*” She was the vessel, and he was the seed, the only thing permitted to fill her.

“*Je suis la racine, tu es le ventre,*” Damian replied. *I am the Root, you are the womb*, binding her fertility to his heritage.

“*Un seul pouls, un seul destin, une seule fin,*” they finished in haunting unison. One pulse, one destiny, one end. “*Par le fruit et le sang, qu'il en soit ainsi.*” By the fruit and the blood, so be it.

The haunting figures began a low incantation in an evil tongue: *Verba du Diable*. The drone was a physical pressure, a tremor making the threads of her dress thrum—the time for promises was over; the harvest had begun.

As Kimbra drew closer, the cloth draped over the altar rippled. It was a thick, living weave of brown moss and thirsty roots, kept moist by a slow drip of blood from a rusted basin above. Embedded in the grain was a single, large indentation shaped like a hand—not human, but something with elongated, jagged claws.

Surrounding the strange print was a border of shimmering script. The letters were moving, pulsing with a bilious glare.

A jolt of horror struck her as the text revealed itself as a record. Names were written in a strange substance, hundreds of them, most crossed out with a dark, permanent stain. At the very bottom, two names were being etched by an invisible needle: Damian Boudreaux and Kimberly Woods.

The debt discussed behind the locked doors of her childhood was real, a living ledger currently feeding on the words spoken in the room.

Vincent turned toward a wrought-iron brazier. Inside, the coals burned with a low tangerine flame, sucking the oxygen from the room. Resting in the center of the heat was an instrument forged into the unmistakable shape of a lily—but the petals were inverted, and the central stamen was a sharp, protruding spike.

“The blood of the vine,” he intoned.

The guests responded in a hollow drone: *“Sang de la racine.”*

He pulled the metal from the furnace. It remained a matte texture, radiating a primordial heat. Kimbra turned to Damian, searching for the boy who had promised her security. But he was an idol in satin, exalted on the altar. *He was letting this happen.*

Madame Claudette appeared from the shadows, pulling the silk away from her left shoulder. “Steady, Miss Kimberly. Do not fray the thread.”

“What is this? What are you doing?”

The blistering metal chewed past the flesh, cauterizing the very bone.

“Argh!” Her scream tore through her lungs, the silver threads of her gown shrieked, oscillating in a dissonant, mourning hum—a tuning fork of agony vibrating inside her skull.

The pain was an unmistakable weight anchoring into her soul, forcing her to her hands and knees. The smell of burnt

flesh seeped through the ballroom, enlivening the crowd as they began a menacing hiss.

The world went white, then a static-filled gray. The moaning of the guests became a dull, underwater drone. Damian's lips were moving, but his muffled speech was a mile away, drowned by the psychic tether binding her flesh to the threads of the dress. The scent of her favored flowers now carried the revolting tang of her own burnt skin.

As the iron was pulled away, the names on the altar flared with hellfire before smoldering deep into the wood. The wound was inflamed, embossed with the charred outline of a lily—a permanent, blackened bloom throbbing with a dreadful heat.

The brand was a buried hook tethering her to the names on the altar. In a moment of agony, she glared at Damian.

He acknowledged her, but the boy from the willow tree was gone. In his eyes lay a mixture of pity and a terrible, crushing relief. The gravity keeping her from drifting into the recesses of her mind suddenly reversed, pushing her further into isolation.

He didn't reach for her. He didn't protest. He simply stood there, a prince standing over his prisoner, bound to her now not by fireflies and secrets, but by a debt written in blood.

As he watched the smoke rise from her limb, his fingers twitched against his seam, sheltering his own unmarred shoulder.

Then, from the corners of the room, the chanting began again, the dry, abrasive rattle of hissing locusts trapped in a confined space.

Through the haze of her trauma, she realized they weren't only witnessing the ritual; they were participating in it. Their vile sound traveled up through the marble, into her knees, and settled in the fresh mark, awakening the lily—a second, heart palpitating in her body.

For years, she had been a delicate flower cultivated for a collector's glass case, but the iron had burned away those precious petals. Underneath, something older and far more primal remained. It was the crash after a storm breaks—raw survival. It was the part of her heritage the Boudreaux family had tried to civilize out of her, now screaming to be unbridled.

Her crushed lungs suddenly expanded with a depth she hadn't known she possessed. The threads of her gown shrieked in protest, sensing the expansion of her flesh, but they could no longer contain the pressure.

Every compulsion that once bound her to please, to bow, or to belong was being incinerated. In its place, a shrewd awareness emerged. *The mansion was no longer a palace; it was a slaughterhouse. The guests were not elite; they were predators. And Damian was the bait.*

The anguish was no longer a burden; it was an inheritance, a righteous revolt striking down the *Verba du Diable* rising from the guests. A century of ancestral bondage buried in the dirt beneath the foundation rose at once, a collective fury funneling into her bones to demand her autonomy.

Suddenly, the roar reached its crescendo. Choice was reprobated, replaced by an evolutionary mandate. Every

nerve in her system aligned into a single command drowning out the frantic scream of her conditioning. *Run.*

BROKEN GLASS

The doors of the ballroom swung open. Kimbra didn't remember walking; she was a passenger in her own body, a broken doll steered toward the Library. Every time the silk brushed her shoulder, a fresh jolt sparked through her—a reminder that the promise Damian made was now seared in flesh and blood.

He caught her on the staircase, locking onto her wrist. “Kimmy, wait.”

She stopped, her knees shaking so violently she slammed against the balustrade for support. She turned to look at him, mascara running down her cheeks in charcoal lines.

“He branded me,” she said, her voice catching on the copper taste in her throat. “I was marked like livestock in front of everyone! They weren't watching a ceremony; they were inspecting a crop... and you just stood there and watched.”

“It was the only way.” He pushed up the mask to reveal his face. “The guests... they needed to witness the claim. In this house, visibility is the only law. But it's over now. The public part is done. We've paid the entrance fee.”

“It’s not over,” she breathed. “I can feel the altar. Even through the walls, I can feel it. It’s calling to something inside me... something that wasn’t there before.”

He cupped her face as he had hundreds of times before—at the sandbox, by the fireflies, under the willow tree. His palms were cool against the fever burning in her skin. For a second, the familiar touch almost worked, nearly quenching the anguish roaring in her blood.

“Listen to me,” he said, his voice dropping into a low register she had never heard before. “Once we go inside, once we finish this, we’ll be beyond their reach. My father won’t be able to touch you again because you’ll be mine. Legally. Metaphysically. I can’t protect a ward, Kim. The Law doesn’t allow it. But I can protect my wife. I can lock the door against everyone.”

“Is that what this is? Protection?”

“It’s the only world we have... Don’t fray the thread now, Kim. A few more minutes, and we’ll be left alone. This will all be over.”

He leaned his forehead against hers. For a moment, his fresh scent replaced the smell of burnt iron. She wanted to believe him. *She needed to believe.*

“Promise me.”

“I promise.” He tilted her head back and kissed her. It was possessive, thick with the bitterness of the ritual. She let herself dissolve into it. But as he pulled away, a flash of something remained in his gaze—not love, but a hunger. It was a need already draining her. “It’s time.”

The Library doors closed with a sharp click. Inside, the room had been cleared, the rug rolled back. In its place,

embedded into the floorboards, lay a pentagram channel-deep with liquid mercury.

At the center of the star, a translucent script was written: *The sins of the father are a debt.* Vincent stood by the fireplace. “Stand at the points.”

As their feet stepped into the quicksilver grooves, the liquid metal pulsed against her limbs, freezing and toxic. Then the siphoning began—a slow, excruciating depravation. A thousand invisible needles piercing through her brand, pulling the warmth from her blood. The pentagram began to glow a bold maroon.

Damian’s eyes began to change, his pupils dilated into a dismal black. Kimbra’s breath flattened as the carved geometry actively claimed the oxygen from her lungs. The threads of her gown hummed, turning into live conductors.

His physique expanded, his pigment flushing with an unnatural, stolen vitality. He was thriving on her depletion, drawing the very life out of her veins.

Vincent stepped into the circle, passing his son a sharp onyx blade. Damian stood perfectly still, his lips a bewitching red. He was no longer her companion; he was a temple being prepared for a god of the pit.

Tears ran down her face. “Damian, please...” The words were faint, scraped from the back of a dry throat as her vision blurred at the edges. “...Don’t do it.”

His movements were jerky, like a marionette. He held the blade, its hilt crafted from bone. “*It’s the only way we stay together, Kimberly.*” The statement resonated with an overlapping echo—a legion hijacking his throat. Then, his true, desperate tone broke through. “Don’t resist me. Accept

the binding, or I will have nowhere to anchor. Please, Kimmy... I'll drift into the pit alone."

"Enough sentiment!" Vincent grabbed Kimbra's hair and forced her head back. "The Root does not beg. It commands!"

He snatched the blade, carving a psychic siphon into her wound.

"Argh!" She searched Damian's eyes for any remnant of the boy from the garden, but a predatory void had replaced it.

"With this stroke, the Boudreaux line claims the vessel. What she breathes, the Entity tastes. What she feels, the Entity consumes. She is the hearth, and my son is the flame."

He forced the tip into her. A vine of energy burst from the wound, wrapping itself around her arm and lashing onto Damian's torso. A sickening vacuum took hold.

The edges of her mind began to disappear. She tried to conjure the sunny afternoon under the willow tree, but the image was blotted out. The memory of his protection was warped as his true essence was reeled through the tether, swallowed by the thing growing inside him.

All of her emotions, her very will began to pour into Damian. A look of ecstatic relief crossed his features as he gorged on who she was. He was thriving on her erasure, fed by her slow death.

"Look at her! She is your life now. Without her, you are nothing. With her, you are a god!"

As Vincent turned to pour the ritual wine, the bond tweaked. The agony gave her a burst of adrenaline—a primal rejection of the theft. She didn't think; she didn't pray.

She simply threw herself through the floor-to-ceiling window behind her.

“Kimbra, no!”

The kaleidoscope fractured. Shards of amethyst and jade sheared through her bodice, slicing through layers of tissue as she breached the frame. For a frozen moment, she was weightless—and then it turned into a crushing blue as she hit the water below in a violent splash.

Submerged, the world was a silent, distorted blur. She glanced at the jagged hole in the window, a toothy maw of glass glowing with the unnatural flare of the ritual. The threads, so meticulously woven by the Artisans, reacted to the fluid with a cruel, tightening reflex. They shrank against her ribs like a closing fist, a cage designed to crush her breath and pin her to the bottom of the pool.

She kicked desperately, the lily sizzling beneath the water. She clawed to the surface, gasping for air. The masked figures peered down—gargoyles perched against the night.

One of them pointed straight down at her. “There!”

Kimbra swam to the concrete ledge and scrambled onto the deck. She kicked off her heels, and tore up the hem of her dress to free her legs, and bolted. She was no longer a ward, and certainly no one’s bride.

She sprinted across the lawn. Behind her, the baying of hounds began—the hunt had transitioned from recovery to slaughter.

The tree line loomed. As she hit the mud, the brand throbbed—a deadly root pulling her back toward Damian. She bit her lip until it bled, dragging her ruined dress through the muck.

She wasn't only escaping a house. She was shattering a destiny.

A WINTER STORM IN SPRING

The toll hit her the moment her feet struck the dirt. The hole in her chest ached with the devastation of a physical wound, but nothing carved deeper than Damian's betrayal. Her shoulder burned, a localized furnace tracking her coordinates through the mud.

Keep moving. Don't look back.

The fibers of the ruined gown, sodden from the slough, contracted against her skin. The metallic cage of a dress tightened around her ribs with every wet stride. Every breath fought the vacuum he had bored into her sternum. She tried to retrieve the memories of her childhood, but the siphon had left those images blurry and dull. The theft was evident—she was a house looted, the rooms of her mind ransacked.

The swamp didn't judge her emptiness. *Stay hidden*, it whispered. *Stay wild*. The shrubs tore at her gown—the garment meant to immortalize her bondage—and for every inch of cloth lost to the mire, a spark of her own resolve returned.

As her strength began to fail, a subterranean quake pulsed beneath the soil—the life force of the earth itself, fierce and

protective. She followed it, crawling over rotting logs and briars scourging her skin.

Through the thicket, a flame appeared: a glistening, warm butterscotch. Above the tree line, the indented spires of a Marian statue rose—a silent sentinel harboring the twilight. There, amid her nightmare, was a fortress of rock and perpetual prayers—the only place where the Boudreaux name held no power.

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The humidity clung to the stone walls of Our Lady of Tears Academy like a wet shroud—a curtain of salt-marsh. But as the sentry paced the lower terrace, the climatic pressure began to warp. It turned crisp, biting at his lungs with a dry, alpine chill that had no business in a Louisiana spring.

Roman adjusted the rough-spun wool of his robes. He carried himself with the understated sophistication of his lineage—the De la Croix line, high society who had traded decadence for obedience. But even his cultivated composure faltered as the first white speck drifted past his vision.

Then another.

The flakes settled onto the nearby palmetto fronds, a stark, crystalline white against the deep tropical green. They dusted the ancient stone balustrade, freezing the damp moss on contact until it grew brittle.

“Snow?” His breath bloomed into a cloud of vapor.

Roman held out a hand. A flake landed on his palm, perfectly formed and impossibly frigid. It didn't melt; it sat there—a serrated diamond. His jaw tightened. *This wasn't weather.* It was a localized trauma of the elements, swirling in a peculiar vortex around the entrance.

He held his breath as another disturbance cut through—a desperate, wet rasp. Someone was wheezing for air. He spun toward the gate, fumbling with the rusted key at his belt.

A figure staggered out of the abyss of cypress.

He had been trained to brave the horrific, but the girl he encountered was a bloodied catastrophe.

“H-help!”

She collapsed against the steel bars. Her ghastly outfit was a combination of blood, wet mud and wire. *He had turned his back on the last one.* The memory flared in his mind—the limousine door shutting, the social currency bought with his silence. *Not again.* That girl had died. The boy he used to be had died with her, buried under a mountain of family secrets. It was the guilt that had ultimately driven him to this reform school, trading his bespoke suits for cheap wool.

The snow was a second chance—a frost of mercy falling from the overcast. He wouldn't turn his back this time. He couldn't. His robes chafed against his skin, a constant reminder of the penance he had chosen. As he grabbed the key on his belt, the shadow of his past met the reality of his present.

“Hang on!”

His fingers were numb from the unnatural frost as he threw the bolt. The gate groaned open and the girl fell forward. He caught her, his muscular arms steadying her

battered frame. As he pulled her into the courtyard, the reality set in that she was not only bleeding. *She was burning.*

A searing heat radiated from her, so intense it was charring the oxygen between them. Roman brushed the torn silk of her sleeve, and a jolt passed from her body into his—a void trying to suction the life out of him.

His blood ran colder than the frost. Through the shredded fabric, the gruesome mark revealed itself, weeping a fluid so toxic it hissed against the fresh snow, staining the slush an unholy purple.

He didn't know what it was. He only knew the shards of metal in her gown were scratching against his robes, almost ripping through them.

“I got you!” He gathered her into his arms without looking back at the swamp or the flurry. He sprinted toward the spires of the infirmary, his boots crunching through the ice as the girl leaned against his chest.

Kimbra’s head rolled toward the midnight sky. “S-safe?”

The girl was a dying stranger in his arms. He didn't answer her. He couldn't. He gripped her body tighter, crossing the threshold of the entrance as the impossible snow outside faded into the darkness.

THE VAULT

Roman didn't wait for the infirmary doors to open. He drove his boot into the center seam, the metal slamming against the walls with a violence that rattled the rafters. The ward was filled with antiseptic, bitter herbs, and the stinging bite of ammonia.

"I need a medic!" His muscles screamed under the weight of the girl's shriveled gown. He laid her down, and the sterile sheets were instantly soaked with streaks of brackish blood.

Sister Marta arrived amidst the shadows of the apothecary wall. She wore the habit of a nun, but she stood there as a battlefield surgeon. Her sleeves were rolled up, revealing forearms corded with muscle, her eyes magnified behind thick bifocals—sharp as the scalpels she kept immersed in sanitizing alcohol. She took one look at the girl's waxen face—the blue tint of her lips and the shallow rise of her chest—and moved with urgency.

"She's in hypovolemic shock! Cut those laces. Now! They're acting as a tourniquet for the infestation, not the blood."

He fumbled for the spotless shears on the tray. His hands, usually steady with a pen or a razor, trembled as he sliced

through the ruined garment. Every time the blades sheared through the fibers, a violent spark jumped with an electric snap, stinging his fingers.

“She’s losing too much blood!” The pool of red widened across the table before him. “The wound... it isn’t clotting, Sister. It’s seeping.”

“It won’t clot while the link is active.” Father Manuel appeared from the corridor. He studied the brand. The lily morphed into a deep cavity, suctioning the heat out of the room. “The blood isn’t coagulating. It’s being pulled. Somewhere beyond our gates, a predator is attempting to feed through a hidden door.”

Sister Marta ignored the talk of predators. She ripped open a bottle of saline solution and began swabbing the wound with a mixture of alcohol and hyssop. “I don’t care about the theology, Father. If I can’t find a vein and close this arterial bleeding, she’ll be a ghost before you can finish your prayer. Pin her down, Roman. The moment the silver nitrate touches that mark, her nerves are going to fray. If she thrashes, I’ll nick the carotid.”

He restrained her pale forehead and her hips. “Do it.” He felt the pounding of her heart—a chaotic, misfiring trigger against her ribs. Sister Marta strapped down the girl’s wrist, then took a scoop of coarse, gray crystals and slammed them directly onto the weeping lily.

The reaction was instantaneous. The crystals hissed, smoking against the tissue. The girl’s spine arched with a bone-snapping force. A guttural, inhuman screech tore from her throat and for a split second, the frost flared back to life, coating the surgical trays in a layer of rime. He leaned his full

weight into her, his arms locked. He felt the tether—the sickening pull trying to siphon itself into his own veins.

“Steady, girl. Stay on this side. Stay with me.”

Sister Marta was a blur of motion, stitching flesh that didn't want to be knit, her needle flashing in the fluorescent lighting. “Pressure! Apply pressure to the packing!”

As he pressed a thick wad of gauze into the wound, the blood soaked through the cotton instantly, turning his palms a rich scarlet. It was the first time he had felt her warmth—the first sign there was still a life left to save.

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The ward was reduced to the precise snip of surgical thread and the artificial chirp of the EKG monitor. Sister Marta stepped back, stripping off her blood-smeared latex gloves with a sharp snap. She wiped a smudge of bright fluid from her forehead with her forearm, her face set in a grim line.

She adjusted the line of the drip. “The bleeding stopped.” She stepped back, checking the flow of the saline. “But that... thing on her shoulder. It’s defying everything I know about cellular repair. The tissue is necrotizing and regenerating at the same time. It’s a biological paradox.”

The priest approached the patient, picking up a shard of her gown with a pair of surgical tongs. The metal thread hummed with a dissonant, low-grade pitch before turning a dull, leaden gray.

“Someone has invested a significant amount of resources to craft this.” The priest set the tongs down. He turned to the young man. “You felt it, didn't you? The pull?”

He flexed his fingers, testing the blood drying and tightening into a second, unwanted layer of skin. “It sure did feel like a hunger, Father. Not hers. Something reaching through her.”

Father Manuel studied the exposed mark once more. “It appears to be a siphon... or an anchor; perhaps both. This wasn't a random attack. It's... ancient ritualism. Whoever marked this girl didn't want to kill her; they wanted to claim her. They've turned her into a conduit for something that hasn't been completed.”

“Do you know who they are?”

“No.” The priest's brows furrowed. “But they are powerful and nearby. To maintain a link this strong, the source must be within a thirty-mile radius. By bringing her here, you've severed a circuit that was meant to be permanent. Whatever—or whoever—is on the other end of that line just felt the door slam shut.”

There was a sudden creaking sound, but no footsteps followed. Instead, the rhythmic tap-slide, tap-slide of a cane announced the arrival of Sister Alba. She stopped at the edge of the room, her opalescent, unseeing gaze settled on a point between them.

“The frequency is dissonant.” She stopped just inside the threshold, her voice cutting through the sterile room like the frost on the surgical trays. “It isn't a mark, Father. It's a “*Droit de Greffe*”—a *Right of Graft*.” They attempted to rewrite her very nature to serve the Root.”

Roman watched her cane vibrate. He felt the tremor in his own marrow. “The Root?”

“You know this mark, Sister?”

“Yes, Father. It’s part of an occult ritual. We have some recorded history with this particular coven in the archives; I will brief you later.”

She turned towards the boy. “Can you hear it, De la Croix? The *Sanguine Law* is a greedy mechanism. It hates being interrupted. The girl is a refractory limb now. To the author of this sacrilege, she is gangrene which must be cut away or reclaimed.”

The heat circulating from the Lily had subsided, replaced by the natural, cool dampness of a survivor in recovery. The priest placed a hand on Roman’s back. “Go. Wash. Sister Marta will finish the dressings. The immediate danger of her bleeding out is over. We need to find out who she is before they come looking.”

He didn't want to move. He watched the girl—now cleaned of the muddy grime, her hair fanned out against the pillow. She was no longer a scene from a horror movie, but a poor girl used and discarded as a ritual tool.

“With all due respect, Father, I’ll stay until she wakes.” He dragged a heavy chair to the bedside, the legs scraping loudly against the flagstones. The movement left no room for pastoral correction.

Father Manuel watched him for a long moment, noting how his attention never left her face. “Then keep your eyes on the monitor. If her vitals spike without a physical cause, it means the source is trying to find a way back in.”

He nodded, settling into the chair. He watched the steady rise and fall of her chest, hoping and praying that the girl on the table would survive.

JUST US

The hours spanned by in a blue glare and the periodic hiss-click of the specialized ventilator Sister Marta had set up. Roman hadn't moved. The dried blood began to flake, dusting his robes like rust.

Outside, the blizzard subsided and the snow melted, leaving the wetlands in a state of disordered, dripping humidity. Inside the Vault, the room remained unnervingly still until 3:00 AM, when the noise from the monitor began to change.

The shift was a subtle acceleration, a pitter-patter against the silence. He hovered inches from Kimbra's face. "Hey?"

Her eyelids fluttered, thin and translucent, showing the restless movement beneath. A low moan vibrated in her throat—a mournful yearning.

Then, she snapped awake.

Her pupils were blown wide, but Roman caught a glimpse of the abyssal black he had witnessed at the gate. She didn't see him. She was looking through him, past the stone—toward...

"Damian?"

The name was a plea and a curse all at once.

She tried to bolt upright, but the movement triggered the brand. The monitor let out a sharp alarm as she threw herself into tachycardia.

He threw his weight forward to keep her pinned to the bed. “Stay down! You're safe. You're in the Infirmary.”

Kimbra's focus shifted to the man sitting in the corner. She didn't see a savior; she saw a stranger covered in her own blood. A ragged scream tore from her throat, cutting through the room as her fingers clawed at his arms. “Don't touch me! The thread—he's pulling the thread!”

He felt it. The mark flared with a sudden, violet blaze, and the temperature in the room plummeted. His own skin began to crawl, pricked by a thousand invisible needles trying to jump from her body to his.

He didn't pull away. He gripped her tighter, securing her to the bed and the physical world. “He can't reach you here. Look at me! It's just us. No one else is here!”

Once Kimbra heard those haunting words—Just Us—her eyes rolled back into her head. The pain of the betrayal, the horrifying events—it was another shock to her system as she drifted into an unconscious state. The EKG, which had been shrieking in a sustained panic, gradually resumed its basic chirp.

He remained hunched over her, still pinning her downward. He was breathing as hard as she had been, the phantom sensation of needles still prickling him. He stared at the girl—now limp, her head lolling to the side, her face twisted with an unspoken grief even in sleep.

“I didn't mean...” His defenses failed, exposing him to the emptiness of the room.

He examined his palms—the rust-colored flakes of her blood disappeared, replaced by a purple shimmer fading into his pores.

Sister Marta burst into the room, Father Manuel trailing behind her. She went straight for the IV line to check the sedation levels, moving with clinical precision to re-secure the dressings. “What happened? The alarm triggered on the main board. Did she code?”

He stood up quickly, the chair legs emitting a single, harsh scrape against the floor. “She woke up. She was terrified. I tried to calm her—I told her no one else was here. I said it was just us, and she...”

Father Manuel’s concern hardened into an intellectual dread as he looked from the young man to the unconscious girl. “*Just us?* You may have unintentionally used a trigger phrase. In a parasitic bond, certain words act as tethers. You probably mirrored the language of her oppressor. You didn’t merely tell her she was safe; you told her the predator was still in the room.”

He felt a spear pierce into his gut—the blood he had felt obligated to carry now felt like a mark of his own failure.

“She won’t wake again for some time,” Sister Marta reassured him, noting Roman’s distress. “Her vitals are stable, but the psychic shock has forced a mental reset. We need to move her.”

“To where?”

“The North Campus,” Father Manuel replied. “The old tower. The walls are thicker, lined with a salt-fused mortar. If the thread she mentioned is still pulling, we need more than a rite to snap it. And Roman?”

“Yes, Father?”

“Go wash. Properly this time. Her blood is not something you want to let soak in. It contains more than hemoglobin; it carries the scent of the hunt.”

+ + +

Roman walked to the water basin in the corner of the anteroom, his legs turned to lead. He turned the brass tap, and the liquid hit the sink with a hard splash.

He scrubbed. He used the abrasive lye soap until his skin was raw, but he couldn't drown out her screaming. He heard the way his voice—the one he had intended for comfort—acted as a prison door slamming shut.

Just us.

He thought of his former life, the debauchery of the De la Croix parties where those words meant the elite, the untouched, were the ones who could turn their backs on the suffering. He had come to the Academy to be a shield, to atone for the girl he hadn't saved, but tonight he was no protector; he was a bridge for the enemy.

He watched the water turn murky as it swirled down the drain, wondering if he would ever be clean of the old blood on his hands.

“You're scrubbing but the blemish isn't on the surface.”

Ignatius Santiago stepped out from the hidden crevice of the archway, holding only a small, leather-bound book and a

fresh, dry towel. He moved with a measured pace, a fluid gait that neutralized the static in the corridor.

His eyes were a knowing amber, possessed with a genuine kindness. He didn't scrutinize Roman with the keen judgment of the faculty, but with the shared understanding of a brother-in-arms.

"She was marked, Iggy." His head remained bowed, his voice a low rasp. "I felt the void. It tried to siphon the air from my lungs."

Ignatius placed the towel on the edge of the basin and stood beside him. His presence was an immediate counter to the pressurized heat of the vault—a calm, cooling influence.

"I saw the monitors from the perimeter. It was a violent discharge, but listen to me." Ignatius locked his attention onto his friend. "A Shield fractured by pity cannot guard anyone. You are looking at her through the haze of your own penance, but she is a living soul in the middle of a war. If you want to help her, you have to be the mountain, not the dust."

Ignatius shut off the brass tap. "Go. Clean yourself off. I'll stay here with the Rector. We need to watch the gates, not the ghosts."

THE FALL OUT

The Boudreaux manor was crumbling. Without the hearth, the grand halls had surrendered to a biting cold, reeking of stagnant water and old ash. In the master study, the fire in the furnace had turned a guttering grey.

Vincent stood by the window, his lens reflected in the moonlight. He watched the trees, tracking the way the branches recoiled from the house as if sensing the dead space within. Behind him, labored, uneven breathing occupied the room.

Damian was collapsed in the armchair, his suit rumpled, his mask cast aside on the floor—a piece of refuse. His complexion, once vibrant with the life-force he had siphoned from Kimbra, was now a feverish white. Repulsive veins traced across his neck, pulsing with a faint shimmer.

“I can’t... I can’t feel her.” He clutched his sternum, right where the spiritual vine had lashed onto him during the ritual. It was bruised—a necrotic purple throbbing in time with his failing heart. “The wire is a ghost, Father. The broadcast is dead. It’s as if she vanished from the earth.”

Vincent kept his eyes fixed on the horizon, his expression as cold as a gravestone. “She hasn’t vanished. She has been shielded. Someone has dropped a veil over her signature—one dense enough to kill the resonance. We are blind... for now.”

Damian let out a strangled cry, his fingers digging into the cushion of the chair. The withdrawal was a physical torture—a psychic famine. He had been fed on her peace, her memories, and her warmth for so long that his own soul had become an empty nest.

“We need to find her... You said I would be a god, but I’m starving.”

It was a hunger with no bottom. For ten years, Damian hadn’t felt the true burden of his wicked heritage because Kimbra had carried it for him. She had been the filter through which his distorted edges were smoothed, turning his father’s overbearing demands into something he could tolerate.

He tried to reach for the memory of the willow tree—the way the sun had glistened as he sat beside her—but it was a distant fantasy. He could see the emerald luster and the drooping branches, but the feeling was gone, reduced to a film of someone else’s life—a flat, colorless projection.

The Sanguine Law was a cruel accountant. He had spent his adolescence siphoning her essence to stabilize his own soul—every breath was a theft of oxygen; now that the connection was split, the deficit was consuming him. Without her frequency to anchor him, the Old Growth of his ancestral line was turning inward. He felt his own blood thickening,

becoming sluggish and congealed, as if his veins were filling with the very filth of the swamp.

His mind fractured; shadows at the edge of his vision twisted into reaching vines, while a thousand locusts screamed in a language he almost understood. He was losing more than a girl; he was shedding the last of his humanity. Without her, he stood as a shell in a suit, a broken prince with no crown.

Vincent turned, looking at his son with the disappointment of a craftsman evaluating a failed machine. He walked toward a lacquered table where a topographical map of New Orleans lay spread out. Beside it sat a bowl filled with viscous fluid.

“If the tether doesn't reconnect soon, the siphoning will reverse.” He dipped a finger into the liquid, tracing a strange, geometric sigil across the parchment. “The asset is too valuable to lose, and your stability is already compromised. You are at the peak age of your Ascension—the final threshold, son. Fail to reestablish the connection within this lunar cycle, and the collapse of the Boudreaux dynasty begins with you.”

The solution etched itself into the paper, simmering with a low rumbling as it rose in an oily mist.

“We cannot see her, but we can follow the tremors she left behind.” Vincent inhaled the vapor. “A concealment that effective has only one source. It is a bunker, not a home. Somewhere with enough salt and stone to quell a god’s appetite.”

Damian struggled to stand, his legs shaking. “Let me go. I’ll search every inch of the mud until I find her.”

Vincent spun around. “You can barely breathe, boy! You wouldn't make it to the back door. We don't search. We broadcast. If we cannot reach her through the tether, we will spike the line. We will make the frequency of the lily so loud she'll scream her coordinates to the sky.”

He walked to the dusted bookshelves and pulled down an iron-bound volume—the *Livre de la Racine*, the ledger of every graft and debt owed to their family for three centuries. He flipped through the vellum pages until he found the entry for Woods, Kimberly. “She is a Boudreaux asset, groomed for one purpose. Whoever is protecting her might think they can hide her, but they have only invited a live wire into their house. It is written in the *L'Exil du Réfractaire*.”

The ink beneath his fingertips transformed into a dismal violet.

“But the girl is more than an asset.” Vincent's fingers traced the ancient text. “She is the conductor. Without her, the walls of this house will turn inward. The trees will stop guarding our borders. The mud will vomit our secrets. If we do not reclaim her, the Root will consume its own heir.”

Damian glanced at the book, the glowing letters reflecting in his bloodshot pupils. He could feel the conduit spasming, a phantom limb reaching for a ghost.

Vincent read directly from the page. “*He who cuts the vine shall bleed until the swamp water runs red. A fool attempting to sever the Sanguine Tether is a limb in gangrene; it must be reclaimed by force or consumed by the very vine it sought to escape.*”

He looked up from the diabolic script. “Therefore, we pulse the line until their shield breaks—or she incinerates their sanctuary.”

THE NORTH TOWER

A man-made canal of concentrated brine circled the outer edges of St. Benedict Tower. This served as the first level of defense—the moat of tears disrupting the earth-bound frequencies of the cursed land. Beyond the water lay the North Campus quad, a desolation of gray clouds and weeping moss.

The Garden District and the De la Croix estate were another life—all sweeping oaks and gas-lit wrought iron. His mother would've trashed this place as a tomb; his father would've seen nothing but a blown inheritance. But here, the Shields held the line.

Roman sat in the corner of Kimbra's room. The adrenaline coursing through him had diminished into a weary, protective alertness. He had washed away every remnant of blood and changed into a fresh uniform.

The North Tower was a fortress removed from the main campus. It housed the Exceptions—those whose burdens were too volatile for a standard classroom. Here the walls were sanctified, designed specifically to stifle the frequencies Vincent Boudreaux was currently trying to broadcast.

The purple shimmer had vanished from his palms, leaving his limbs dense and leaden.

“You're waiting for the other shoe to drop.”

He didn't turn toward the doorway. He already knew Father Manuel's tread.

“The atmosphere changed ten minutes ago, Father. The room felt... pressurized. Like a storm trying to break through the ceiling.”

“That's the broadcast from the other end.” Father Manuel stepped into the room and walked to the bedside, inspecting the IV catheter Sister Marta had established. “The source is scanning our perimeter. They're trying to force a reconnection by spiking the brand. If we weren't in the North Tower, she would have been a glowing beacon.”

Kimbra was serene in her reset coma, unaware she was the focal point of a supernatural search party.

“How long until they infiltrate our defenses?” Roman asked.

“It is not a permanent solution. The river stream surrounding us is a barrier, not a cure. Eventually, the seeker will find a crack. Our only hope is to wake her and have her agree to the Rite of Severance.”

He noted the way the young man's hand rested near her pale fingers. “You told me you felt it at the gate. The vacuum. If they spike that frequency while you're touching her, you won't be a shield to protect her, Roman. You'll be a lightning rod.”

The EKG emitted a single beep.

Kimbra twitched. Her fingers curled, scratching at the white linen sheets.

“She's coming up.” He stood so quickly his chair nearly toppled over.

This time, there were no screams. Her eyes opened slowly. They weren't bloodshot or subdued with the horror of the ritual; they were a clear, pained greenish-brown. She stared at the ceiling for a brief moment, her breathing shallow and steady, before her attention drifted to the IV bag and the plastic tubing disappearing into her arm.

She turned her head. She recognized him—the young man from the gate. The one who had held her fragile body in the snow. He appeared different now, his student uniform crisp and his posture taut.

“Hey... What’s your name?” He kept a respectful distance, allowing her space to breathe against the thickening tension.

Her throat felt as if it were filled with gravel. She tried to speak, but only a dry rasp escaped. “Kimberly... Kimbra Woods... Where am I?”

“Kimbra,” he repeated, cataloging the name within the blank spaces of his memory. “I’m Roman De la Croix. You’re at Our Lady of Tears Academy, in the St. Benedict Tower. You’re safe here.”

She closed her eyes, but the respite brought no relief. She could still feel it—a painful thrumming in the tissue of her arm. It was a distant call from the bottom of a well.

“I can hear it,” she winced. “It’s a repetitive noise inside my head, calling for me to come back.”

Father Manuel moved towards the foot of the bed. “That is the signal, Miss Woods. Someone is pulsing from the other end of the tether, trying to find the frequency of that mark in your arm. The tower is quelling the signal, but as you wake, your mind is inadvertently searching for the familiar.”

“I want it to stop,” she pleaded, her fingers curling into the sheets. “How do we make it stop?”

She tried to push herself up, but the movement sent a jolt of agony through her marrow. The monitor spiked—a chirp-chirp-chirp filling the room.

“You don’t.” Roman placed a firm hand on the edge of the plinth. “Not yet. You’ve lost a massive amount of blood, Kimbra. Your body is in shock. If we try to sever a spiritual tether while your vitals are this low, the recoil will kill you.”

“But the sound—”

“Is a ghost for now.” Father Manuel gave the boy a slight nod. “We have fortified these walls with consecrated elements and sacramental protections. The signal can’t reach you if you rest. Your only job right now is to recover.”

Sister Marta returned, already checking the site of the IV. “He’s right. You’re running on fumes and adrenaline, my dear child. I’m increasing your sedative. Father Manuel will discuss the path forward once your hemoglobin levels aren’t at a lethal low.”

Kimbra looked to Roman in desperation. “And you? Will you stay with me?”

He pulled the chair back to her bedside. “I’m not going anywhere. I’ll be here when you wake up.”

As the sedative began to pull her under, Kimbra’s grip on the sheets loosened.

The last thing she saw was the young man’s silhouette—a loyal sentry watching over her.

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The serenity of the Tower returned, disrupted only by the low, digital hum of the medical devices. Roman watched her breathing level out into a tranquil, drug-induced sleep.

Father Manuel stood at the window, scanning the darkened campus below. “She is stronger than she looks. Most would have been consumed by a siphoning of this magnitude.”

“She was terrified,” Roman said softly. “But she didn't give up. She purposely plunged herself into danger. That’s a total rejection of whatever they were trying to do to her.”

Father Manuel turned, his expression severe. “Whoever they are, they won’t accept the rejection. To them, she isn't a person; she’s a stolen portal. They will keep pulsing the line until they find a weakness in our walls. You need to sleep. If you are to be her ground during the Rite of Severance, your own spirit must be iron-clad.”

“I'll sleep here,” he replied, leaning back in the chair.

Father Manuel nodded, knowing better than to argue with a De la Croix once his mind was set. “Very well. But remember what Sister Marta said. This isn't about the Rite. When she wakes, she will be a girl with a cursed past and a hunted future. You are the first person she has seen who didn't demand something from her. Be careful with that power.”

The door clicked shut as he exited.

Roman remained alone in the blue-tinted night. His palm hovered above her fingers clutched on the white linen, grounding the room against the broadcast screaming in the night. “Rest, Kimbra. I won’t let anything happen to you,” he whispered. “*St. Michael, defend us.*”

QUILT & OLD RITUALS

The morning sun pierced St. Benedict Tower, the deep stone embrasures slicing its rays into geometric bars across the bare floor. The noise from the monitors had been replaced by the cadenced tolling of a sturdy bronze bell.

Kimbra awakened to its chimes. The hard gongs drowned the unsettling shrieking in the back of her mind. She turned her head slowly; the movement was no longer a torment, but a dull ache. The man was still there, brilliant in the sunlight—a true stoic.

He appeared different from how he had in the shadows at the gate; he now wore the school's student uniform—a charcoal-gray jacket buttoned to the throat, the fabric stiff and utilitarian. "You're awake." He didn't approach her immediately, giving her a moment to acclimate herself to the new surroundings.

"The bell." She winced. "It's so loud."

"It's the only thing that stays the same here." He met her gaze. His eyes were bloodshot from the vigil, the subtle poise of the De la Croix ancestry stripped by human exhaustion. "It's meant to remind us that time belongs to the Creator, not to our ghosts."

He brought over a cup of water from the side table. He sat on the edge of the bed, moving with a practiced, chaste caution, propping her neck to support her head as he held the glass to her lips.

Kimbra froze.

His skin was cool, carrying only a hint of lye soap. This was the first time a male had touched her without the intent to harvest something.

She took a slow sip.

The gap between them was filled with the static of the broadcast, persistent in its attempt to find a breach in the fortress walls.

For a moment, she forgot the manor—and with it, the gown and the foul taste of the ritual. Her world narrowed to the steady beat of his heart, which she could feel through his proximity. He was solid, a stark contrast to Damian's ephemeral presence. Where Damian was a shadow moving with the wind, this young man was the mountain standing against it. Roman was statuesque, his raven hair contouring a face with the timeless depth of a chiseled Greek masterpiece—glorious and triumphant.

As she drank from the glass, his fingers brushed behind her ear. A shiver that had nothing to do with the cold raced down her spine. It was a tender sensation—the realization that her body, which had been used as a tool, was still capable of a human response.

She noticed the gold cross on his lapel and wondered if the Academy's God knew her soul was drawn to the man holding the water, not the prayers on the wall.

“Why?” she asked, the water loosening the knot in her throat. “At the gate... you didn't know me. You saw the blood. Why didn't you just leave me there?”

He lowered the cup, his thumb brushing her hairline at her temple for a moment longer than necessary before he withdrew his hand entirely. His gaze fixed on the colored bars reflecting off the mirror. A shadow crossed his face—not of fear, but a hidden remorse.

“In this place, we don't wait for reasons,” he said. “We look for duty. You were at the gate. I was the one behind it. That is the only reason that matters.”

Kimbra watched him. She could feel the wall he had just slammed into place. This was the guardedness of a man with a secret. She sensed the hollow space in his words, a delicate history he was choosing to omit.

“I have a feeling you're not telling me everything...There's more.”

He stood up, smoothing the front of his jacket, the cross glinting like a warning. “There's always more. But right now, your survival is the priority. My past won't keep the thread from pulling you back to the swamp; only your strength will.”

The door screeched open before she could press him further.

Sister Alba walked across the threshold. She didn't use her cane to feel the floor; she moved with a noetic certainty.

“The room smells of guilt and old rituals.” She remained fixed on the exact space where Kimbra's heart was hammering against her ribs. “And the girl's pulse is far too loud. Are we nurturing a soldier, or a liability?”

“She's recovering, Sister.” He straightened his stance into a rigid deference.

The nun stopped exactly three feet from the bed. She tilted her head, the bejeweled cane vibrated as it detected the lingering frequency of the brand. “Do not look for pity in me, child. I am here to see if you are worth the salt we used to save you.”

She aimed her blind gaze at the girl. “This is not a hospital. We do not heal the sick; we forge them. You are being evaluated for a place in the Lord's Army, where we turn the damned into Saints for Jesus Christ. If you cannot be of service to the Almighty, you are nothing but a beacon for the adversary. And we do not keep beacons.”

Kimbra looked from the terrifying, blind nun to Roman. The brief intimacy she had felt only seconds ago was eclipsed by a harsh, militant reality.

“Saints?” She looked back at the nun. “I don't... I don't know how to be holy.”

“You are a broken thing; holiness is not a skill to be mastered,” Sister Alba snapped, the tip of her cane frosted with a chilling rime. “The Lord must sanctify you to become His instrument, or you'll be consumed by the very evil you carry. Roman, take her to the quad when she can walk. Let her see the price of the uniform.”

He didn't look back as he went ahead to open the door for the Sister, but he remained tense; his posture was of a man guarding a treasure he hadn't asked for.

Kimbra watched the blind nun exit the room. She could feel the wild roar in her blood settling into a low, expectant thrum. The institution didn't want to heal her; it wanted to

weaponize her. Beyond the door lay the North Campus quad, where cursed children were forged for a holy war.

She had no idea what horrors awaited her, but she was willing to endure it—if only to stay in the orbit of the man who had pulled her from the mud.

THE VIRTUE OF SILENCE

After Sister Alba's departure, the air in the tower felt as if the nun had sucked the room's warmth into the folds of her habit. Roman stood by the window, his back a monolith of gray wool, watching the students' shadows scurry across the quad below.

"Can you stand?"

"I think so," though her legs felt hollowed out, the bone too heavy for her muscles to lift.

She pulled back the starch linen sheets. For the first time, she saw what she was wearing—a simple, white shift, clinical and devoid of the dress that had been her cage. It felt thin. *Too thin.*

He pulled out a fleece sweater from the wardrobe and laid it at the foot of the bed with a soft, careful touch. "Put this on. The halls are freezing, and silence is the rule once we leave this room."

He turned back toward the window to give her privacy.

"Why does she call it the Lord's Army?" Her fingers fumbled with the coarse fabric. "I thought this was a school."

"It is." He moved to the opposite end of the room. "But we aren't here to study the world. We're here to deny it. The Academy doesn't train people to fight with steel. We're

trained to be soldiers for Christ through the discipline of the soul. We fight the things in the dark with prayer and penance.”

He waited by the door. When she stood on her feet, her head swam, and the wire in her shoulder gave a warning thrum, making her vision blurry. She stumbled, her knees buckling, but Roman caught her before she hit the floor, pulling her into his chest.

The effect was immediate and overwhelming. With his contact, the needle screeching of the brand became inaudible.

He was a cool lake, and she was a live wire plunged into its depths. An emanating warmth spread from his palms through her entire body—a *resonance of recognition*.

She gasped, instinctively clutching his jacket. With their faces inches apart, she saw the shock mirrored in his eyes. He felt it, too—a tethering of their breaths, a sudden peace neither of them expected.

“Steady.” He didn't pull away. Instead, he let her lean into him for a second longer than the school's rules would ever allow. His thumb traced a slow, unconscious circle on her arm, and she felt the absence inside her soul fill with his sheltering grace.

“You're shielding me. When you touch me... the static goes away.”

The veneer of the disciplined upperclassman fractured for a fleeting second. His gaze lingered on her lips before he caught himself. He cleared his throat, slowly easing her back until she was standing on her own, though he didn't fully let

go until he was sure she wouldn't collapse. "We need to make sure the inward door stays locked."

The distance between them snapped back into place, leaving the room charged with a shared pulse. "Come. You can see what you're being forged for, then decide for yourself."

+ + +

Roman led Kimbra out of the Tower and into the corridors of the North Campus. A quiet so profound entombed the hallway, leaving only the phantom shuffle of felt-soled shoes on concrete. As they walked onto the balcony overlooking the quad, she stopped.

Below them, hundreds of students in slate gray robes were kneeling on the pavement of the courtyard. They weren't moving. They were held in a state of complete stillness under the mid-morning sun. Each held a rosary. There was no talking—only the collective, low whispers of a Latin prayer, a murmur rising to heaven.

He paused, looking over the expanse. "This is the North Campus."

"The Exceptions. Every person down there had a possession. A mark, a curse, a shadow that wouldn't leave. The Academy teaches them the only way to starve the darkness is through the discipline of the light."

Kimbra watched them. They didn't appear to be students; they resembled sculptures crafted from grief and rock. She

felt the lily pulse—a call from the other side, trying to locate her. She stepped closer to Roman, seeking that grounding effect again.

“They suffer,” he said, noting her proximity but not moving away. “They take the pain of their attachments and offer it up to the cross. They turn themselves into living shields. If you can’t learn to temper your spirit, the signature of your brand will eventually act as a homing beacon. You’ll lead the enemy right to our door.”

She focused her attention on the kneeling figures. She realized then the Lord’s Army didn’t march to war. They stood motionless until the war broke against them.

“What if I can’t be still?”

“Then you’re a beacon waiting to be extinguished,” he reminded her.

They stood on the balcony for a long time, the low-register chanting of the Latin prayers vibrating through the pillar. The wire was relentless, tugging toward the tree line, but every time she brushed against him, it softened into a dull, manageable ache.

“Do they ever leave the quad?” She was observing a girl in the front row who was trembling so violently the beads clacked against the pavement.

“Only when their prayer is completed. When you can sit in the center of your own storm and not feel the wind—that’s when you’re ready for the next level of training.”

He looked at her, his expression unreadable. “You’ll start your first session this afternoon after your official intake with Father Manuel. He’ll teach you how to nest the frequency of the mark.”

The sun crested the paneled roofs, sending heat shimmering off its grey shingles as she surveyed the quad once more. “It looks like a slow death.”

“It’s a slow birth.” He stepped back from the railing, the movement breaking their physical contact. Immediately, the static in her shoulder flared back to life, a cruel reminder of the tether.

Roman noticed the way she winced, his fists clenched as if he wanted to reach out and ground her again, but he held himself back. “The North Campus is a place of survival, Kimbra. If you can’t learn to calm your mind and be still, you won’t be able to reclaim your own life.”

He turned toward the doors leading back into the shadows of the Main Hall. “Come. Father Manuel is waiting for you.”

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The walk to Father Manuel’s office was a solemn procession. Roman walked a half-step behind her, a silent sentinel. Every time Kimbra’s gait faltered, she felt the heat of his proximity—an unspoken promise to catch her if the world tilted again.

They stopped before a set of double doors bound in weathered bands. His expression was tight with an emotion he couldn’t conceal—a warning, or perhaps an apology.

“The Rector knows your name but he doesn’t know the burden you’re carrying. He’ll wait for you to lead the way. You can trust him to be discreet.”

He pushed the doors open.

The office was a circular chamber of theological texts, lit by dozens of flickering votive candles casting a restless glow over walls filled with books. Father Manuel sat behind a walnut desk, his spectacles perched on the end of his nose as he studied a series of Latin rites.

He was a man who inhabited two lifetimes at once. His skin was tanned and lined with crevices of a life spent under the harsh Louisiana sun, yet he possessed the startling, clear intensity of a youth who had just discovered his calling. Framing his jaw was a thick, silver-streaked beard—trimmed with a precision speaking of disciplined habits.

He had a face of contradictions: the resilience of an old magnolia tree paired with the upright posture of a soldier in his prime. When he smiled, the years fell away, but when he became introspective, the burden of the Academy's secrets returned to settle in the hollows of his cheeks.

"Thank you, Roman," he said, dismissing him with a firm nod. "Wait in the lounge down the hall."

He hesitated—a fracture in his discipline lasting only a second—before he bowed his head and retreated. The door clicked shut, leaving her alone with the discerning priest.

"Sit, Kimberly," Father Manuel said softly, gesturing towards a worn leather chair. He waited a long moment before continuing. "I am the Chief Exorcist and Rector of the Academy. You have been through a great deal of trauma to reach our gates. I want you to know within these walls, your past is a secret until you choose to divulge it."

She clutched the folds of her robe, her knuckles white. She stared at the crucifix on the wall, then back to the priest. His

gaze was patient, lacking the cold detachment she had grown accustomed to.

“Roman said you could help me,” she managed. “That you could make the noise stop.”

“I can help you strengthen your own defenses,” he corrected gently. “But first, I must understand the nature of the broadcast. The brand... it has a resonance I haven't encountered in many years. It is a tether. Someone is calling for you, aren't they?”

His kindness acted like a key, slowly turning a lock she had kept bolted since her escape. She took a shallow breath.

“His name is Damian.” The name was a gash on her tongue. “Damian Boudreaux.”

Father Manuel didn't write it down. He didn't move.

“Boudreaux?” he repeated, his brow furrowed with a hint of recognition, but he didn't interrupt. He watched her with an intense focus.

“I was a debt... or I am a debt. They live on the other side of the marshland. Damian was dying. His heart was failing. They didn't want a doctor; they wanted a Hearth. They took me because our frequencies matched. They used a blood ritual to stitch his life to mine. I'm not a person to them. I'm a battery. Every spark of life I have left is keeping his from ending. That's the pull I feel—the wire. It's him reaching out to lure me back.”

Father Manuel's expression shifted to a somber gravity. He leaned back, the wood of his chair creaking.

“A Hearth... and an occult ritual. They have attempted to play God with the threads of the soul.”

“You know of this practice?” She was shocked by his recognition.

“Unfortunately, I do. It explains why there was such a massive discharge at the gate. You’re not only being tracked. You are being reclaimed by a void that cannot fill itself.”

He slid the glasses from his face, folding the frames with slow, deliberate precision before setting them on the desk. “Kimberly, a tether such as this cannot be cut with a blade. To sever a diabolical contract, we must undergo what we call the Rite of Severance. But before the rite, we must Nest. You must learn to become empty of your own essence so that Damian finds nothing to latch onto.”

Father Manuel cleared his throat. “May I ask a personal question?”

She nodded tentatively.

“Have you ever undergone a baptism?”

“No,” she admitted. “My parents weren’t religious in that sense.”

“In what sense, then?” He scanned her face, searching for a trace of her origins.

“I was sold to Vincent as a child to settle my father’s debt. I’ve lived on the estate ever since I can remember. So you tell me, Father, what kind of parents would do that to their only daughter?”

He didn’t waver, but his hand tightened on the edge of the desk. “We are commanded to honor our father and mother by the Almighty, but that doesn’t mean remain subject to their abuse. It is a grave sin to harm the little ones... I am so sorry this has happened to you, Kimberly.”

Her throat tightened as she fought the sudden sting in her eyes. “I just want to be free from all of them. Can you help me do that?”

“It will be difficult,” he said softly. “To hide from someone who is stitched to your marrow requires a level of discipline most saints spend a lifetime seeking. Are you prepared to sever the tie? To become the stillness so that he thinks you have vanished from the world?”

She thought of the willow-shriek and the cruel, parasitic pull of the manor. She thought of Roman, and the peace he brought.

“I’ll do it,” she said, looking straight at him. “I want to be my own person again.”

“Then we can proceed with the arrangements.” He pushed forward a manila folder. “Fill out these admission forms, then go back to Roman. Let him take you to the refectory. Sister Marta is waiting with your first meal. You will need your strength before the afternoon bells.”

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The refectory was devoid of clattering trays and teenage gossip. It was a hall of vaulted stone and long trestle tables. The scent of rosemary and sourdough wafted out from the kitchen. Roman led her to a corner table, his presence an unspoken warning to the students looking up from their bowls with knowing whispers.

She sat, the cold bench hard against her weak frame. Across from her was a boy whose upper limbs were wrapped in thick, fluid-stained gauze. He didn't look at her; he was focused entirely on his broth, his movements robotic and precise.

“That’s Jordan,” Roman whispered. “He was a vessel for a coven near the outer banks of the Mississippi. If he touches the table without the linen, he’ll burn. He hasn’t completed the Catechumen process yet, so for his sake, Sister Marta wrapped him up. She wanted to make sure he could navigate the halls without scarring himself further.”

Kimbra didn’t need the linen, but she had the brand—a different kind of heat. She felt the scrutiny of the room on her—the new Hearth who had brought a winter storm into spring.

She picked up a piece of bread, but as she went to bite it, she realized with a sting of trepidation, she couldn't remember what honey tasted like. Damian had been fond of honey. He had spread it on her toast every morning, but he had dragged the memory of its sweetness with him through the tether—a stolen comfort.

The theft was so thorough it felt as if she were being erased from the inside out.

Roman studied her, a look of genuine concern spreading across his face. “Are you okay?”

She wiped away tears with the sleeve of her robe. “I’m not hungry after all,” she choked out, the bread turning to cardboard in her mouth. “Can we... skip this part?”

“Of course we can. Whatever you need.” Without hesitation, he gently caressed her arm.

The effect was instantaneous. The wire stopped its erratic vibrating, and the empty void where the memory of honey should have been felt less devastating.

“Thanks.” She let out a brief sigh.

She felt small in this grand institution, but the sensation was different here. At the Boudreaux mansion, she had been reduced—shrunk down to fit a collector’s shelf. Here, she was a seed planted in nourishing soil.

There was something awe-inspiring about the Academy, a felt presence of something immovable she couldn’t quite place, and for the first time, it wasn’t trying to consume her.

THE RED LAMP

After her meal, Roman led her further into the Campus. The transition from the Tower to the common areas was jarring. The silence remained, but it was populated now.

In a long, arched corridor lined with votive candles, a girl was propped against the wall. She was curvy, her figure carrying a distinguished maturity for her age. She had an olive complexion and astute eyes that catalogued every movement Kimbra made. Her robe was unbuttoned at the collar, revealing a small tattoo of a flame behind her ear—a remnant of a life lived outside the gates.

“You’re the new girl,” the student said. Her accent was a Metairie lilt feeling strangely out of place in the historic hallway.

“Genesis, don’t.” Roman stepped in between the two women, blocking the view. “She’s on her way to the White Room. She hasn’t been cleared for socialization.”

Genesis pushed off the stone with a lazy, graceful movement. She ignored him, stepping directly onto their path. “The Exceptions are never cleared for anything. We exist until we stop vibrating.” She sized Kimbra up and down. “I’m Genesis. I used to be a star in the choir. Then I realized I

preferred the smoke in the clubs better than the incense in the sanctuary. Now? I'm here because I got bored of being bored."

"I'm Kimbra." She was surprised by the girl's lack of pretense.

"I know who you are. The whole campus knows." A knowing smirk played on her lips. "They say you brought the weather with you. Here's a tip: don't let the Rector catch you looking for a why. In this place, the why is always Jesus—even when it's an iron door."

She tucked a stray lock of hair behind Kimbra's ear. It was a quick, sisterly gesture that felt foreign.

"He's a good one." She flicked a teasing wink. "But he's a De la Croix. He thinks he can save the world by being perfect. Sometimes, you have to let the storm hit you and see what's left after the strike... know what I mean?"

"He isn't looking for perfection, Gen. He's looking for peace, and you're currently the most disruptive thing in the West Wing."

Ignatius stepped from the shadows of a nearby archway, towering over everyone. He possessed a muscular, fluid gait—a lethal extension of the wall itself.

His hands were clasped behind his back, his posture one of patient, watchful composure. He moved to Roman's side, his presence subtly expanding the perimeter around her.

Genesis tilted her head up, a cheeky grin spreading across her face. "Oh, look at you, Santiago. Arriving just in time to save the heir to the throne. Does he pay you in silver coins or extra penance?"

“He pays me in the satisfaction of watching you fail to ruffle him,” he replied coolly. “Besides, shouldn't you be at your station? Or did the Rector discover you've been replacing the chapel's salt with floor-wax?”

“It wasn't floor-wax; it was an aesthetic upgrade,” she shot back, her eyes dancing with the usual defiance. “Unlike you. I bet you even dream in a straight line.”

“I dream in a way that doesn't involve being committed to a North Campus cell for loitering.” He didn't move an inch, acting as a stop-block to her restlessness. “Move along, Gen. Your static is giving me a headache.”

“Careful, Iggy,” she laughed. “If you get too close to Roman, you might turn into a statue too.”

“Genesis, enough.” Roman rubbed the bridge of his nose as if a headache were already forming.

It was evident these three shared a long-standing, begrudging respect.

“Go on then.” She stepped aside as Ignatius's presence crowded her out. “Go play the quiet game, Kimbra. But if the prayers remind you of a cage, just remember: cages are meant to be lived in, not stared at. Might as well decorate yours.”

Roman appeared more tense now, his shoulders taut. But Ignatius didn't vanish into the shadows; he fell into step beside them, his presence acting as a stabilizer absorbing the friction Genesis had left behind.

He slowed his pace, his posture relaxing enough to acknowledge the man beside him. “This is Ignatius. He's the only one in this place who can tell me when I'm being too stubborn for my own good.”

“I suspect I’ll be busy, then,” he joked, looking at her with a kindness that felt reassuring. It lacked the analytical examination of the faculty; he simply saw the girl beneath the trauma. Where Roman’s beauty was defined by striking, sharp angles, Ignatius possessed a smooth, uncomplicated symmetry. His presence carried a notable magnetism—a fragment of sun-drenched wood preserved against the cold architecture of the institute.

“It’s an honor,” he added with a small, respectful nod. “Roman hasn’t stopped talking about the strength it took for you to get here. Most would have been consumed by that kind of vacuum before they ever reached the gates.”

“I didn’t feel strong,” she whispered, though she felt a flush of heat at the genuine sincerity in his voice.

“Strength feels like exhaustion while you’re using it,” he replied. His smile was brief but possessed a deep understanding. “You’re in good company. Roman might be a bit of a statue, but he’s the best Shield we have. Just remember to breathe. The air here can get a bit thin if you become too anxious.”

“Iggy is the one who keeps us all from floating away.”

“I make sure the anchors are tied correctly,” Ignatius countered playfully. He stayed with them for a few more paces before stopping at a branching corridor.

“I have to report for the evening watch. I’ll see you later, man. Good to meet you, Kimbra.” He offered her a gaze that held the solidarity of a promise before turning away.

Roman watched him go for a second, then led her toward the reinforced door at the end of the hall.

The White Room was unlike the rest of the building. It was a chamber of smooth ivory, lit naturally by a crown of windows set high into the ceiling. The acoustics were amazing; every breath she took became a sigh from a giant. Father Manuel stood behind the glass barrier. Beside him was a bowl filled with water, sitting atop a pedestal.

“Welcome.” His greeting projected from the intercom as if born inside her own head. “Roman, take your position at the Anchor point.”

He sat on a narrow bench against the wall, gripping his crucifix.

“The Boudreaux pulse is a broadcast.” Father Manuel stepped toward the bowl. “They are trying to find the resonance of the mark. To survive the rite, you must first learn to sink the signal. You must make your spirit so encumbered with stillness that the broadcast passes through you without triggering any feedback.”

He tapped the side of the bowl with a small mallet. A low, vibrating tone filled the room. In an instant, she felt it. The lily flared with searing heat. The wire in her bone began to sing—a high-pitched, needle-thin sound trying to harmonize with the bowl’s resonance.

“Don’t fight the current, Kimberly.” Father Manuel paced the circumference of the ivory floor. “Don’t push against it. If you push, you give the signal something to latch onto. You must become the silence.”

He struck the mallet against the bowl repeatedly. The resonance bypassed her ears to strike the floorboards beneath her feet, rattling through her bones until they ached. The room was designed to reflect every stray thought, every tinge of fear. Unlike the wetlands, which absorbed the noise, this room caught her internal wire and amplified it.

“The salt-stone is only a mirror,” he explained. “But if you cannot quell the storm brewing in your own soul, the broadcast will vibrate until the resonance shatters you.”

She clutched the edges of her robe. She felt the unwelcome intrusion trying to manifest in her fragile state—the smell of burnt flesh, the heat of the iron. The room began to hum with a discordant note. She wasn't fighting Damian's broadcast; she was resisting the part of her that still recognized him as her home.

Her vision blurred. The willow-shriek was back, louder than the bowl, demanding her return to the blood-thirsty soil. She felt her knees buckle. She was desperate for the grounding touch Roman had given her in the hallway. His knuckles were white as he gripped the edge of the bench. He wanted to move—she could see the muscle in his jaw jump—but he remained at the Anchor point.

“Close your eyes.” His guidance cut through the static, low and stable. “Find the space between the notes. Don't look for an escape, Kimbra. Be still in the noise.”

She quickly obliged, focusing on the rough fabric of her robe, the chilling draft in the corridors, and the memory of falling into his arms. Slowly, she felt her pulse slow. She stopped fighting the wire. She let it bite, waiting out the

pressure in her head until the frequencies went dead. The bowl stopped humming.

“Good,” Father Manuel said. “You survived the first test. But when they broadcast again, they will compress the frequency until the air in your lungs claws its way out.”

+ + +

Genesis materialized from the shadows of the corridor as soon as Roman stepped into the Rector’s office to discuss the session’s resonance readings.

“The white room is a trip, isn’t it?” She smelled of lavender and mint vapor. “Father thinks you can just pray the signal into a corner. He’s a saint, but he’s never been hunted. He doesn’t understand the reality of the situation. Sometimes you have to scramble the signal, not hide from it.”

Kimbra leaned against the cool dampness of the wall, her shoulder still buzzing with a relentless ache. “What do you mean by scrambling it?”

The scrambler dug into the pocket of her robe and pulled out a small, worn piece of seashell. It wasn’t religious; it was a piece of debris smoothed by the tide. “You find something that belongs only to you. Not to your family, not to your ex-boyfriends. A secret. A memory they didn’t corrupt. You concentrate on it until the noise stops. It creates a knot in the wire they can’t slide past.”

The words lingered in her mind. *A secret.*

Kimbra's fingers curled, her nails digging into her palms as she mentally retreated into the empty hallways of her own mind. She went looking for a knot, a piece of her old self that didn't belong to the Boudreaux family.

She tried to remember her childhood before the estate, but it was a landscape of white fog. She recalled the day she arrived at the manor, but all that was found was the phantom sensation of Damian whispering in her ear. She tried to conjure the smell of her mother's hair, but the spicy scent of lilies Damian had brought her the day of the ceremony immediately overtook it.

The realization hit her, a blow to the stomach: the wire acted as a parasite, and the tether was more than a drain—it was a selective harvest. Damian wasn't siphoning her memories; he was overwriting her history. Every precious, private moment she thought she owned had been tainted, and claimed by the wire. Even the wild trek through the bayou after her escape was a blur.

A cold panic flared throughout her body. If she couldn't find a secret, she had no anchor. If every room in her mind was crowded with Damian's presence and every memory was narrated by him, then what was left of her? She was a book with half the pages ripped out, and the remaining ones were written by him.

"I can't think of one... Besides, Roman says the only way through is to be silent."

"De la Croix is trying to be a martyr because he thinks he owes God a debt... He's a noble boy. One I wouldn't mind having my way with in another life, and if you're crushing on him hard, I don't blame you. I mean, look at him—did he

step out of a Gucci ad or what? And then he brings Ignatius along to play the brooding sidekick? It's almost unfair. Santiago has a charming and magnetic look that's just as tempting. They're a matched set of high-end statuary... But never mind those two. Don't let the Shield's duty become your obligation, because you're the one who has to live with the noise."

Before she could ask what debt he was paying, the door at the end of the hall creaked open. Genesis retreated into the shadows with practiced ease.

Roman walked toward her, a glimmer of hope in his eyes. "Father is pleased with your progress." He offered his left arm to guide her. "But the sun is setting. We need to get you back to the Tower before the Compline bells."

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As they walked back through the artery of the North Campus, the atmosphere shifted. The freezing condensation of the lower halls gave way to a new feeling... holy. They passed by a set of hidden doors. They weren't locked, but they stood ajar. Above the archway, a small red lamp burned—the Sanctuary Lamp.

She stopped. She didn't know the theology, but she felt a foreign pressure in her chest. A soothing sensation emanated through the door, a physical heartbeat. It was the complete opposite of the screeching, needle-thin broadcast from the wire.

“What is that?” she breathed.

“The Perpetual Adoration Chapel.” His voice was a bare whisper. “Someone is always in there. Kneeling. Watching. It’s the cornerstone of the Academy’s shield. That peace you feel? That’s the Real Presence of Christ.”

Kimbra allowed the purity of the chapel to wash over her. For the first time since the brutal event, the line felt completely dead. Not suppressed, not silenced—just gone.

“Can we go in?” she asked.

“Not yet.” Roman’s hand rested briefly against the stone archway. “You aren’t ready for that kind of holiness. To go in there, you must be entirely free of the other side. If you went in now, the brand would react. It would be... putting ice into boiling oil.”

As he spoke those words, the mark on her shoulder gave a final throb of protest. It felt like a vicious leech. She realized then the Boudreaux not only marked her; they colonized her. The tranquility from the chapel was an allergen to the Blood Lily.

He gently urged her forward, but as they walked away, she kept her head turned toward the red lamp. The peace was a promise, but his warning was a reminder: she was still carrying a fragment of the enemy inside her skin.

A CRACK IN THE ARMOR

The North Campus didn't sleep; it shifted its frequency. After escorting Kimbra back to the salt-lined safety of the St. Benedict Tower, Roman was not permitted the reprieve of his dormitory. A young acolyte intercepted him, gesturing toward the Archives—the subterranean guts of the school where the dampness of the New Orleans water table was held back by lead linings and constant prayer.

He found Father Manuel and Sister Alba hunched over a massive, vellum-bound ledger. The atmosphere was stifled and pungent, with a hint of vinegar used to preserve ancient ink. Instead of a faculty lesson, they conducted themselves like coroners examining an anomaly.

"You've felt the broadcast." Her cane tapped a consistent, impatient beat against the scraped floor. "But we are only now discovering the ledger of the men who exploit it."

She gestured to the table. In place of the usual resonance charts lay a genealogical branch—a rough sketch of a nervous system of bloodlines. "The Boudreaux family are not practitioners of the Sanguine Rite; they are its architects. For three centuries, they have used this city as their private

battery. Ordinary magic is a toy to them. They answer to a system we have recently uncovered—a living ledger of blood they call the Debt.”

“Debt?” Roman’s fingers curled against the edge of the table.

“Not the financial debt you find in the secular world, although it functions much the same.” Sister Alba’s fingers moved blindly across the raised ink of the script. “From what we have gathered, a debt to the Root means someone has entered a contractual agreement with a demonic entity to gain worldly status or prestige. The debt is paid back through sacrifice, whether monetary or spiritual. In this case, the cost is a living soul—their most priceless return on investment, as it strengthens their power and influence.”

Sister Alba’s sightless eyes bore into his chest. “Kimberly’s father was a man of superior academic standing whose success and fortune had crumbled. It appears he sold his daughter’s life, signing over his legal guardianship to settle his own accounts.”

The weight of the information was a physical blow, leaving him reeling. He thought of the way Kimbra looked in the radiance of the morning sun—not as a ledger entry, but as a human being learning to breathe without a burden on her chest.

“But the Boudreaux family had discovered the girl could be used for something else entirely.” She traced a trembling finger over a name at the root of the tree: Alphonse Boudreaux, 1723. “Alphonse first discovered a soul, when properly tethered, can be siphoned of its natural signature to extend the life of another. They call it the Crimson Root. It is

a parasitic link surviving the death of the host's body. What is attached to the girl upstairs isn't magical; it's a three-century-old accumulation of stolen vitality. We have never encountered a construct such as this."

Father Manuel stepped forward, his face grim and unusually pale in the candlelight. "The archives tell us every fifty years, a Hearth—also known as the Blood Lily—is chosen from their own coven. She is a girl with a rare resonance who can act as a bridge for the next Boudreaux heir."

The name *Blood Lily* hit Roman with the force of a psychic discharge. He pictured the mark—not as a chaotic scar, but as a deliberate curse. The weeping stripes he had mistaken for simple necrosis were actually the curling petals of a flower, attached to her bone and sucking from her marrow.

"She isn't a random victim," Father Manuel continued, his theological certainty replaced by a defensive edge. "She is the current vessel for the family's immortality. If we fail to sever the connection, she will be gutted completely until nothing remains but the entity."

His throat tightened. "Has anyone ever made it out alive? In three hundred years, has there ever been a successful defection—an escapee who didn't end up as fertilizer for the Root?"

Father Manuel and Sister Alba exchanged a glance—a silent, somber communication lasting a second too long. For the first time, he saw doubt on the Rector's face.

"The records are obscure...because the Boudreaux do not suffer a breach of contract," Father Manuel admitted, his fingers tracing the edge of the book. "Those who attempt to

flee the Sanguine Law are usually reclaimed within the lunar cycle. The few who were found alive were found... differently. Their identities simply ceased to exist. In the history of this Academy, we have never successfully processed a survivor of this coven. We are operating entirely without a blueprint.”

“No one?” His stomach sank.

Sister Alba’s cane tapped a sharp note against the floor. “The Rector speaks from the official intake logs.” Her head tilted toward a darker corner of the shelf. “But whispers live in the margins—the things seen by those of us who do not rely on ink and paper.”

She leaned forward, the flickering candles casting long shadows across her blind features. “Many years ago, rumors spoke of a woman who sought sanctuary at a parish in the outer Basin. She was not alone. She carried a child—a boy, it was said—whose signature was already fractured, as if he had been partially siphoned while still in the womb.”

“Did the Church protect them?” Roman asked.

“The Church provided a roof and discretion,” Sister Alba replied. “But the archives of that parish were lost in a fire, leaving the earth scorched for a mile in every direction. No bodies were recovered. No history remained. Some say they escaped into the veil; others say the Root pulled them under so deep even God lost sight of them.”

She turned her sightless face toward him. “I have begun a search into the woman’s identity. If she survived even a day longer than the Law allowed, she may have left a footprint—a gap in their evil ledger. But for now, as far as the world is

concerned, Kimberly is the only bird having ever flown this cage. That makes her a miracle... or a target.”

“She isn't a target,” Roman muttered, knowing full well the miracle was a death sentence. “She's a person.”

“The Root does not care for persons,” Sister Alba countered. “It recognizes only the Debt.”

“The boy, Damian.” His mind was still reeling from the image of the flower marred on her body. “He is the current recipient?”

“He is the leech,” she clarified sharply. “He is what they call the Legacy.”

“Legacy?” A confused look spread across his face.

“A Legacy for them means he is the chosen heir to manifest a high-ranking demon—one acting for them as a god of the pit,” Father Manuel interjected. “However, he was born with a defect, a condition common in their bloodline. He should have died young. Instead, his father used the Sanguine Knot to tie him to the Woods girl when they were children. She has been strengthening him, feeding him her own life-force—often through an initial blood ritual now sealed by the brand. Every breath he takes is stolen from her.”

Sister Alba leaned in. “This is why the broadcast is so aggressive. We aren't protecting a girl; we are attempting to disconnect a life-support system. The Boudreaux will not stop. To them, she is a proprietary asset. And they will burn this fortress to the cinder blocks to reclaim what they believe is theirs by right of blood.”

Roman studied the ledger, focusing on the names of the Hearths who had come before—dozens of girls who had simply vanished from the census, their lives consumed by the

Crimson Root. He realized now the brand wasn't simply a mark of possession; it was a harvest clock.

Sister Alba tilted her head slightly. "Tell me. When you touched her... did you feel the discharge? Or did you feel the pull of the Root?"

This was the moment. According to the Academy's code, he was required to report any Symphonic Resonance—the state where a protector's soul vibrates in harmony with the signature they are guarding.

He thought of the way the wire had stopped reverberating the moment he caught her, and the overwhelming peace filling the emptiness inside his own chest. He thought of the Blood Lily blooming, reaching out for his own heat.

"I felt the expected discharge." The lie tasted like bitter melon on his tongue. "Nothing proper grounding cannot manage."

"You are a De la Croix." The clicking of her cane stopped. "You were born into a world of silver-tongued liars. Do not bring that filth into this house. If you are bound to her, you must confess it now. Otherwise, you are no longer a Shield, but a bridge. And bridges allow the enemy to cross."

"I'm not tethered, Sister." His heart pounded a frantic rhythm he prayed his breathing didn't betray.

"We shall see," Father Manuel said, stepping in to break the tension, placing a hand on his shoulder—a grounding touch of his own. "Get some rest. Tomorrow, we move from sinking the signal to nesting it. If you cannot hold the line, you must tell us. A melting rod only burns the house down."

Roman bowed his head and exited, the revelation of the Boudreaux history choking him—the suffocating depth of the

swamp itself. He stopped in front of a washbasin and plunged his face into ice-cold water, holding his breath for as long as he could.

His skin was humming. A low-frequency vibration started in his fingertips and settled into his marrow—an echo of a heartbeat not his own. The lily in his mind replayed with every passing second.

He was no longer a protector; he was a mirror.

“You lied to the Rector,” his conscience hissed.

He saw his reflection in the rippling water. He was a De la Croix descendant having perfected the art of the Beautiful Lie. His ancestors had lied to governors, to cardinals, and to any higher authority to maintain the veneer of perfection. He thought he’d left that vice in the Garden District, but here it was disguised as a disciplined monotone.

He plunged into the cool liquid once more, hoping to drown out the static. As he came up for air, gasping, the resonance remained. He could feel her fear, a tingling needle at the base of his spine, and by some unknown cause, he could feel her relief.

If the faculty found out, they would label him as a compromised limb. He wasn't saving her; he was sinking into her. He knew Sister Alba was right. He had felt more than a discharge. He had felt a home. And in the North Campus, looking for a home in another person wasn't a sin; it was suicide.

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The St. Benedict Tower was supposed to be a fortress, but at 2:00 AM, it became a tomb. Kimbra drifted, the sedative pulling her into a languid slumber. In her dream, the scent of sun-warmed hay and wildflowers lingered. She stood in the thick grass behind the Mansion, years before the rituals.

“Look.”

She turned. Damian was there. Not the translucent creature from the study, but the boy of her childhood, with messy hair and a sweet smile. He held a small, wooden bird he had carved for her.

“It’s going to be okay, we’ll run away. Beyond the levee. Just you and me.”

In her sleep, she whimpered in distress. She leaned into him.

“I’ve been waiting for you,” he said softly.

As he spoke, the sun began to bleed. The floral scent curdled into old cinder. The carved bird rotted into a cluster of thorny vines. *“I’m so cold, Kimmy. Why didn’t you keep me warm?”*

The dream dissolved into a weeping thicket of cypress branches. The innocent Damian was gone, replaced by the Entity. He tore through the veil of her sleep, his fingers elongated into claws.

In the waking world, her breathing turned into a wet, drowning rattle. The mark began to palpitate with a purple liquid bleeding through the bandages. A thin, iridescent fluid—neither blood nor water—seeped from the wound. Her spine arched, snapping tight like a bowstring.

“I see the tower, Kimberly. I see the little box they put you in. But the vine is still in your blood. Ce qui est noué ne sera pas défait.” The dialect was from the horrible ritual. *What is bound will not be undone.*

At the foot of the bed, the shadows coalesced. A silhouette of a boy manifested from the pools of darkness. The resonance was dense enough to displace the atmosphere.

The door to her room burst open. Roman rushed in, his jacket unbuttoned. He lunged for the bed, embracing her in his arms. The discharge was a physical blow, a spike of psychic static throwing his head back, but he didn't let go.

“Wake up! Don't listen to him!”

“He's here.” Her nails scraped against her shoulder, trying to scratch away the brand. *“He's... he's under my skin.”*

She snapped out of the nightmare, her sheets soaked in sweat.

She realized she was alone.

The Roman who had lunged for her, the warmth of his chest—it had all been a trick of the tether, a hallucination woven by the Entity to make her lower her guard. There was no soot, no scorch marks on a sleeve. There was only the beaming moonlight pouring into her room.

But the fluid was real.

The bandages were drenched with ichor. It sizzled faintly—a physical wound left by a ghost. Damian hadn't been in the room, but he had left his mark on the waking world.

“He saw me.”

The shriek was gone, replaced by a satisfied hum in her bone. The lily felt engorged as if it had fed on her terror. The

Entity didn't need to break the doors down; it had already located the exact coordinates of her essence.

She stood up, her legs shaking, and moved toward the washbasin. She caught her reflection.

"You're mine, Kimmy. I'm coming for you."

She stumbled back from the sink. She knew she wasn't safe anymore; she was a bridge. Every word Father Manuel had warned her about was manifesting in the weeping heat of her mark.

She noticed the bandages on the floor, the strange fluid had soaked through them. The salt-lined mortar of the tower, once a comfort, had been breached. Damian didn't have to know her location; he was already infiltrating from the basement of her own soul.

She realized then the nesting wouldn't be enough. You couldn't hide a fire in a wooden house, and you couldn't keep a Boudreaux claim from burning through a heart still in love with the monster who scorched it.

She needed to be emptied of everything—his laugh, the taste of honey, the memory of the willow—before the wire turned into a permanent chain.

MUSIC BOX

The tolling of the morning bells turned the limestone floors into a tuning fork, forcing her pulse to match its chime. Each strike served as a reminder of the time slipping away, a rhythmic note competing with the throb in her shoulder. To the other students, the sound called them to prayer or duty; to her, they were a countdown.

She didn't wait for Roman to arrive for their morning session; the haunting memory of Damian's transformation—and the horrifying shift in her own appearance—provided all the incentive she needed. Taking control was her only chance to survive another night in solitude.

She found Genesis in the neglected garden behind the refectory, where the lime-washed walls were covered in a thin, defiant layer of gray lichen. She sat on a lonely bench, tossing a smooth pebble into a dry fountain.

"You look like you've seen a ghost," the girl said without turning around. "Or perhaps the ghost found you."

"He saw me."

"Ooh. Who saw you? Do tell—I wanna know all the deets." She stopped tossing the pebble and inched closer.

“Damian... in my dream. He used the frequency to map the room. The silence isn't enough. I can't be still while he's in my head.”

“Creepy.” Genesis went wide-eyed, her mouth hanging open. She turned, scrutinizing Kimbra's pale face. “So, are you ready to scramble the signal?” She reached into her robe and handed her the seashell, the frosted green shard catching the morning sun. “The faculty teaches you to be an empty vessel so the noise passes...blah...blah...blah. I'm telling you to be a knot. You need a memory. Something your oppressors didn't give you. Something they don't even know exists.”

She searched through the obscure, manicured halls of her upbringing. Every memory was stained with the scent of the branding or the trauma of the gown. But then, she found it—a bright spark from her former life, buried deep in her psyche.

“A melody. My mother gave me a music box for my sixth birthday. I remember I'd wind the little ballerina figurine over and over again. I can still hear its chimes.”

For a moment, the remnants of the nightmare dissolved. She was back in a room smelling of laundry soap and vanilla—her life before the grim estate. She felt the smooth gloss and rectangular shape of the music box in her lap. Its rose-pink lid creaked a little too loudly when opened.

Plink. Plink-plink. Plink.

It was a simple lullaby, a few notes tripping over themselves. She remembered the ballerina—a tiny plastic figure with a chipped tutu and one arm raised in a permanent, frozen salute. As the spring unwound, the music created a tiny pocket of safety where the world couldn't reach

her. “It’s a different kind of song. It’s... a loop. It stays inside itself.”

“Fabulous. It’s done. There’s your knot. The ballerina is your sentry now. When the wire broadcasts, you wind the spring. You let the little dancer take up all the space in your head. Picture the time when you were innocent. Play the melody in your mind. It’s a scratch on a record. It keeps the needle from moving forward... It’ll drown out the noise.”

Kimbra gripped the seashell. For the first time, she felt she had a weapon. It didn’t belong to the Church nor the Boudreaux. It was hers.

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The main chapel of Our Lady of Tears was a cavern of shadows, lit only by the distant, unwavering flicker of the Sanctuary Lamp. Roman entered the confessional at the back, the velvet curtain dropping like a protective shield. He knelt on the wooden kneeler, the draft of aged timber and beeswax pressing in on him. Behind the screen, the silhouette of Father Miguel—the Rector’s mentor and the oldest priest in the fortress—waited in patient silence.

“Bless me, Father, for I have sinned... It’s been three weeks since my last confession.”

“Speak, my son,” the old priest whispered.

“I lied to my superiors. I told Father Manuel and Sister Alba the resonance was manageable. I told them I wasn’t tethered.” He paused, the small booth losing its dimensions,

trapping him in the hard reality of what he'd just admitted. "I am a bridge. When I touch her, the noise of the world stops, and something else begins. I felt... a home. For the first time since the night I walked away from my family name, the shame was gone. It was replaced by her."

The silence from the other side of the screen was long and sober. "You are seeking your own redemption through her suffering. It is an imprudent path for a man trying to denounce the world."

"It's more than that..." He gripped the edge of the screen. "...I don't want to save her. I want to be near her, always. When I'm with her, I don't see a vessel or an asset. I see a reason to stay in the world. I've started to love the woman I'm supposed to protect. If the other guy was a parasite, then who am I for wanting her woven into my own heart?"

"You're a young man," Father Miguel said gently. "But in this tower, you are a guardian. If you lie to hide your feelings, you leave the gate unlocked. The enemy doesn't need to break down the walls if the sentry is dreaming of a life he can't have."

"Then, what do I do?"

"Penance is not enough for a lie endangering the sanctuary," the wise priest replied. "You must tell Father Manuel the truth. If the resonance is symphonic, you must step back. You cannot be her ground if you are becoming her gravity."

The final word hit him harder than any exterior blow. It was a terrifying truth. He had spent years trying to be weightless, a ghost in a uniform, and now Kimbra had given him mass again. He felt the pull of her in the center of his

chest—an anchor eclipsing anything he had ever felt before, dragging him away from the denial of the world he had sworn to uphold.

In the physics of the Sanctuary, a Shield was meant to be an inert conductor—absorbing the toxic static of the demonic realm and grounding it into their bodies as an offering to the Cross. But a symphonic resonance was a lethal malfunction. When a Guardian's soul harmonized with an unsealed Vessel's, the spiritual current stopped flowing through the circuit; it began to loop, building an exponential, blinding voltage between them. If he didn't sever the connection, the overcharge would inevitably blow the circuit, shattering Kimbra's mind and burning the fortress walls from the inside out.

He thought of the De la Croix parties—the vanity, the vapid laughter—and how he had run to the school to escape the yoke of his own family's sins. But this was different. This wasn't the restrictive expectations of the New Orleans elite; this was a draw toward a lighthouse in a storm. If he stepped back, as the priest insisted, he would be letting her drift further into the abyss. But if he stayed, he was the very crack in the walls allowing the enemy to enter.

He leaned his forehead on the screen. The home he had felt when he held Kimbra was the only tangible thing he had ever experienced; now, the Church was telling him he had to burn it down.

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Roman emerged from the chapel, the confessional's curtain swinging behind him. The corridor's chill couldn't compare to the icy fracture Father Miguel had carved into his chest.

Gravity.

The word carried its own mass. If he stayed with her, he'd be a liability. If he left her alone, she would succumb to the evil curse.

He found Ignatius in the training quad, drilling a sequence of slow, deliberate forms with a hefty practice staff. The upperclassman used it to pin his own center, the wood whistling softly through the damp morning air. Ignatius stopped the moment Roman stepped onto the pavement, sensing the transition in his friend's temperament.

"You look like you just heard your own death sentence." He rested the staff along a nearby pillar, knowing better than to offer a platitude.

Roman leaned against the stone masonry, his fingers digging into the cold mortar. "Father Miguel says I'm becoming her gravity. And if I lie to protect my feelings, I leave the gate unlocked for the enemy... He told me I have to step back. I can't be her ground if I'm becoming the very thing that pulls her under."

Ignatius sat on a bench, wiping sweat from his brow. He wasn't shocked; he watched him with a weathered understanding. "The Church deals in absolutes, brother. The administration wants you see-through—clear enough for the Light to pass without clinging to your desires..."

Have you forgotten the words of our Oath?" Ignatius continued, his voice dropping into a stern, rhythmic cadence.

“I am the wall, not the prize. I am the sentry that guards the flame, holding no warmth for myself.” We swore to be transparent, Roman. But we were born with mass. We have density.”

“I told him I felt a home in her. He said it was ill-advised—that I’m seeking my own redemption through her suffering.”

“It’s a complication, but Father is right about the mechanics. A Shield cannot be a home. A home is a destination; a Shield is a barrier... I’ve seen her, my friend. Kimbra is special. She possesses a purity untainted by the grime, despite what they did to her for years. It’s no wonder you’re drawn to her. I felt it myself when I met her in person.”

Roman looked at him, surprised. “You felt it too?”

“I felt the potential of what she could be. But unlike you, I’m not trying to atone for my past. You’re trying to save the girl you lost by clinging to this one so tight you’re both going to drown. If you want to keep the gate locked, you have to stop dreaming of a life you can’t have and start being the rock she needs.”

Ignatius stood up and walked over, placing a reassuring hand on his shoulder. “You don’t have to burn the home down. You build a wall around it. If you step back, do it to give her room to find her own standing, not because you’re afraid of your emotions. If the resonance is symphonic, we manage the discharge. We don’t let the circuit blow.”

He let out a long, uneven breath, the pent up tension subsiding under Ignatius’s stoic influence. “And if I can’t distance myself?”

“Then I’ll be the one to hold the line while you figure it out,” he promised with a brief, genuine smile. “Now, go to her. She’s with Genesis in the garden. And Roman? Try to breathe. You’re not a crack in the wall yet.”

LITTLE LAMB

The total vacuum effect of the White Room was disconcerting as Kimbra took her place in the center of the ivory salt circle, clutching the seashell Genesis had given her.

“Position, Roman.” Father Manuel’s attention was fixed on the resonance charts.

He took his place at the Anchor point, feeling a reassuring clarity. The Sacrament of Confession with Father Miguel hadn’t removed his growing fondness for the girl, but it had stripped away the lie and his guilt. He was no longer a thief—only a penitent sinner standing in the truth of his own weaknesses—and that made him solid.

The atmospheric pressure inside the chamber had risen to a fever pitch. The water in the bowl coalesced into a symmetrical star. “The Pulse is coming,” Father Manuel warned. “Sink the signal.”

The violet glow from the lily began spasming. She stood there, paralyzed for an instant as the spiritual weight mounted.

“Now!” Roman gripped the bench so hard the wood groaned.

She didn't sink. Instead, she began to hum. It was a thin, tinkling melody—the sweet chimes of a ballerina spinning on a plastic gear. It was childish, and entirely out of place in the severity of the room.

The intercom crackled. “What is she doing?”

Roman's mind flashed back to their encounter with Genesis. *The scramble*, he thought, shaking his head. He knew it wouldn't work for the same reason he had tried to shield her from the rebellious girl in the first place: she had no idea Kimbra was never baptized. A scramble only works when one has the protection of the Church.

“Kimbra, don't! You can't!”

As the words escaped his lips, another voice manifested.

“*Kimberly...*”

Her body contorted as the Entity fought the scramble. Father Manuel raised his crucifix and began the severance incantation. But as the first Latin words left his lips, a deafening noise of insects screaming in unison filled the room. The wound on her shoulder tore open. The willow-shriek erupted into a horrific presence. She jerked upward, her toes barely reaching the floor, her head lolling back at an impossible angle.

The filth spilling out of her mouth was not her own. It was a layered, distorted baritone carrying the density of a creature from hell. “*Manuel,*” the Entity mocked, its transmission bleeding through the intercom system without a microphone. “*You speak of Severance with a mouth full of dead law. Do you think your little strings of Latin can cut a knot tied by the Sanguine Master?*”

“In nomine Patris, et Filii, et Spiritus Sancti!” Father Manuel intoned, thrusting the crucifix toward her. “I command the link to break!”

The Entity laughed—a harrowing note. Kimbra contorted, her limbs jerking like a puppet. *“You have no standing here, Priest. Look at her! Scan her soul. Where is the mark of your King? Where is the seal of His precious blood?”*

Father Manuel froze as he realized the tactical error.

“She is unmarked by the Eternal One,” the Entity hissed, her face twisting into an evil smirk. *“Sold to the Root as a child. By the laws of the Petit Catéchisme, she is a natural asset. You are trying to evict a tenant from a house you do not own.”*

For the first time in his thirty years at the Academy, Father Manuel felt a paralyzing dread. The spiritual topography of the room was shifting. Since there was no seal on her soul, she was a blank ledger to the evil laws of the unseen world. Vincent had been the first to write his name on the page.

“The Petit Catéchisme...” the priest whispered, his fingers gripping his crucifix. It was an inverted mirror of the Church’s own laws, a set of legalistic bylaws allowing them to claim any unsealed soul as a biological resource. Because she had never been claimed by the Kingdom, the Sanguine Law had established a binding acquisition of her essence. He wasn’t exorcising a demon; he was evicting a landlord who currently owned the deed to her flesh.

“Roman, hold the line!” Father Manuel shouted. The psychic pressure mounted, crushing the air from Roman’s chest. He switched tactics from his standard defense to force the Academy’s High Rite prayer past his lips. *“Ave Maria, gratia plena, Dominus tecum...”*

The brand flared into a heinous violet flame. Because she was never baptized, there was no spiritual armor to protect her internal organs from the heat of the broadcast. She was being cooked from the inside out. Her nervous system was acting as a conduit for the demon's malice.

Roman watched in horror as a fine mist of steam rose from her skin, the humidity of the outdoors manifesting in the dryness of the chamber. Her very cells were vibrating at a lethal current meant to sustain a demon, and the friction was tearing her apart.

"Stop!" He strained against the Anchor point. "You're killing her!"

"I am claiming her," the Entity hissed through her lips. "As for you, De la Croix... you say you want to be a shepherd, but we both know you want the little lamb for yourself. Your absolution has made you very clean indeed—and empty. Perhaps after I've finished with this girl, I'll take up residence in that vacant chest of yours."

The Entity's words sliced through the roaring static of the room, hitting him with the precision of a scalpel.

Vacant.

The word mirrored the absence he had felt since his former life—the feeling he was nothing more than a suit draped over a cursed lineage. He had laid his emotions bare in the confessional, scrubbing himself clean of the lie only to have the creature mock the space he had cleared.

For a second, Roman wavered. The accusation that he wanted the lamb for himself stung because it was the truth. He did want her. He wanted the warmth she brought to his frozen world. But as he watched the way her body was being

used as a conduit for a filth she never asked for—his shame curdled into something holy.

The Entity wasn't merely claiming a debt; it was declaring love and duty the same kind of prison. It was trying to convince him his affection for her was another form of bondage.

No. He clenched his fists so tightly, the bone felt ready to snap. *He wasn't a void waiting to be filled. He was the wall.*

He stepped into the consecrated circle, the soles of his boots crunching the rime of frost. The violet sparks lashed out at him, but he didn't flinch. His decision to cross the threshold was no longer an act of protocol; it was a total rejection of the lies the Entity presented.

It spoke of ownership, assets, and laws. He saw the distorted color in Kimbra's eyes and remembered the boy he used to be—the one who stood by while a girl was taken. He wouldn't be that vacancy again. If the demon wanted to find a home in his chest, it would find it occupied—a fury of fire ready to scorch the Root to its core. He interlocked his fingers with hers, anchoring her not to a category or an asset, but to a man who had ultimately found a cause greater than his own shame.

Father Manuel recalibrated. The Rite of Severance was a legal procedure, and he quickly realized he was in a court where he had no jurisdiction.

"I cannot sever the link!" he shouted over the roaring chaos. "I have no authority to exorcise a claim established before she arrived at our gate. To the Law of the Spirit, she still belongs to the boy! The only way to break the Sanguine

tether is to establish a higher claim. We cannot sever the vine unless we graft the branch onto a different Tree!”

She slammed back onto the floor, her chest heaving. The Entity was retreating, the awful noise receding, but the wire was now glowing red.

“The Baptism... Father, you must do it now!”

“A Baptism under fire.” Father Manuel grabbed the gold basin. “But she must choose it of her own free will. It cannot be forced like the brand. If she takes the water, she is no longer a natural asset of the Earth. She becomes a Citizen of the Kingdom. The Boudreaux will have no legal standing to siphon her.”

Kimbra glanced at the water, then at the lily. The ghostly shriek was still there, whispering she was a debt, a battery, a nothing.

“Do it...please,” she choked out, squeezing Roman’s wrist. “Make me belong to something else.”

BAPTISM BY FIRE

The pulse from the manor had turned into a desperate, continuous scream trying to shake the foundations of the building.

“Hold her steady!” Father Manuel commanded.

Roman sat on the floor of the sanctified circle, supporting her trembling figure against his chest. She was freezing, yet her body radiated a heat charring the fabric of her shift. His recent absolution gave him the grace to be her anchor—a solidness allowing him to stand in the center of the storm without being swept away.

“Kimberly Woods,” Father Manuel said, rising to cut through the layered mockery of the Entity. He didn't use the complex Latin of the Severance; he used the simple commands of the ancient Baptismal Rite. “Do you renounce Satan and all his works? Do you renounce the Crimson Root and all its empty promises?”

The Entity roared through her lips—a giant oak splitting in a gale. *“She is marked! She belongs to the Sanguine Master! You cannot undo a debt written in the marrow with a simple prayer!”*

Her fingers dug into Roman's sleeves. The agonizing ripple she felt in her chest tugged at her brutally, tearing her insides. She was fighting the black threatening to drown her irises. "I... I renounce it," she managed to choke out.

The room's temperature plummeted. Frost began to bloom in the shape of icy thorns, creeping toward the circle.

"Do you renounce the Sanguine Master and the parasitic knot he has woven?" Father Manuel's hand hovered over the water.

"I do," Kimbra trembled.

The Entity lashed out. A physical shockwave of energy threw the iron doors of the room outward, the metal groaning as it slammed into the walls of the corridor. Father Manuel didn't flinch. He was no longer a man; he was a conduit for a Higher Law.

"You are stealing what is mine!" the Entity shrieked.

"She was never yours!" Roman's jaw locked as he felt the willow-shriek trying to inhabit his own flesh. He squeezed her tighter to his chest. *"Kyrie Eleison, Christe Eleison..."*

"I renounce him." A sob caught in her throat. "I renounce Damian Boudreaux. I renounce the Root. I renounce the debt." The last words broke from her, desperate and honest, as tears tracked through the dust on her face.

The moisture in the pressurized chamber crystallized instantly into a swirling vortex of ice. This was a paranormal tantrum. The frost clawed at the walls, tracing the shapes of thorns that grew and thickened into a cage of winter.

She was violently snatched from Roman's clutches as she began to levitate, her spine arching and cracking—a dead

branch snapping. The Entity within her fought the renunciation with a violent, biological desperation.

Her blood felt as though it were being replaced by molten lead. She was a bridge collapsing under the strain of two worlds tugging in opposite directions, her nervous system firing off thousands of neurotransmitters at once.

“Hold her!” Father Manuel shouted, his voice barely audible over the roar of the supernatural gale.

Roman threw his entire weight on top of her, pinning her to the platform. He was the only thing keeping her from being jerked into the rafters by the invisible tether.

The sparks flaring were rapid bolts of electricity, a live wire searing through his charcoal sleeves, slicing his forearms. He gritted his teeth, his vision tunneling as he absorbed the shock directly into his own physique.

“Don't let go of me, Kimbra! Look at the water!”

Father Manuel continued the rite: *“Do you believe in God, the Father Almighty, Creator of heaven and earth?”*

“Yes.” Her jaw stiffened as if her mouth was being sown shut, the sickening strain in her chest cutting off her breath.

“How much longer? The pull is... unbearable...”

She clung to him, falling in and out of consciousness as her body boiled with a fatal fever. The ice blizzard roared, shaking the whole room and bursting through the windows.

“Don't give up. Hang on, Kim. A few more minutes.” The supernatural storm pulsed around them, but Roman held the line.

Father Manuel continued: *“Do you believe in Jesus Christ, His only Son our Lord, born of the Virgin Mary, who was*

crucified, died and was buried, rose from the dead and is now seated at the right hand of the Father?"

"Yes." For the first time, she wasn't sinking into the noise. She was reaching for the light as the final words of the rite were recited.

"Do you believe in the Holy Spirit, the Holy Catholic Church, the communion of Saints and the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body and life everlasting?"

"Yes."

Father Manuel dipped a cup into the water, the liquid shimmered with a beautiful radiance, driving back the mystifying purple of the room.

"Then I baptize you, Kimberly Woods," Father Manuel intoned, pouring the water over her forehead. *"In the name of the Father..."*

The first contact of the holy water jolted her body. The stabbing hook in her chest ripped through as if her heart tore in two, while the brand screamed—a high-pitched wail of agony making the bowl crack. The purple fluid began to evaporate into a foul steam.

"...and of the Son..."

The second pour hit. The wire in her marrow snapped. Miles away in the Boudreaux study, the veins on Damian's neck turned to ash as the battery was suddenly disconnected.

"...and of the Holy Spirit."

When the third pour of water dripped on her forehead, the lily let out one last ghastly shriek shattering the remaining glass in the room. A cloud of steam erupted from the wound, reeking of sulfur and burnt flesh.

For a terrifying second, her heart stopped—the monitor’s sustained beep lost in the roar of the wind. Kimbra saw the pit of hell opening to swallow her, the jagged claws of the corrupted vines reaching for her ankles.

But then, the golden brilliance from the water surged. It was a searing, holy fire cauterizing the link. The wire turned white, and the curse of the Root’s claim was lifted.

The frost vanished instantly, the ice sublimating into nothingness, leaving only the gasp of her first breath as a citizen of the Kingdom.

The room was flooded with a heavenly luminescence tasting of lilies—real lilies, fresh and uncorrupted. The abyssal black in her eyes vanished, replaced by a clear, vibrant hazel. The mark transformed. The weeping cavity dwindled, leaving behind a silver-white scar—no longer a siphon, but a trophy of a war won.

The Entity was evicted. A defeated hiss echoed in the room before the creature was banished forever.

She collapsed on Roman’s chest, her breathing shallow yet steadfast. She wasn’t an asset anymore. She wasn’t a Hearth. She was a girl, alone inside her own head.

He held her, his chin resting on her damp hair. He felt the hole in his own chest fill—with a restored peace. The lamb was safe, and the Shepherd finally knew what he was guarding.

Father Manuel’s face was etched with a weary, victorious joy. “The claim is broken, the Law of the Kingdom has superseded the Law of the damned. She is reborn. They can pulse the line until it burns, but they will find nothing and no

one on the other end.” He studied the basin; the water was clear and holy again.

Kimbra, barely able to move, looked down at her scar, then at Roman. “I can't hear the screeching anymore.”

He let out a long sigh of relief. “Good. Because from now on, the only thing you need to listen to is your own heart.”

+ + +

In the White Room, the frost began to melt into mundane puddles, and the smell of burnt ozone dissipated.

Roman didn't move an inch. Even as the frost melted and her vitals stabilized into a strong, healthy pulse, he held her against his chest. His own limbs were sore and tender; the bolts of energy had sliced through his uniform, leaving bleeding lines across his forearms. His skin felt as if it had been scraped raw, yet he didn't feel the pain—only the clarifying realization of her life in his hands.

“Roman.” Father Manuel leaned against the podium, worn out with exhaustion. “The infirmary. Now. Before the shock sets in.”

“Yes, Father.” He stood, his muscles screaming in protest. He lifted her in his arms, surprised by how weightless she felt now that the claim had been broken. She was pale, her breathing shallow but resolute. As he carried her through the chamber doors, the halls felt different. The students who usually roamed about were gone, cleared out by the Rector's order.

Sister Marta was waiting. She directed him to a bed screened off by vinyl curtains. “Lay her down. And you,” she pointed a sharp finger at him, “Sit. Do not move. You are radiating enough residual static to blow a fuse.”

He collapsed onto a nearby bed. He watched as Sister Marta began peeling the charred remains of the shifts and bandages away from Kimbra’s shoulder. “Look.”

He leaned forward. The weeping lily defining her existence—was gone. In its place was a smooth, iridescent scar, forged out of sterling silver. It was a beautiful, sanctified mark of ownership by a different King.

“The necrosis is gone,” Sister Marta observed, running a gloved finger over the edge of the scar. “The Sanguine tether has been completely cauterized. But the cost...” She scanned the monitors. Her vitals were severely low, and she was fighting a fever purely supernatural in origin. “She has survived a spiritual transplant. She doesn't know how to function without the siphon yet. It’s like a person who has lived in a vacuum suddenly being thrust into a high-pressure room.”

“And the burns?” he asked.

“The burns are the least of our worries.” She began cutting away his tattered sleeves. She hissed through her teeth as she saw his forearms. The skin was patterned with Lichtenberg figures—the fern-like scars left by lightning strikes—tracing the path where he had absorbed the discharge for her.

“You acted as the ground for a difficult and dangerous exorcism,” she muttered, dabbing a cool, pungent salve onto his wounds. “If you weren't a De la Croix—if your blood

hadn't been tempered by generations of Exception history—this would have fried you. You're lucky to be breathing.”

“I did what was needed.” His focus never left Kimbra's sleeping face; he was watching the way her chest rose and fell—a miracle after the violence of the spiritual war.

“No,” Sister Marta corrected him. “You did what a Sponsor does. You've grafted her to your own strength. It is no longer a simple duty.”

She paused. “The tether left a void when it snapped. You filled that space with your own resonance. Every time she feels a tremor of the old link—every time Damian reaches for her—she's going to reach for you. And every time you feel her pulse, your own heart is going to react in kind. You aren't her guardian anymore. To the Laws of the Spirit, you're her life-support.”

Roman didn't flinch at the diagnosis. The Symphonic Resonance wasn't a curse to him anymore; it was a tether of his own choosing.

“I can live with that.” A sheepish smile spread across his lips. He leaned his head back against the wall, letting his own breathing sync with the melodic beep of the monitor. For the first time, the cadence wasn't a countdown; it was a promise.

EXCEPTIONS &
EXPECTATIONS

At the Academy, a miracle meant a successful operation, but recovery was the most vulnerable phase. The Snap—the moment a demonic-tether forcibly severed—was known to leave its victims in a comatose state. Kimbra opened her eyes to a room filled with a soft morning sparkle.

For a fleeting second, her heart fluttered against her ribs as she attempted to contemplate the remnants of the tie in her mind, bracing for the excruciating shriek of the wire, the wicked mockery of the entity, or the degrading, searing heat of the brand.

There was nothing.

The solitude was a comfort—a mink blanket draped over her consciousness. For the first time in years, her head was a house with only one occupant. She sat up slowly, her muscles aching with a leaden heaviness, as if she had run a marathon through waist-deep mud.

“Careful... Don’t move too fast.” Roman sat by the window. He wore a white linen shirt, but his injury drew her attention. His forearms were wrapped in clinical gauze climbing from his wrists to his elbows. Where the fabric was

thin, she could see faint markings burned into his skin. He had acted as her anchor during the exorcism, and those violent bolts of electricity had left their fern-like marks over his flesh.

“Is it done?”

“The claim is severed,” he said, standing up. There was a noticeable stiffness, his movements cautious as if he were still adjusting to the additional weight of his frame. He held a small cup filled with a clear, fragrant liquid. “Drink this. It’s infused with hyssop. It will help calm your nerves.”

As she took the cup, her hand brushed his. She flinched, expecting the painful discharge of the old static, but there was only the human warmth of an innocent touch. The tether was gone, yet deep beneath the surface, she could feel the faint echo of the new resonance Sister Marta had warned Roman about—the grafting of his frequency into her empty space.

“I feel... like I got hit by a bus.”

The blood-soaked gauze was gone. In its place was a clean dressing, but she could see the edge of the scar. It no longer throbbed with the sickened hunger of the entity.

“Of course you do.” He sat on the edge of the bed. “You were being drained and filled by a parasite. You were a conduit meant to sustain a dying boy. Now that the tether is cut, your nervous system is in still shock. It takes time for the cells to adjust.”

“What happens now?”

“Now, the Church decides what to do with you. You aren’t a vessel to be guarded anymore. You’re a citizen of the Kingdom, which means you have rights—and responsibilities.

Father Manuel is meeting with the Academy's Council. They're debating whether to let you stay in the North Campus or move you to the High Yard for training."

"Training for what?"

"To use your gift." A small, proud smile touched his lips. "Now that you're baptized, you can use the scramble Genesis taught you, but with the authority of the Church behind it. It won't be a desperate plea; it will be a weapon. Your frequency is remarkable. If you can learn to master it, you could be one of the most formidable sentries we have."

The door creaked open, the scrambler slipped in carrying a tray of fruit and bread. Ignatius followed behind her, his presence providing a necessary balance to the room.

Genesis noticed Roman's bandages and gave him a playful, soft salute before winking at Ignatius.

"Look at you! You've got that newly baptized glow," she chirped, though her usual snark was tempered. She set the tray down on the desk. "And look at De la Croix, playing the devoted nurse even though he looks like he went ten rounds with a power transformer. And Santiago, lurking in the back to make sure he doesn't fall over."

"I'm not lurking, Gen. I'm providing a necessary perimeter." Ignatius walked toward the edge of the bed, offering Kimbra a brief, respectful nod. "How are you feeling? The internal noise usually leaves a dull ache after a few hours."

"I'm okay."

"Just okay?" Genesis smirked, glaring at Roman. She let the silence stretch, playfully charting the sudden tension brewing in the room before she walked in.

“She needs rest,” he warned, though he was visibly relieved to see Ignatius.

“She needs a friend who doesn't smell like incense and hospital corners... Speaking of baptisms... I'm sorry about teaching you to scramble. I assumed you were already marked by the Big Guy. I never realized you were technically... un-owned.”

“Which is why we witnessed a near-catastrophic manifestation instead,” Roman interrupted. “A scramble without a seal is an invitation for the Entity to tear the host apart.”

“I said it before: sometimes you have to let the storm hit you,” Genesis joked weakly, but she regarded his bandages and bit her lip.

Roman let out a long, unamused sigh. “Easy to say when you're a scrambler. You don't have to swear your life away on an altar.”

“He's right, Gen,” Ignatius added smoothly from the foot of the bed. “The administration views your lot as useful contractor assets, not consecrated conduits. You aren't bound to the same restrictive laws we are, which means you get to play with live wires while we have to absorb the shock.”

“Hey, I pay my dues in my own way,” Genesis snorted, rolling her eyes at the men's convicting gaze. She wasn't about to let their self-righteous martyrdom make her feel small. “Besides, the Boudreaux manor is in a state of emergency, Kim,” she continued, pivoting back to the safer topic. “My sources say the Snap hit your boy like a physical amputation. They say the house is a cemetery because you

took the battery with you. The poor guy doesn't know how to live on his own anymore.”

Kimbra felt a pang of recognition. “He’ll die without me, won’t he?”

“He’ll starve,” Genesis said bluntly.

“Which is the natural consequence of being a parasite,” Ignatius added, standing near the foot of the bed. He caught Genesis’s eye with a cheeky smirk. “Though I’m surprised you haven’t tried to sneak out and offer him one of your aesthetic upgrades. You always did have a soft spot for lost causes.”

“My only soft spot was for the club scene in Metairie, Santiago. The Root is a bore. They don’t even have a fake ID.”

“Neither do you. Not anymore,” Ignatius reminded her coolly. “I believe the Rector repurposed yours as a bookmark for the Book of Lamentations.”

“Ha. Ha.” She snorted.

Roman’s posture relaxed as he realized he could step away. “Iggy, I have to report to the Council. I’ve been sitting here since the Snap. Will you stay with her? I don’t trust the perimeter to anyone else.”

“I’ve got the watch, brother,” he promised, shifting into a serious, protective stance. “Go. I’ll make sure the anchors stay tied and our little scrambler doesn’t try to trade the girl’s shift for a pack of cloves.”

“It was one time, Iggy! And they were an emergency!” She laughed.

The precise stroke of the bell cut the hour—the midday Angelus. The two men stood upright, the chime acting as a command. Roman’s eyes lingered on Kimbra with a warmth the Shield’s oath didn’t account for.

“I’ll be back as soon as I can.” He wanted to touch her but he didn’t—mindful of the intense, looping pulse Sister Marta had warned him about—but the proximity was enough. “Sleep, Kim. You’re safe. For the first time in your life, you’re truly safe.”

Roman signaled to Ignatius, and they stepped out into the desolate corridor for a moment, the door clicking shut behind them to give the girls a semblance of privacy.

“They’re going to try to roast you in there,” Ignatius warned. “Sister Agatha is already looking for a reason to classify this as a theft of property rather than a baptism. She thinks you’ve overstepped the Law of Tears.”

“I did what had to be done.”

“I know. But the Council doesn’t deal in ‘what had to be done.’ They deal in the *Lex Academiae*. They’ll argue that because she was un-owned, you’ve brought a live wire into a dry house.” Ignatius gripped his arm, his gaze serious. “Don’t talk to them about her former status. Talk to them about the Prior Claim. Tell them she was a Mary in the ledger before she was a Lily in the Bayou. And for Kimbra’s sake... if they ask if the resonance is symphonic, tell them it was a mechanical ground. If they think your souls are looping, they’ll separate you before the sun goes down.”

He took a sharp breath, nodding slowly. “Mechanical. Understood.”

“Go on.” He opened the door to slip back inside. “I’ll keep the static out of here.”

Roman watched Ignatius secure the door before departing for his summons.

Inside the room, Ignatius resumed his post by the bed, his presence providing a welcomed support allowing her to breathe. She felt the lingering foundation of the resonance deep in her chest—to the Academy, it was a dangerous defect, but to her, it was a safe haven.

She turned to Genesis, who was already peeling an orange. “Tell me about the High Yard. If I'm going to be an Exception... I want to know what I'm fighting for. I don't want to be a victim who hides. I want to be the one who stands at the gate next time.”

Genesis grinned. “That's the spirit, Kim. The High Yard is where they turn the vulnerabilities into weapons. But be warned: the school's version of training involves a lot of prayer, a lot of fasting, and very little sleep.”

She looked at her scar and back at the door where Roman had vanished, then to Ignatius, who stood next to her as an immovable rock. “I can endure the training. I’ve already survived the fire.”

Ignatius peered down at her. “You’re going to need that momentum later, but for now, get some rest.”

PENANCE

The Council's Chamber was located at the peak of the Cathedral, a room where the walls were made of transparent quartz and the floor was a mosaic of sacred scripture. The structure provided a view of the sprawling campus and acted as a massive spiritual resonator, magnifying every spoken word.

Roman knelt in the center of the mosaic, the Latin of the Psalms biting into his knees. He was no longer the confident protector. Before the members of the Council—men and women whose robes were trimmed with majestic embroidery—he was a subordinate who had allowed his frequency to sync with a natural asset.

Father Thomas leaned forward, his features a map of angular lines and his eyes a steel gray that seemed to look through Roman's flesh into his soul. When he spoke, he carried a shrewd, surgical discernment. "Father Manuel's report is... unorthodox. A Baptism under fire. It is a legal miracle, but a tactical nightmare. We have gained a Citizen, but we have lost a clean Shield."

"I was an anchor for her, Father—I mean, Councilman," he corrected himself, keeping his head bowed. "The Entity

sought to use my presence as leverage. By confessing my... attachment... I removed its power to accuse me.”

“You removed the accusation, but you kept the attachment,” Sister Agatha countered. She was the oldest of the group, her wrinkles draped over a fragile skull that housed an iron-willed intelligence. Her gray habit was pinned at the throat with a garnet cross, and she toyed with an ornate rosary clicking rhythmically against her palm like a ticking clock. “You are a De la Croix. Your family has spent centuries learning to control people. We brought you here for one purpose—to be the stone that breaks the wave. Not to find solace in a broken girl.”

“The wave was drowning her, Sister. I simply gave her a shore to climb onto.”

“And now you are compromised,” Father Thomas sighed, leaning back into his leather wingback, his thin fingers steepled. “The Council has deliberated. Kimberly Woods will transition to the High Yard. She is a Citizen Exception now. She will train with the other Exceptions. She must learn how to sustain the Shield, not hide behind it.”

“And my assignment?” Roman asked, forcing his voice to remain steady despite the spike of dread in his chest.

“You are to be reassigned to the Outer Perimeter,” Sister Agatha declared. “You will guard the salt-lines near the swamps. You need the wind and the rain to remind you of the boundary between the sanctuary and the world. You are forbidden from visiting the High Yard during her recovery.”

“But Councilwoman, she has been severed.” Roman stood up, openly challenging their authority. “She’s in the recovery phase. If I am not there to ground her—”

“If you are there, you are the only ground she knows.” The click of her beads stopped with finality. “She must find refuge in the Kingdom, not the comfort of Roman De la Croix. Your fondness is a crutch. If we let you stay, she will never walk.”

Suddenly, the doors of the chamber opened, and Father Manuel walked in. He gave a slight nod to Roman, whose features tightened with confusion.

The Rector stepped further into the room, carrying a seasoned authority that locked the Council members into immediate attention. “If I may interject on behalf of Mr. De la Croix. The fondness we are speaking of played a pivotal role in saving Miss Woods's life. His action was the care of a Shepherd in charge of the ninety-nine; he risked everything to save the one.”

He stood in front of the board. “It speaks volumes of his character. And yes, the girl will need to learn to stand on her own. But the bond I witnessed during the rite was pure and holy. The poor soul was blessed to have someone who cared as much for her as he did.”

The members were astonished, the truth of the testimony shifting the tension of the room.

“What do you propose?” Sister Agatha inquired.

“Assign the Shield to the outer perimeter for penance if you must.” He offered the boy a subtle wink. “But I want him training alongside Miss Woods immediately. We will leverage this newfound connection for the difficult cases. As we all know from experience, brothers and sisters, darker roads lie ahead.”

Father Thomas leaned back against the wall depicting the broken wing, cold and fixed in stone. “A symphonic pair. It is

risky. If one falls, the other is dragged into the dark. Furthermore, a pair of this kind is a breach of our primary safety protocols. You already know this... We all remember the Gauthier twins. They shared a resonance so unified they could communicate without words. When the devil took the brother, the sister didn't mourn; she became a conduit for the very entity that killed him. She burned down the West Tower before we could seal her. We do not create tethers at Our Lady of Tears; we break them."

"The Gauthier twins were a biological fluke," Father Manuel countered. Roman and Kimberly are a sacramental choice. One is a Ground, the other is... a Flame. Together, they create a circuit the enemy cannot bridge. Treat them as a liability, and they will become one. Forge them into a weapon, and they will be the only thing left standing when our defenses eventually fail. We can train them to be a co-link. If one falls, the other is the only one who can reach into the abyss to pull them back. They are no longer Shield and Asset. They are two citizens of the same Kingdom. Let them train for the fight that is coming."

After a long pause, Sister Agatha nodded to the other members. "Very well."

Father Thomas delivered the final verdict. "Mr. De la Croix will serve his penance at the Outer Perimeter by night, but he will remain Miss Woods's primary tactical partner during her High Yard training. Let us see if this holy bond can withstand the Root's inevitable retaliation."

Roman snapped to attention, his posture locked as his heart hammered with a fierce intensity. This penance served a greater purpose: it would prepare him to fight at her side.

THE HIGH YARD

The High Yard was the lungs of the campus. Embowed by soaring arches of ivory stone, the courtyard's massive mosaic mirrored the astronomical charts of the southern sky—a celestial guide to orient the mind when the world below fell to shadow. For her, the sheer amount of openness was dizzying, a stark contrast to the claustrophobic canopy of the Boudreaux estate.

Sister Alba led the way, her cane clicking with a holy authority.

“You have seen the North Campus, Kimberly. You have also seen the chamber where we sink the noise.” She paused by a fountain where the water flowed over corroded marble. “But you have not seen the basis of our vocation. To understand your place here, you must understand the Law of Tears and the Doctrine of the One Soul.”

She observed the Cathedral's spires, piercing the morning mist like silver needles. “Why Tears?”

“Because every drop of water used to seal your soul was paid for in grief.” She guided her toward the center of the yard, where a magnificent statue of the Blessed Virgin stood, modeled after the visions of Sister Amalia of Campinas. The

Virgin's face was etched with a sorrow so profound it felt heartbreaking.

“This is Our Lady of Tears. In 1930, she and her son, Our Lord Jesus Christ, appeared to a humble sister in Brazil with a specific promise: *'My daughter, what I am asked for the sake of the tears of my Mother, I grant with love.'* At this school, whenever we pray, we utilize the Crown of Tears.”

She reached into the folds of her habit and presented a unique rosary. It was not the standard five-decade string; it consisted of forty-nine white beads, divided into seven groups by seven larger beads.

“This is your weapon.” She pressed the cool necklace into Kimbra’s hand. “The Scramblers use dissonance to fight the noise. They create chaos to hide and bypass the enemy’s signal. But you, Kimberly, are a Chalice. You are intended for a Co-link. You and Roman are to embody the One Soul—the frequency of Christ. When two become one in His name, you do not scramble the air; you restore it. You bring the perfect order of the Creator into a space distorted by the adversary.”

Kimbra gripped the beads, focusing on the statue. “The One Soul... is Jesus?”

“It is the manifestation of His presence through the unified will of two citizens of the Kingdom,” Sister Alba clarified. “The Boudreaux wanted you to be a battery for a demon—a Legacy feeding on your life. The Church wants you to be the chalice for the Living God. To establish the connection, you must first undergo the Heart-Sync prayer.”

“Hey, Newbie! Don't let the architecture swallow you whole.”

Genesis was leaning against a nearby pillar, her uniform cinched tight. She noticed the Crown of Tears in Kimbra's possession and her manner shifted from playful to somber. "Sister, she's really going for the High Rite? Pretty heavy lifting for someone who was a battery forty-eight hours ago."

"Kimberly is not a Scrambler," Sister Alba said firmly. "She will train alongside the Shields. She is learning the Penance of Prayer. If she is to walk with a De la Croix, she must be the stillness to his strength."

Genesis nodded slowly, stepping back into the hidden pocket of the arches. "Good luck, Kim. Roman is out there at the Wall right now. If you're going to be co-linked, you'll feel every bit of the cold he's standing in."

The blind nun gestured for her to kneel on the mosaic of the Stations of the Cross. "Concentrate. Do not look for your music box to hide. Use the melody as a bridge, not a wall. Find the rhythm of the Prayer of Tears."

She recited the words: *"O Jesus, look upon the tears of the One who loved Thee most on earth and the One who loves Thee most ardently in heaven."*

As the prayer left her lips, her scar began to glow with a shimmering gold. She felt her heartbeat slow, matching the rhythmic click of the beads.

Then, the miracle happened. Through the Symphonic Resonance, she felt a tug. It was not the willow-shriek trying to pull her back to the manor. It was a constant, disciplined heartbeat coming from miles away—at the Outer Perimeter. It was Roman.

She felt his exhaustion, the biting cold, and the weight of guilt he was trying to shed. As she held the Crown of Tears,

she met his pain with a deliberate offering of her newfound peace. For a fleeting second, the two of them were not separate people in a war-torn world. They were a single, luminous flame. The One Soul breathed through them, and the air in the High Yard turned sweet and still.

“He feels you.” The nun turned toward the statue. “The link has begun. You are no longer a victim, Kimberly. You are now a servant of the King.”

+ + +

The Outer Perimeter was where the foundation of the architecture gave way to the menace of the swamp. It was a brutal, transitional space—a line of iron fences and salt-fused concrete smelling of stale water and industrial-grade incense. Here, the Sentry’s Penance was a physical reality. The unrelenting pulse of the Boudreaux broadcast served as a persistent reminder that the enemy was always leaning against the gate, looking for a way back into the girl.

Roman stood on the elevated catwalk, his black coat buffeted by the damp gale. His arms were still wrapped in the bandages Sister Marta had applied. He gripped the metal railing. Beside him stood Sebastian, a veteran Shield whose face was a patchwork of scar tissue from decades of grounding the perimeter’s leaks.

“You’re quiet tonight, De la Croix,” Sebastian grunted, his attention fixed on the dark tree line where the cypress knees resembled skeletal fingers.

“Something is off.” He didn’t tell the old man his skin felt like it was being scrubbed with wire. He knew it was the Co-link; it was no longer a secret, but a tactical burden he had to carry.

“It’s the Root. The broadcast has been nonstop since your girl arrived. Boudreaux is looking for a weak spot in the rampart. He’s looking for—” Sebastian grabbed the brass resonance-meter on his belt. He didn’t need to look at the dial—his own jaw clenched as the air ionized.

The surge struck Roman—a blunt blow to the solar plexus. Devoid of the warmth of divine peace, it was the unrefined heat of a link colliding with a power it was not braced to hold. Because Kimbra was only Baptized, the frequency was white-hot steam passing through an unsealed pipe.

His knees buckled, his vision fracturing into shards of blinding sparks. He reeled under the unmediated impact of her raw consciousness—her grief, her sudden hope, and a spiritual frequency vibrating so hard his nose began to bleed.

“Roman!” Sebastian caught him at the waist. “The grounding! Your charge is spiking—it’s too hot!”

Roman gasped for air, his fingers clawing at the railing. This was the danger of the Co-link without the full Sacramental Seal. They were trying to retain the One Soul in vessels still porous. He felt the resonance trying to expand in his chest, pushing against his ribs until he thought they might snap. It was trying to manifest, but without her access to the Eucharist to feed the bond or Confirmation to seal the armor, the power was leaking into his very system.

“I... I feel her,” he managed to choke out, though his heartbeat was fluctuating at an arrhythmic pace.

Across the expanse of the wetlands, the willow-shriek became frenzied. The Boudreaux felt the leak. They felt the power. The murkiness of the marsh water began to boil toward the fence, drawn to the beaming, unsealed flame of the Co-link like moths to a blowtorch.

“She’s open, Roman!” Sebastian lunged for the distributor lever. “She’s broadcasting without a shield! If you don’t stabilize this right now, you’re going to lead them straight to her!”

Roman bit his lip until he tasted copper. Rejecting the instinct to push back, he fought to maintain control of the turbulent frequency. He suffered through the agony of the connection, straining to find her unstable spark in the High Yard. He had to anchor a ship caught in a holy gale.

“Be still.” The words were meant for both of them.

“Kimbra... breathe with me... Don’t let it all out at once.”

The pressure in his chest eased enough to let him stand. He was exhausted, trembling from the overwhelming surge, but the circuit remained.

His face was pale and sweat-beaded. “It was... a false start.”

Sebastian eyed the ruined resonance-meter, wisps of smoke still rising from the casing. “It was a disaster waiting to happen. If she’s going to be your partner, she needs the remaining sacraments. Cause the next time the broadcast hits, it won’t knock you down—it’ll fry you both.”

THE PRODIGAL DAUGHTER

The transition from day to night at the High Yard was a solemn affair; it was the hour when the Vespers of the Wall began, a soothing chanting from the monks in the lower cloister acting as a secondary seal for the outer limits.

The two girls were perched on the edge of the western balcony, legs dangling over the side. Below them, the world surrendered to shadows, save for the distant pulse of the Perimeter lanterns flickering to life. Those burning beacons illuminated the dark—Roman's world.

Genesis was twisting a rosary ring on her finger, the metal band clicking in her lap. "You're thinking about him again, aren't you? The Shield is in the mud, Kim. He's fine. De la Croix men were built for the grime; they've been wading through it for two hundred years to keep their boots clean in the Garden District."

"I just... I worry I'm the reason he's out there." She pulled the sleeve of her shirt back, her fingers tracing the scar. It felt cold tonight—a dormant, metallic sensation reminding her of a dead circuit.

Genesis froze, her fingers stilling on the ring as she turned toward the Marian Statue in the center of the yard, where the Virgin's stone eyes seemed to weep with the evening dew. "We're all the reason someone is out there, Kim. That's the school's whole deal. We're the Exceptions because we invited something in requiring a holy eviction. Some of us opened the door wider than others."

"I remember you said you were in the choir," Kimbra said softly, steering the conversation away from her own guilt.

"I'm the prodigal daughter." Genesis let out a short, nervous laugh. "Truthfully, the apathetic Catholic is more accurate. I didn't cherish my faith; I treated it like a pair of socks I kicked off. I was the girl in the front row with the loudest voice and the emptiest soul. I got bored. Bored of the incense smelling like old dust, bored of the Liturgy feeling like a script I'd memorized but never understood. I wanted to see if the other side had a better venue. I wanted a song that belonged to me, not to the Church."

She leaned back against a pillar etched with the names of forgotten saints.

"I started small. Ouija boards in damp suburban basements, blaming a draft for the planchette's crawl. Then a flea market tarot deck. I thought I was being edgy, playing with the forbidden like a toy. But it's never a game, Kim. You don't play with the occult; it plays with you. It's a cunning intelligence waiting for a hole to exploit. And when you fall, you're the one left with an empty bag."

"What happened?"

"A girl named Chloe from my Drama class... She was jealous I'd danced with her ex at homecoming—that ugly,

green jealousy. She was crazy. She saw me dabbling in astrology and reading the Potter series, so she decided to give me a push. She went to a coven on the outskirts of Metairie. She used Vodou—the nasty, evil mojo feeding on pride. She didn't want to kill me; she wanted me to go insane so I'd stop singing. She turned my own curiosity into a key.”

Genesis instinctively grazed the tattoo behind her ear, a permanent mark covering a scar from her own severance.

“I left the door unlocked with my lack of faith, and Chloe kicked it open. One night, the voice I had wasn't mine anymore. I wasn't singing hymns; I was screaming in languages that made the stained glass in my parish crack. It felt like hot lead being poured down my throat. It was a violent, screaming takeover. I was a puppet with my own vocal cords used as strings.”

“Is that why you're a Scrambler?”

A moment of silence passed as she bowed her head in shame. “The Church pulled me out of a state hospital ward where I was a case file and a sedated zombie. Father Manuel and a few others performed the Severance Rite. They burned the tethers—the cards, the boards, the books—until nothing remained but smoke. But the eviction left me... off-key. A fractured frequency. I'm a broken bird. I can't sing for the pews anymore; I can only scramble the air... So, they taught me how to use it to hunt. I call myself the Sonic Saboteur because I know exactly how it feels to have your own soul used as a broadcast tower. I don't mess with the cards anymore. I don't search for answers in the New Age channels. In here, we're taught to seek the Lord, or we get lost in the noise.”

Tears pooled in Genesis's eyes—the first crack Kimbra had ever seen in her armor. Her jade facade vanished, exposing a trembling contrition. The confession caught in her throat before spilling out: “That’s the beauty behind the Law of Tears. The thing washing the stain of the occult is the weeping of our Sorrowful Mother.”

The evening bells began to toll—the Angelus—rumbling through the balcony. Kimbra thought of the Music Box melody—the only thing the Boudreaux hadn't been able to overwrite. It was her only pure frequency.

“I spent ten years as a bystander in my own horror story,” she said, her voice steadying as she stared into the darkness. “I’ve been the Debt, the Hearth, the Blood Lily, and the Asset. I refuse to be a victim anymore. If the One Soul breaks the bonds of my past, I will learn to sustain it.”

Genesis smirked, her posture hardening as the sun dipped below the rim. “Good. Because your enemy hasn't stopped hunting you. To them, your baptism is a breach of contract. And to the faculty? You're a trial run. They're already strategizing your first deployment to see if your co-link can hold a line when the enemy starts to climb the walls.”

“With Roman?”

“Yes...But remember the rule of the Chalice: don't look for his hand. He's the ground, meant to take the shock. But you're the lightning. If you don't strike true, if you hesitate even for a second, he's the one who gets burned. He'll melt into the mud to keep you standing, but a melted rod can't protect anyone.”

Kimbra shivered slightly, her eyes drifting toward the heavy oak doors that led back into the main corridor of the

High Yard. “And what about the other members of the faculty? Sister Alba... she terrifies me. It’s like she can see right through your skin, down into every bad thought you’ve ever had. But her eyes are completely white. How does she know exactly where we’re standing?”

Genesis let out a short, dry chuckle, a mischievous glint returning to her eyes. “Oh, Sister Alba is a whole different brand of lethal. You should be scared of her. Everyone is. You want some real tea on the blind wonder?”

“What do you mean?”

“Rumor has it that before she took her vows and put on that habit, Sister Alba wasn't exactly praying the rosary. She was a high-ranking witch in one of the old, brutal covens deep in the switchgrass of the Atchafalaya basin. She didn't just dabble like I did; she was their mastermind.”

Kimbra’s breath caught. “A witch? Then how is she a nun here?”

“Because she flew too close to the sun... They say she conjured a spell so massive, so entrenched with malice, that the feedback loop nearly tore her soul apart. It left her in a comatose state—completely broken. The Church swooped in and miraculously healed her body, but the evil magic she practiced left its receipt. When she finally woke up, the price of her dark ritual was waiting for her. Her eyes were completely burned out. She lost her physical sight to the very storm she unleashed.”

Genesis twisted her ring, looking toward the empty yard. “The Academy converted her expertise. That’s why her nonsense attitude with the demonic is most effective. She knows every shortcut, every sigil, and every lie the Entity will

spew, because she used to write the script. When Sister stands in front of a manifestation, she isn't just defending the Church—she's scrutinizing Satan. The enemy doesn't trip her up because she's already walked his damned path.”

Kimbra stood, her robes settling over her frame with the stiff rigidity of armor. She fixed her gaze on the flickering flames of the Perimeter, processing the sheer weight of the people guarding this place. Shedding the ghost of the girl in the tower, she was learning how to become a weapon in a war she was only beginning to understand.

MONSTERS IN THE DARK

At the Outer Perimeter, the boundary between the consecrated and the corrupt was marked by more than iron. Every fifty yards, a gold-plated brazier burned with a low, greenish flame—the Fire of Discernment. Fueled by oil infused with blessed minerals, it was designed to sway or dim whenever a foreign frequency, an uninvited guest, leaned against the fortress’s spiritual hide. The flames acted as a silent choir of sentries, their movements reflecting the invisible pressure of the Root’s malice.

Roman walked the ramparts, his boots crunching on the loose salt and bitter frost blanketing the border. His utilitarian coat was buttoned to his chin, a heavy wool barrier against the supernatural chill rising from the water below. His hands were encased in leather gloves embroidered with protective symbols. The penance was a physical mortification; the cold was bone-deep, and the isolation was a cavernous ache in his chest.

He missed her.

He felt a constant, erratic throbbing in the space where she should be—a phantom limb of the spirit. Without Kimbra’s proximity, his soul became a piano with a missing

middle C—the harmony imbalanced, the circuit incomplete. Because of their unsealed Co-link, he lived as a man with two heartbeats. One was in his own ribs, while the other was a new throb, hidden miles away in a tall ivory tower. The connection was a ghost-wire, invisible but taut, stretching across the campus.

“Signal’s spiking at Post Four, De la Croix!” a fellow guard called from the observation point. The warning was thin and brittle, easily torn apart by the rising wind.

He did not hesitate. Darting toward the fourth brazier, his shadow stretching long and distorted across the platform, he watched the flame flicker. It leaned outward, drawn toward an invisible lung on the opposite side of the boundary—a spiritual displacement, a hungry void reaching for the warmth of human soul to fill its own lack.

He leaned over the battlement, his grip tightening until the frost of the iron bled through his gloves. The mist hung thick and pea-soup gray, swirling in a deliberate pattern—a slow-motion whirlpool of spiritual rot.

Damian.

He could feel it—a pathetic thread of willow-shriek, a spider’s web drifting through the air. The encounter carried only the hungry, desperate whine of a starving beast. The famine had begun. Without Kimbra anchoring him as his Hearth, Damian’s essence reeled, his signature unraveling into a chaotic discharge. The family was sending out feelers, hunting for the Blood Lily they had lost—a desperate reach into the ether for the battery keeping their legacy from extinction.

A shape materialized in the muck—a scout forged from sulfuric gas and the oily, discarded memories of the sinister manor. It manifested as a distorted, translucent version of Damian, reduced to empty pits of black and white static, a dying television screen flickering in the night. Its mouth tore open a gap in the mist, a weeping sound struggling to form words.

“Where... is... she?” the thing hissed, causing the loose salt on the ramparts to skitter in discordant heaps.

He pulled a gold-tipped spear from the rack. The metal was cold, but it droned with a low, defensive vibration traveling up his arms and settling in the center of his chest. “She’s beyond your reach, Slave. She belongs to the Kingdom now.”

“We are... hungry. The Root... demands... its Lily. The Legacy... must... feed. We are... fading...” The mist around it shifted, taking the shape of razor claws scratching at the wall’s surface.

“Then let it starve,” Roman snapped.

Suddenly, a distinct tension bloomed at the base of his skull, radiating down his spine.

Kimbra.

Across the campus in the St. Benedict Tower, she gripped the Crown of Tears Rosary, sending the connection crashing into him—a surge of unshielded electricity. He felt her nervous system ignite, her heart syncing with his across the distance. Lacking her final seal, she channeled an unrefined current—a high-voltage surge without a regulator. Rather than the peace of a prayer, it delivered the violent, protective heat of a furnace.

Her fear, her resolve, and her unmanaged power poured through the Co-link, flooding his senses. No longer a mere guard, he became a conduit for a divine force he lacked the proper bracing to maintain. His muscles locked, his vision sharpening until every ripple in the muddy water below stood clear.

He struck the spear into the earth. The tip erupted into a shockwave of energy fueled by their bond. The blast sent a literal wall of electrified energy down into the dirt, a golden scythe cutting through the gray mist. The scout shrieked, a collision of scraping metal and breaking glass, as its gaseous form dissipated into the dingy water, leaving behind only the rotten scent of scorched iron and sulfur.

The flame in the brazier remained flickering toward the dark edges of the wall, a sign of mounting pressure on the other side. The Boudreaux had felt the link. They had tasted the One Soul, and now they knew exactly where the breach in the fortress was located.

Father Manuel appeared at the top of the deck, the hairs of his beard shimmering in the moonlight. His face showed grave concern as he inspected the smoking tip of the spear.

“They know she’s here. They’re testing the wall’s integrity. They felt the power. They know she’s trying to ground herself through you, and they know the connection is still unsealed.”

“The static was hot, Father,” Roman said, his breath coming in uneven gasps clouding in the numbing air. “I was almost electrocuted.”

“Which is why your training starts tomorrow. The Co-link is not a theory anymore; it’s an active frequency bleeding into the world. But without the seal of the other sacraments, she

is a live wire, and you are an exposed rod. If you don't learn to manage the One Soul power, if you can't temper that heat, the next time she reaches for you, you'll both go up in flames."

He could feel the vibration of Kimbra's heartbeat, a pleasant reminder of the life he was now bound to. "Is she ready?"

"She's finding her own standing." The priest's attention veered toward the gloomy tree line. "The question is, are you ready to be the one who takes the hit if she fails? Are you willing to be the melting Shield so the Chalice can stay pure?"

Roman focused on the Cathedral spires in the distance, where the Sanctuary Lamp burned, a single ruby illuminating the midnight sky.

"I've been taking hits since the day I met her. I'm not stopping now."

PLAN B

Eleven miles away, the Boudreaux Manor had shed its palace prestige, reduced to a house of mourning and decay.

The study, once a place of esoteric knowledge, was in ruins. The remnant of veins etched into the wall—the psychic chart Vincent used to track his assets through the wetlands—had burst into flames the moment the third pour of water hit Kimbra’s forehead. The smell of charred parchment and sulfur filled the room, a thick, suffocating haze clinging to the velvet curtains like dense silt.

Damian sat in the center of the Persian rug, his head thrown back, a dismal glare frozen on his face. The tether connecting his marrow to Kimbra’s for a decade had recoiled, a snapped whip lashing back into his own chest and leaving a strip of spectral frost across his ribs.

“Damian!” Vincent lunged for his son.

The boy slumped over, his skin turning the deathly, translucent gray of a corpse left in the rain. The trail of veins that had once flowed with stolen vitality turned to ash. He was experiencing a Soul-Shock. For eleven years, he had lived on the interest of a life-debt, and now, the blood bank was off

limits. Without the constant feeding from her essence, his own heart, defective from birth, was erratic—a faltering percussion threatening to stop entirely.

“It’s gone, Father.” His voice was a thin wheeze. “The line... severed. Burned. I can still feel the place where she used to be, but there’s... nothing.”

Vincent was oozing with calculated fury. He stared at the charred map on the wall. He did not need the tether to know where she was. Only one place in Louisiana had the power to sever a Sanguine ritual with such holy, surgical precision. Only one fortress was paved in enough salt to drown the shriek of the Blood Lily.

He stood by the floor-to-ceiling window, looking toward the distant, hidden spires of the St. Benedict Tower. He held a bronze chalice, but the liquid inside churned as if it were boiling, reacting to the sudden vacuum in the family’s power.

“The Church thinks a scoop of river water can overwrite a contract,” he said, his voice a low, dangerous vibration making the windows rattle. “They have shielded her behind the Laws of their God. They believe they’ve won because they’ve hidden our Lily.”

“Haven’t they?” Damian trembled as he held a glass of water, his fingers lacking the strength to even grip the crystal. “The hunger is turning inward. It’s devouring me.”

“Then we change the menu,” Vincent snapped, turning away from the window, a malevolence bordering on the manic igniting his gaze. “The Sanguine Law is reasonable, Damian. It dictates a Master must have a Hearth to anchor his power. It does not dictate the Hearth must remain the same forever.”

He walked to the desk and unrolled a hidden scroll—the *Codex of the Grafted Vine*. The parchment was so old it groaned, the wet ink scuttling across the page like trapped insects. “There is a loophole.” His finger traced the script. *“The bylaw of the Replacement. If a Hearth is stolen or corrupted, the Master may graft his line onto a temporary vessel—a Proxy—to sustain the pulse until the original can be reclaimed.* It is a violent process, abrasive and volatile, but it will keep you alive.”

Damian sat up slowly. “A proxy? But who? It took you years to groom Kimbra. Doesn’t the resonance have to be perfect?”

“I have already made the arrangements.” Vincent gestured toward the door, which creaked open. “A girl from the outer covens. No, she is not a perfect match to your signature like Kimberly, but she is willing. She has been promised a seat at our table and a share of the Legacy in exchange for her vitality.”

The figure stepped into the dim haze. She was draped in a bright red hooded cloak obscuring her face, but the air around her circulated with a chaotic energy. She did not have Kimbra's grace or innocence; she was a fierce and seductive broadcast—a biting edge compared to their Lily's silk.

She slid the hood back, letting a cascade of dark hair fall over her shoulders. Her eyes locked onto Damian with an unholy eagerness. She stalked toward him like a venomous snake, the hem of her cloak brushing against the rug.

Damian looked up, his breathing shallow, but as she knelt before him, his gaze darkened with a sudden interest. He

didn't shrink away from the potency radiating off her skin; he basked in it.

She wrapped her slender arms around his neck, pulling him down into an intoxicating kiss. It was aggressive, laced with a consuming lust that made the air in the room grow thick and heavy. Damian accepted the corrupted life-force—relishing in it, his hands wrapping firmly into her hair, pulling her closer as if trying to consume her entire flesh. The entity inside him responded with a roaring approval. A sinister wave of recognition flooded his senses—a silent homecoming as the force inside him surged to meet hers.

He gasped, his back arching off the floor as a fervent surge of vitality rushed into his marrow. It was not the clean, resolute peace he had become acquainted with—it was the stinging turbulence of a parasite latching on, fueled by a breathless passion—but it was life.

The trails on his neck, which had been gray and ashy, flared a bold crimson. He stood up, his movements fluid and sharp for the first time in days, pulling the girl up with him. He kept her close, his thumb tracing her lower lip as she smiled up at him with a wicked satisfaction.

“It’s... different,” he muttered, his voice dropping to a low, carnal rasp as he tested his limbs. “It’s louder. More aggressive. I can feel... her hunger.”

“It is enough,” Vincent said, a crooked smile spreading across his thin lips. “She will sustain you while we prepare for the Harvest. The graft is complete, and the proxy has provided us with exactly what we needed: a homing beacon.”

He pointed to another map spread across the desk. A small dot had manifested near the northern boundary, right where the walls of the institute met the swamp.

“They hid her soul, but we have caught her signature. She is at the Academy, behind their stone walls, playing at being a student, thinking she is safe because a priest said a prayer.”

Damian chuckled, pulling the hooded girl into his lap, his fingers digging into her waist. Kimberly's pure memory was completely drowned out by the hot, violent static of the vessel currently in his arms. “Let her play... She thinks she cut the wire, but she only gave us a reason to reinforce it. I can feel her heartbeat, Father. A distant, fragile thing. I'll reclaim what is mine. I'll ravish her then plant my seed in her body.”

Vincent nodded, his gaze returning to the girl, who had wrapped herself around Damian like a vine, her fingers tracing the newly revived veins on his neck. “We have what we need. Now, we prepare the covenant. The Academy wanted a war of Laws; we will give them a war in blood.”

MIDNIGHT SOLACE

The Academy was asleep, or as close to sleep as a fortress of perpetual prayer ever got. Kimbra tiptoed through the desolate halls, her bare feet pressed against the cold floor. She felt a pull—not the tug of the tether, but a firm, magnetic gravity drawing her toward the mysterious light at the end of the corridor.

She stopped at the entrance of the Adoration Chapel. Above them, the Sanctuary Lamp burned—a ruby-red glow signaling the Living God within. The flickering flame cast long, maroon shadows across the white walls, turning the foyer into the chamber of a living heart.

She did not enter. Roman had warned her of spiritual shock—the boiling oil of a formerly tethered soul confronting the Presence. Despite her recent emergency baptism, she wasn't prepared for this kind of purity. She stood at the threshold instead, letting the divine radiation permeating the door wash over her. *She wanted to stay forever.*

It was the sole place in which the evil whispers dissipated, replaced by an undeniable peace.

“It’s the only heart in the building that will never stop beating.”

Kimbra did not flinch. She had begun to recognize the cadence of his step, the sudden grounding of atmospheric current. She turned to find Roman in his full patrol gear, standing a few feet behind her. He appeared haggard, the biting cold of the Perimeter still clinging to the fabric of his coat, his hair damp with the mist of the swamp.

“I thought you were at the Wall.”

“My shift ended an hour ago.” He stepped into the red glow, maintaining a respectful distance. “I usually come here before I head back to my dormitory. It helps... recalibrate the senses. The Wall has a way of making you forget what you're guarding. You start to see the monsters, and lose sight of the light you're protecting.”

“Genesis said you think you owe God a debt. She said you're trying to be a martyr to pay it off.”

“Hm.” He leaned against the rail, his gaze fixed on the door. “She can be dramatic.” A distant tolling from the lower cloister held the moment—a mournful tone anchoring the stillness of the night. “You remember when you asked me why I didn't leave you at the gate?”

She nodded, her breathing gradually matching his slow and steady pace.

“Because I left someone behind once.” The confession fell from his lips. “I spent the majority of my life in a world of power and prestige. The De la Croix name was a pretense I used to hide from the truth. I lived for the party, for the luxury, for the absolute cowardice of social standing. I saw someone who needed me—a girl who had been caught in the crosshairs of my father's business dealings. But I chose my

reputation over her life. I walked away because helping her would've been a betrayal to my family."

He crossed his arms, his gaze dropping to the floor as a heavy, silent flush of regret took over.

"She died because I was afraid of losing my seat at the table. I traded my old life for this uniform—for penance and prayer—so I would never have to walk away again. Helping you was the only way I could stand the sight of my own reflection."

The energy between them changed. She didn't see the iron-willed guardian; she saw the man beneath the uniform, a soul trying to find its way home through the wreckage of his own past.

"You're not that person anymore, Roman." She took a cautious half-step toward him. "A coward wouldn't stand at the wall until his hands bled from the cold."

"I'm the one who's going to make sure you stay alive," he said, his eyes meeting hers. "But if we are to become a successful Co-link, there can be no secrets between us. No hidden compartments. We must be transparent as glass."

He closed the gap, sheltering her in the intimate space. "If I am to ground you, I need to know the severity of the interference. When you think of him... when you think of Damian... what do you feel? Is it only fear? Or is the wire still pulling... or is it something else?"

Kimbra froze.

The question was a probe into the most sensitive part of her trauma.

She tried to find words untainted by his influence. "For ten years, he was the only person I thought loved me. He was

my family—the only constant I’ve ever known. My parents abandoned me, and I was left with no one but him. He owned my thoughts, my body, and my soul, even if it was through a ritual or a wire—even if it was theft. It’s a pathetic sickness, I know... but when you spend a decade as someone’s battery, you start to mistake the current for a heartbeat. I hate him for what he is, but a part of me... feels the terrifying emptiness where he used to be.”

“You’re not pathetic, Kim.” His leather gloves were gone, discarded on the floor. His bare fingers were warm as he brushed a stray strand of hair from her cheek, his thumb lingering against her face with a tenderness that made her breath hitch. “It was the Graft. He tried to make you believe you were part of him, that you couldn’t exist without the pain of losing him. But he was a parasite. I am your partner. There’s a difference between being used and being unified. We choose this of our own free will.”

“If we’re going to train for the Co-link, we have to trust each other implicitly.” He gazed into her eyes, searching for the signature of her true self beneath the scars. “Do you trust me with your life? With the frequency of your very soul?”

“You’re asking me?” Kimbra smiled—a small, genuine gesture breaking the oppressive tension of the hallway. “The man who saved me from the gate, who kept me from being consumed by the entity? Yes. Of course I trust you.”

“Then I promise I’ll stay by your side,” he affirmed. “I’ll battle those demons with you, no matter how dark it gets. You’re no longer a battery for his Legacy.” He pointed at the door, or rather what stood beyond it. “You’re a Chalice for His.”

Kimbra leaned her head against his shoulder, the exuding warmth from the chapel bathing them both. She felt the pulse of his heartbeat—disciplined and fiercely protective. For a few minutes, there was no wall, and no scary monsters. There was only the solace of the night and the rhythm of two hearts beating as one.

PURITY HAS
SUCH A VALUE

The Scramblers and Shields were gathered in the amphitheater of the High Yard. In the middle of the dense morning fog stood the Rector, his priestly cassock rustling against the pavement as he paced before a large, weathered tapestry.

The fabric depicted a single flame—the Sacred Heart—shared between two kneeling figures whose silhouettes were intertwined by a luminous thread.

Roman stood next to Ignatius at the front, his posture bold and militant. Kimbra sat a few rows back with Genesis, the cold of the stone bench seeping through her robes. In her lap lay a small, leather-bound book—her Catechumen’s Manual. The page trim caught the first sliver of morning sun, a reminder of her journey toward Confirmation.

It was a path she now realized was a tactical necessity for her survival.

Father Manuel paused before the students, his voice cutting through the chill with the sharpness of a bell. “You look at the tuning forks and the training equipment, and you think this is a science. You think a Co-link is merely a

synchronization of heartbeats, a biological trick of the blood. You are wrong.”

He locked his focus onto Kimbra with an intensity that quickened her heart. *“Purity has such a value. And when two or more are gathered in His Name...”*

He stepped closer. “The enemy wanted you, Kimberly, because they recognized a design they could never replicate. They saw an extraordinary phenomenon—a soul crafted by the Greater Architect to be a Chalice of His pure Love. Satan didn’t create your power; He tried to exploit the favor God placed upon you. The Root wanted to use the flame within you to fuel their own perversion, to turn a divine gift into a sacrilegious engine.”

He gestured to the embroidered canvas, the flaming heart appearing to pulse in the shifting haze. “To defend that Love, we use the Co-link. Repeat the Axiom.”

The students spoke in a low, resolute drone vibrating throughout the theater:

“A Co-link is not two souls standing together; it is the union of the one Lord Jesus Christ, King of Kings, inhabiting two bodies. Any darkness in the heart of one becomes a poison in the veins of the other.”

“To inhabit the Soul of the Master, you must first be empty of yourselves,” Father Manuel said. “In 1842, Sister Clara and Brother Elias held back a massive flood and saved an entire village through their combined effort. Through deep meditative prayer done in unison, they became a single, unbreakable bond. But in 1978, a link shattered because a Shield held a secret grudge. He not only failed; he profaned the sanctuary they had built. He was scorched from the inside

out because the Light of the Master cannot coexist within the shadow of a lie.”

Kimbra recognized the rigidity in Roman’s stance. She wondered if he was thinking of the girl he had left behind, the guilt he was still carrying.

“Kimberly.” Father Manuel moved toward her until he stood at the edge of the circle. “You were destined to be a Chalice, but currently, your own temple is unguarded. You were baptized in an emergency—pulled from the water, plucked from the fire. You now have the indelible mark upon your soul, but you’ve yet to be Confirmed—you haven’t been sealed by the Holy Spirit. And more importantly, you have not yet received the Eucharist—the literal fuel for the One Soul to manifest. Without the Precious Body and Blood to sustain the circuit, any sync you attempt will be holding a sun in a plastic jar.”

He stepped off the mosaic. “Today, we will attempt a Low-Sync. No wires. Just the touch. Roman, Kimberly—to the center.”

As they positioned themselves into the circle, the world around them dissipated until there was only the heat radiating between them. Roman extended his hands. White clinical gauze ran tight from his wrists to his elbows, masking the burns beneath, his fingers holding steady despite the raw ache in his nerves.

“Remember, trust is the conductor, Kim, but until you’re fully sealed and fed by the Sacrament, the current is going to feel... incomplete. Don’t fight the emptiness. Let the flow move through the gaps.”

She placed her hands in his.

The moment they connected, the One Soul ignited. It was a massive presence. She felt the warmth of Divine Love stir in her chest—the very flame Vincent had tried to harness and steal for his family's legacy. But the connection dwindled. Without the sacraments to anchor the power and seal the vessel, the energy had no ground. It poured from her, a steady bleed through a cracked jar.

It was a preview—a connection wanting to be a roar but remaining a desperate whisper. The feedback was a dull, aching thrum in her scar, a sensation of being stretched too thin. Roman winced, locking his jaw as he fought to ground the leakage through his damaged nerves.

“It’s like... trying to cup a bare flame,” Kimbra gasped, her fingers trembling as she recoiled from the heat.

“That is to be expected. You have the mark of our King, Kimberly, but you do not yet have the full armor of His Church. You are a Citizen in name, but you are not yet a Soldier in His power.” Father Manuel looked toward the Outer Perimeter, where the tree line haze was transforming into a sickly shade of purple, churning with a vicious momentum. “The Boudreaux know this. They know you are in the middle of a transformation. And they are not going to stop for its completion. They will strike while the glass is still brittle.”

+ + +

The Scriptorium was a refuge of old books and stale frankincense. The moonlight filtered through the narrow windows, casting long yellow bars across tables polished by centuries of use. It was here they spent their evenings, tucked away from the scrutiny of the Council and the restless energies of the High Yard.

Roman sat across from Kimbra. They were studying the Catechumen's Manual, tracking the truths she needed to internalize before she could undergo the final Rite.

"The faculty usually assigns a Sister to act as a sponsor for female students, but Father insisted that because of the Co-link, I should be the one to guide you. He says a Shield must know the architecture of the Chalice he is grounding, and that our synchronization must develop in the mind before it can reach the spirit."

She traced the lettering on the page, the texture of the paper rough against her fingertips. "Is that what I am to you, Architecture?"

His expression softened in the amber glow of the candle. "No. You're the reason the architecture exists. A temple is only rubble and mortar until the Real Presence enters it. Without the inhabitant, the building has no purpose."

He turned the page to the section on the Sacrament of Confirmation.

"When you were baptized, you were claimed. You were pulled from the enemy's grasp. But when you are confirmed, you are commissioned. You'll receive the Seven Gifts of the Holy Spirit. For a Shield, the most vital is Fortitude. It's the spiritual armor protecting your soul, preventing the leak we felt today."

“And the Eucharist? Father Manuel said it was the fuel for the bond.”

“It’s more than fuel. It’s a physical union.” Roman leaned forward across the table, his shadow stretching against the stone wall. “In a Co-link, we aren’t two people working together. When we receive the Eucharist, we carry the same Life within us. We truly become one body, two separate candles united by one flame... If we both have the Master dwelling within us, the Boudreaux cannot find a gap to enter. We become a seamless garment, a single point of entry they cannot breach.”

For years, she had been filled by Damian’s static. The idea of being imbued by something holy—something that didn’t take, but gave—was almost terrifying in its selflessness.

“I’m afraid,” she admitted. “What if I’m not pure enough? What if the shadow Father Manuel talked about is still in me, hidden in a corner I can’t see? What if I poison the link because of what they did to me? I was his Blood Lily for years. I don’t know how to be a Chalice.”

Roman hunched over the table and took both of her hands, his palms covering hers, a physical safety net against the rising tides of her anxiety. “Purity is not the absence of a past, Kim. It’s the direction of the heart.”

His gaze held hers, his conviction balancing her fear. “The Sacred Heart doesn’t look at the scars the Boudreaux left behind; It looks at the girl choosing to stand against them. I am your Sponsor. That means I take an oath before the Church to help carry your burdens. If there is a shadow in you, I will stand in the Light until it fades. That is what a Shield does. We take the burn so the Chalice can stay pure.”

A peaceful calm settled over the room. For the first time, the Co-link ceased to be a tactical burden or a dangerous experiment. It was a real promise—a covenant between two souls who had both known the dark.

“I want to be ready,” she said, her resolve hardening. “I want to be sealed. I want to be able to look at Damian and feel nothing.”

“You will be,” Roman promised, his thumb grazing her knuckles. “But tonight, we review the basics. Let’s start with the Apostles’ Creed. This isn’t just a list of beliefs. For us, these are the coordinates of the Kingdom. This is how we find our way home when the fog rolls in and the enemy tries to scramble the map.”

As they began to pray the words together, their voices synchronized in the candle-lit room, the true bond was taking form.

THE PULSE OF
THE PROXY

The following afternoon, the sun filtered through the stained glass windows of the Scriptorium. Kimbra sat at the elongated table, her fingers tracing the Latin vowels of the Apostles' Creed. Beside her, Roman meticulously sharpened a pencil, cutting the silence with a dry scratch of wood against blade.

"Father Manuel said that for the Confirmation, I have to choose a Patron Saint," she said, her eyes drifting toward the icon of the Blessed Mother near the archway. "He said I need a name to carry into the last Seal—a secondary anchor."

The pencil was set down, turning his full attention to her while maintaining a careful distance—the mechanical ground Ignatius had advised him to keep between them. "It's an important decision. At Our Lady of Tears, your Patron is not solely a namesake. They are the specific frequency you choose to resonate with. When the noise gets too loud and I'm not there to ground you, your Patron is the rock you lean on."

"How do you even choose? Genesis told me she chose Saint Cecilia because she wanted to sing. Ignatius chose Saint James the Greater—the one who stands firm."

“James the Greater—the son of thunder,” he said, a faint smile breaking his disciplined expression. “It fits his nature. And mine is Saint Michael. I chose the Archangel because he is the Prince of the Heavenly Host, the one who stands between the Light and the void. My task is to secure the perimeter, and Saint Michael is the ultimate sentry.” He leaned slightly forward, the shifting sunlight catching the warm, protective depth of his eyes. “Who do you feel calling to you? Don't think about the history. Think about their virtue.”

She thought about the un-owned vacuum she had felt since the Snap. She thought about the ten years she had spent as a vessel—a battery for someone else's life. She didn't want to belong to the Root anymore, but she did not want to be an empty space, either.

“The Blessed Virgin Mary.”

His breath hitched, his posture momentarily losing its rigid discipline. To choose the Mother was to choose the most powerful Shield the Academy recognized—the *Speculum Iustitiae*.

“The Virgin,” he repeated. “Why her?”

“Because she was the first to hold the Light without being used as a tool to stand against it,” she replied, her fingers tracing the dormant scar on her arm. “She was the one the enemy couldn't ruin because she was completely full of the other side. There was no hole in her for them to whistle through. If I take her name... if I become Mary at the altar... I will never be a vessel for Damian again. I'll be a soul belonging entirely to God, and if I truly belong to Him, the demons can't ever claim a single piece of me.”

He gripped the edge of the table, his proximity acting as a silent vow. “If you take her name, the Lily the Boudreaux created will be overwritten. You won't be a bridge for them anymore. You'll be a fortress—set apart and sealed forever.”

She nodded, the decision settling into her bones as a foundation. A flicker of the peace she had experienced in the Perpetual Adoration Chapel returned to her.

“Mary,” she whispered, testing the name against the silence of the room.

The moment the name left her lips, the hard-won stillness of the Scriptorium disappeared, overcome by a sudden, sickening drop in atmospheric pressure. The ink of the Apostles' Creed twisted into living thorns, crawling across the vellum.

Roman felt it first. As her Sponsor and Ground, his nervous system triggered like a struck bell. A familiar, metallic taste flooded his mouth—the unmistakable sulfur tang of a breach. He stood up so abruptly his chair slammed against the floorboards. “Get away from the window!”

She remained frozen. Outside, the mist had turned purple, pressing against the reinforced glass with a cruel, relentless intensity, taking the distorted shape of screaming faces that vanished as quickly as they formed.

The Boudreaux's new Proxy was broadcasting a signal meticulously designed to mimic the Hearth tether she had lived with for ten years—a Trojan Horse trying to trick her soul into reopening the door it had only begun to bolt.

“He's... he's calling me!” She covered her ears.

The willow-shriek was back, but it was no longer a low-grade pulse. It was layered with the new Proxy's turbulent

chaos—an abrasive, unmanaged signal of hot needles stitching themselves directly into her frontal lobe. It bypassed her ears entirely, pounding inside her head:

“Come back to the Root, little bird. The shield is a cage. Holiness is a desert. Come back to the garden where the soil is warm...”

Roman lunged across the table, his boots slipping on the polished wood as he pulled her down. The moment his hands locked around her, the static from her unsealed soul hit his gauze-wrapped arms like live wires dropped in water. The Proxy’s broadcast jumped the gap, tearing through the clinical dressings, scorching his flesh from wrist to elbow.

A blinding white flash detonated behind his retinas as his burned nerves misfired all at once, feeling as if molten lead were being injected directly into the tissue. His vision went completely gray at the edges. Yet, his posture locked into a military-grade resistance—his jaw clamping shut to choke back a scream as he forced himself to hold her tight against the floor.

“It’s a broadcast, Kim! It’s a parasitic lie!” he gritted out through clenched teeth, his entire physique trembling under the lethal charge of the feedback. “Look at me—focus on the link!”

The static singed directly into her scar, turning the tissue from dormant white to a burning, angry purple.

“I can’t... I can’t even scramble it!” Her body violently trembling under his grip as her vision fractured. “There’s no escape from it... the signal is just sheer anger!”

The glass in the windows began to spider-web, the cracks blooming in the frost. The sanctified scent of frankincense

was replaced by the acrid smell of scorched paper and old decay. The peaceful quiet they had built throughout the day was completely drowned by the aggressive noise seeking to overwrite her new identity.

Suddenly, the doors of the Scriptorium burst open, the iron hinges groaning. Father Manuel and Sister Alba entered, their movements swift and practiced. Their rosaries were held out like metal swords in the dimming light, the beads clicking with a solid, protective energy as the Rector began to chant the *Sub Tuum Praesidium* as a counterattack to the shriek.

“Roman! Cover her! She’s a relay tower! If she doesn’t anchor, she’ll broadcast their signal to the entire West Wing!”

He wrapped his weight entirely around her, sinking lower to the stone floor. He ignored the stinging sparks flying from her skin that charred the sleeves of his uniform. Pressing his forehead against hers, he inhaled deeply, forcing his own heart into a slow, disciplined beat. “Listen to my voice. Ignore the shriek. Recite the Creed in your mind. Remember, the words are the coordinates—don’t let them take control!”

A shelf of scrolls burst into flames, the Proxy Hearth’s energy proving too volatile for the physical wards to contain. The air grew hot, the reflection from the window casting horrific shadows against the ivory pillars.

Then, as quickly as the pressure had peaked, it snapped. The mist outside coiled, retreating toward the cypress line as the Great Bells—the consecrated bronze of the Angelus—began to toll, sending a physical shockwave that cleared the Boudreaux’s interference.

She slumped against his chest, her breath coming in uneven, desperate hitches. The Scriptorium was a disaster of shattered glass, torched paper, and the lingering, metallic taste of the demonic realm.

Sister Alba walked toward them, her fingers tight on her rosary. “It is as I feared, Father. They have found a way to bypass our reinforced barrier. They are using the girl’s lack of a Seal as an antenna. She is a hole in our defenses they can whistle through at will.”

Father Manuel helped her up. His priestly collar was askew, and his robes were stained with the soot of the burnt scrolls. “They almost turned you into a beacon for their own invasion, Kimberly. If your Shield had not grounded the bulk of that pulse, the Scriptorium would be a crater of ash. You would have been the doorway through which they marched into the core of this Academy.”

“How did this happen?” Roman asked, bracing himself against the table. “The Wards are consecrated. They should have held.”

“It appears they used a Proxy.” Father Manuel picked up a shard of broken glass. “A frequency human enough to trick the walls into recognizing it as life, but fatal enough to kill. We cannot wait the traditional six months for her initiation. The Root is growing faster than our defenses.”

He turned back to the girl, his eyes darkening. “We must move your Confirmation and First Communion to this Sunday. We have three days to prepare your spirit. If we don’t anchor you to the Eucharist, the next pulse will kill you.”

She looked down at the charred remains of her manual. The pages were curled, blackened, and gray. “Three days,” she whispered.

“Three days.” Roman stepped between her and the broken window, his posture locking back into strict alignment. “I won’t leave your side. Not for one second.”

THE DESCENT

Three in the morning—the Hour of Mercy, a thin, liminal space where the veil between the physical and the spiritual turned porous. They had come to the Adoration Chapel for a different kind of training. No tuning forks tonight, no spears or amplifiers; only the soft glow of the Sanctuary Lamp and the purity of the Real Presence.

“I thought I had to wait to be in here?”

“There’s no more waiting. This is what you are being prepared to receive.” Roman gestured toward the monstrance resting upon the altar. The awe-inspiring gold encapsulated the modest Bread in a perfect, celestial balance, flanked by carved cherubim at the base of the stand.

They moved reverently toward the front of the altar, where the flicker of votive candles formed a visual heartbeat, syncing with the pulse of the Chapel. Here, the illumination penetrated the superficial tissue of her scar, cleansing the lingering static surrounding her until only the sovereignty of the Presence remained.

“Meditation is not about clearing your mind; that’s a secular lie.” They knelt on the velvet-cushioned pews. “It’s

about making a space for the Lord to build within you. You have to descend into the center of your own soul and wait for Him to occupy the ruins.”

Kimbra began to pray. At first, the descent was terrifying. Usually, when turning her focus inward, there was only the static—the thorny vines of the Boudreaux manor and its seductive whispers. She felt her pulse quicken, her scar throbbing with the residual heat of her old life, her nerves mourning the loss of their master.

“Don't let the shadows of your past distract you. Direct your attention ahead, toward the monstrosity.”

She focused on the center of the Eucharist, then toward the image of the Sacred Heart hanging above, its flame perpetual. She imagined the red light of the Sanctuary Lamp pouring into her, filling the unguarded temple Father Manuel had spoken of. Slowly, the abrasive static began to fade. The vines dissolved, losing their color and form until they were subdued into a vast, oceanic peace.

Suddenly, the chapel walls vanished. She was no longer kneeling on the floor of the sanctuary; she stood in a realm of crystalline brilliance. Stillness reigned here, removed only by a frequency so powerful it guided her to kneel beneath its majesty.

In the center of the mystical vision, she felt the Presence. A Love so intense, yet it was not forceful. It was the One Soul. She felt a firm, sovereign hand rest upon her head. With a single touch, the ten years of her captivity were reduced to a speck of dust in an infinite, sun-drenched sky.

“You are not a battery. You are a daughter. You are mine.”

Her breath hitched in the physical world. For the first time, she saw the Chalice within herself. It was not the empty, cracked thing she had feared. It was overflowing with a shimmering liquid sun, pushing back the residue of her trauma. But then, she felt a secondary pulse—a warm, familiar density of iron and oak. Through the One Soul, she could feel Roman. Because they were already bound by the Sponsor’s Oath, his presence was visible even in this interior landscape. He was a pillar of steel, standing between her and a swirling fog clawing at the edges of her vision. He was holding the line even here, in the depths of her subconscious, his own life-force acting as a shield for her burgeoning holiness.

The vision receded, pulling her back to the physical world. She opened her eyes, her face wet with tears, washing away a decade of soot.

“He called me a daughter,” she trembled, looking toward the altar. “He said I wasn’t a battery.”

Roman leaned his forehead against the back of the pew, his own breath recalibrating. “It’s working—the link is strengthening. The Boudreaux can try to claim a soul, but they can’t unmake a daughter.” His disciplined facade stripped away for a fleeting second, exposing a rare dread. “Damian will see this encounter as a declaration of war. We have to move now.”

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The iron bolts of the St. Theresa of Avila cell clicked into place, rumbling through the subterranean levels of the campus grounds.

For the next seventy-two hours, she was to remain in the Chamber of Penance—a small room carved directly into the bedrock beneath the High Yard. There was no bed, only a simple kneeler and a table with a carafe of water and a single candle. The walls were etched with the Psalms of Protection in Latin.

“The fast is not only from food, Kimberly,” Father Manuel’s voice filtered through the iron grate. “It is an abstinence from the world’s noise. You must empty out the old wineskins of your spirit completely so there is no room for the enemy to hide. Only then can the Master fill your cup.”

Roman stood on the other side of the door. As her Sponsor, he was also bound to the fast. He would spend the next three days in the hallway outside her cell, sleeping on the floor as her physical and spiritual sentinel—the ground for her current through a foot of solid rock.

“I’m right here, Kim. Every prayer you say, I’m saying it with you. We’re closing the loop. The circuit is becoming one.”

+++

The first twenty-four hours were a descent into dryness—the spiritual desert. The proxy’s broadcast tried to find residence in her hunger, whispering of the warmth of the manor and the safety of the old chain. But every time the

shriek began, she focused on the Creeds Roman had taught her. *“I believe in God, the Father Almighty...”*

By the second night, the hunger had transformed into a lucid clarity. The walls of the cell were no longer a prison but the interior of a lung, breathing in sync with her.

On the third day—the eve of her Confirmation—came the Dark Night of the Soul.

She was kneeling, her forehead pressed against the stone, when the candle on the table suddenly extinguished without a draft. Twilight swallowed the room. She was filled with a sudden, localized dread—the agony of the Garden, a twisting blade in her heart.

“Roman?”

There was no answer. He was fast asleep on the floor, worn out by the vigil, his own defenses slipped into the exhausted rest of a warrior.

She heard the taunting whispers of the night trying to discourage her, reminding her of the debt she used to be, telling her the cell was a different kind of cage.

Focus, she reminded herself. Don't listen to the lies. The debt is paid by His Precious Blood.

She instinctively grabbed the rosary hanging on the wall. Her fingers fumbled over the beads.

“Hail Mary, full of grace...”

An inexplicable warmth enveloped the room, smelling of roses. The candle ignited once more, radiating a teal flame that banished all shadows. A sudden rupture of joy flooded her mind, guiding her in the first image of the Annunciation.

In her mind's eye, the Chalice revealed itself for the second time. Shedding the cracked, stained vessel the

Boudreaux family had used to trap their claim, it underwent a divine purification. An unseen radiance polished the surface, its sanctification smoothing over the scars of her past. She saw a figure standing in the midst of her vision—not a terrifying stranger, but a man holding a shepherd's staff. His eyes were filled with infinite Mercy. He did not speak of debts or legacies. He simply pointed to the empty space in her heart and spoke a single word that vibrated through her entire being, obliterating the last of the Boudreaux wire:

“Mine.”

At that precise moment, the antenna Sister Alba had feared stopped broadcasting and inverted. The mist clawing at the reinforced walls outside the building instantly recoiled, struck by a holy blow.

Outside the cell, Roman gasped, abruptly waking as his back propped against the secured door. He felt the surge from the signal through the stones—a massive, resolute wave of peace that brought him to his knees. It was not the stinging fire of the Proxy. It was the mass of the One Soul preparing to take up residence in the girl he had saved.

“Roman?”

“I can feel it.” He leaned his head back against the stone, his breath hitching with a redeeming relief—his own penance had ended.

“Tomorrow,” she said, and for the first time, there was no trace of fear in her tone. “Tomorrow, the Root will lose their foothold into my soul forever.”

THE LAMB'S SEAL

The Cathedral of Our Lady of Tears rose in a forest of limestone and flickering candlelight. Red banners—the color of martyrs—hung from the vaulted ceiling, invoking the descent of the Holy Spirit. Outside, a dense, atmospheric pressure pushed against the stained glass, threatening the beauty of the ancient liturgy.

She stood at the center of the aisle, a solitary figure in a hallowed space, clothed in a simple white linen dress with her feet firm on the platform. Behind her, Roman stood as her sponsor. He did not speak; the bond forged during the midnight vigil was a quiet space between their heartbeats—a pre-sacramental resonance harmonizing.

Father Manuel stood at the altar, holding the vial containing the Holy Chrism—the perfumed oil infused with the authority of the Catholic Church. “The enemy was never afraid of who you were, Kimberly. He feared who you’d become.”

The floor beneath them groaned. Millions of phantom fingernails clawed at the foundation, sending scratching noises throughout the structure. The mist from the Crimson

Root tore through the seams of the floorboards, translucent snakes winding around the pews.

The Proxy—the girl Vincent had used to replace her—was screaming from miles across the wetlands. The pressure of the phenomenon pressing against everyone in the Cathedral. The lighted candles extinguished in a sudden, unnatural draft.

“Don’t be afraid.” Roman clamped a reassuring grip onto her shoulder, drawing the abrasive discharge of the Proxy’s scream into his own ribs so she could remain clear.

“Remember the Shepherd. Remember the words He spoke to you.”

Evil whispers probed her mind, searching for a crack of doubt or a shard of unworthiness: “*Unclean. Unworthy.*” But the image of the Good Shepherd remained.

Father Manuel proceeded with the rite. He dipped his thumb into the thick, resinous oil and stepped toward her.

The mist surged in a desperate paroxysm. An invisible force slammed against the great Cathedral doors; the iron bolts shrieked and sparked under the strain. The stained glass of the North window blew inward. Sapphire and ruby shards rained down, glittering in the unnatural scarlet haze. The encroaching shadow solidified into a physical siege, frantically striking to sever her connection to the divine before the Seal was set.

“Kimberly, what is the name you will take for yourself as a Citizen of the Kingdom?” The Rector’s voice rose in a powerful, liturgical roar challenging the storm.

“Mary.” Her secret armor—a hidden shield beneath her own skin.

“Mary, be sealed with the Gift of the Holy Spirit.”

The moment the oil touched her forehead in the sign of the cross, a shockwave of divine energy erupted from the point of contact. Holy and absolute, the authority of the Creator cut through the room, reclaiming His property.

The Anointing’s sanctification obliterated the dreadful mist, leaving only a drift of steam. The scratching at the floorboards ceased. The howling wind died into a gentle breeze smelling of sweet, fresh water. Her signature’s antenna vanished—permanently sealed beneath a golden insulator.

“The gates of hell,” Father Manuel paused, looking at the now-silent Cathedral, “shall not prevail.”

He presented the Host in his consecrated hands. “*The Body of Christ.*”

“Amen.” She knelt to receive her First Eucharist. As she consumed the Bread of Life, the Real Presence moved from a temporary visitation to a permanent residence. The emptiness she had carried for ten years—that hollow space Damian had used as his playground—was gone.

When she stood up, she turned to look at the broken window. The tree line cut against the horizon in the distance. For the first time, the swamp was no longer an inescapable blackhole. It appeared small.

Roman stepped beside her. He surveyed the shattered windows, then admired her. He no longer saw a victim, a ward, or a Blood Lily. He saw Kimbra—fully armed, beautiful, and finally free.

“It’s over,” he said, the burden of her complete admission into the Kingdom lifting from his soul.

“No,” she replied, her voice instilled with a new, affirming power. “It’s just the beginning.”

+ + +

The Cathedral was empty now, save for the cleaning crews sweeping up the remaining shards of the North window. The scent of Holy Chrism—balsam and olive oil—still hung thick beneath the dome ceiling.

Kimbra stood near the baptismal font, her fingers brushing the cool stone edges. Roman approached her, having removed his imposing formal coat, standing in his white shirt with his sleeves rolled up.

“Father Manuel is looking for you.” He stood parallel to her, his posture relaxed as his gaze focused on the same distant horizon beyond the broken glass. “He wants to proceed with the advanced training.”

“I’m not the girl you found at the gate anymore.”

“I know. I can feel it.” He turned to face her, his expression open and unguarded. “I sensed the difference the moment the oil touched your forehead. The grounding I used to do—it’s different. I don’t feel your fear anymore. I feel your strength.”

She smiled. “Are you saying I’m no longer your assignment?”

“You were never just an assignment,” he admitted. “But as of an hour ago, the Sponsor’s Oath stands fulfilled. You are a confirmed citizen and soldier... My balance.”

He hesitated a fraction of a second before pressing his bare palm over her knuckles on the stone edge of the font. No static disrupted them; no stinging fire flared. Only a pure, human warmth remained—the steadfast heartbeat of two people bound into the Body of Christ.

“So, what happens now—now that the Boudreaux know they can’t break the Seal?”

He straightened, his posture locking back into the disciplined stance of a sentry. “Now, we stop playing defense.”

“Then we train.” She squeezed his hand “No longer guardian and ward. Partners.”

His fingers tightened around hers, a single, solid promise. “Partners. Implicitly.”

WHEN TWO BECOME ONE

The High Yard was empty. The mist at the edge of the perimeter had dissipated after the events in the Cathedral. Father Manuel stood at the edge of the training circle, his arms tucked into the folds of his cassock. He did not offer a lecture today; he simply watched.

Roman and Kimbra stood at the center of the quad. For the first time since the gate, he did not have his tuning forks, his leather gloves, or his protective gear. He stood in a simple tunic of blue linen, his feet planted firm against the white dust of the yard.

“No more Low-Sync.” He caught her eye and offered a quick, playful wink—a flash of the man he might have been before his world turned to shadow. It was an innocent tease, but it carried a new level of respect. “Before—I was the support to keep you from drifting away. Now, you lead the exercise. You are the Chalice; I am the base. If you don’t pour, I have nothing to hold.”

She felt the Eucharist—the Real Presence—as a constant, holy-fire in her core. It was no longer a leak. It was an immovable anchor. She knew her name was Mary in the secret registers of the Church—a hidden strength she now

carried—but she was still the girl who had outlived her own destruction.

“Ready.”

She searched inward, past the thorns of her past, wrapping her mind around the new diamond essence of her heart. Free of the need to force a scramble, she simply opened the doors of her spirit, letting the love of the One Soul radiate outward.

A physical heat shimmered in the space between them. As light poured out, the very stones beneath their feet shuddered, causing the white dust to dance in concentric circles.

Ordinarily, a signal of this magnitude would have charred his nerves and left his limbs trembling, but because she was Confirmed, the energy was ordered and precise. It became an oasis—cool water rushing into a parched well. He did not have to fight to ground the power; he simply had to expand the boundaries of his own essence to accommodate the sheer volume of the energy she was diffusing.

“It’s effortless,” he rasped, his eyes glowing with a replenished brilliance.

“Because we aren’t colliding against each other anymore. We are standing as One.”

Suddenly, Father Manuel threw a distraction pebble—a small piece of muddy peat infused with a trace of the Root—into the circle. In any other session, the discordant energy of the rock would have caused a Scrambler to flinch or a Shield to buckle.

Kimbra remained still. She did not even turn her head to acknowledge the projectile. She simply thought of the vision

she had witnessed in the Adoration Chapel. The luminous chord between them expanded into an impenetrable barrier of heavenly force. When the peat hit the field, it dissolved into gray ash before it even touched the ground, its vile energy completely neutralized.

“Excellent!” Father Manuel walked across the boundary of the mosaic, his cassock sweeping the white powder. “The link is no longer a theory. It is a proven testimony. But a testimony must be forged by law before it can withstand a siege. The Boudreaux’s proxy failed to breach the Cathedral, but they have tasted the strength of the Link. They will not stop. They will try to find the structural weaknesses in our very foundation. The Academy’s walls are old, and the salt is thinning in the lower bastions where the water table rises.”

He studied the two of them. “Before you weave the Bond’s frequency into the very architecture of this fortress, you must secure the circuit between yourselves. Roman, take the sponsor position. Kimberly, receive the anchor.”

The playfulness vanished from his expression, replaced by the discipline of a Sentinel. He stepped behind the girl, resting his hands on her shoulders. The contact was instant; the golden-white hum between them transitioned from a diffused heat into a solid current.

She knelt upon the celestial tiles, her bare palms pressing directly against the gritty surface of the yard. A solid, unyielding weight settled behind her as he took his place, his posture forming a physical and spiritual buttress.

Father Manuel raised his crucifix. “Recite the Oath of the Sentry Pair. Let the words be the coordinates.”

Roman's voice vibrated through her spine, his internal frequency calibrating with hers:

"I stand at the threshold where the rock meets the mire. I am a lead pipe cleared of its own noise. I renounce the luxury of a private heart; I surrender the cowardice of a secret room. Where there is a lie in me, let the Light cauterize the flesh. Where there is pride, let the Flame incinerate it to dust."

As the words cleared his throat, she felt her own breathing slow, matching his pace as she joined the current:

"I do not look for a hand to hold, nor a flame to warm me. I am the anvil. I am the iron rail against the gale. When the pulse hits, I will not buckle. When the broadcast passes through, I will be the seal. I will take the vibration into my own bones; I will bleed before I let the sanctuary burn."

The air around them began to condense, forming visible arcs of energy that skittered beneath her fingers.

"To the Chalice assigned to my soul, I swear my trust. I will be the stillness to her strength. I will be the bedrock when the water table rises and the foundation weeps. I will take her fear into my chest so she may emanate His Presence. If she falters, I will take the burn. I will melt into the ground to keep her standing."

Together, their voices synchronized, a singular harmony flowing in the courtyard:

"By the tears of our Mother, by the frequency of the Living God, by the Seven Gifts of the Holy Spirit—sealed in Fortitude—we are Citizens of the Kingdom, Soldiers of the Host. The gates of hell shall not prevail, and we will not abandon the Wall. Ad Regnum et Ad Dei Gloriam. Amen."

As the final word left their lips, the energy detonated. A shockwave of amplified grace swept across the High Yard, blowing the dust back into a pristine circle. The lingering violet stains on the distant ramparts receded, repelled by the formal establishment of the bond.

She stood up, her fingers instinctively lacing through his. The spiritual leveling of the Sacrament and the Oath had sealed any remaining gap.

“We walk the perimeter,” he said, his focus turned toward the battlements. “We become the heartbeat of the wall. We project the essence directly into the structure through our bond. If we do it right, the integrity will become an extension of the Co-link.”

She felt a surge of purpose. She had shed the passive safety of the walls to embody the very power keeping those defenses standing.

“Let’s go.”

As their laced fingers tightened, the divine essence flowed—a holy fire preparing to forge the ivory with His Grace.

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Vincent sat in his chair, a dreadful, funereal shadow masking his face. Across from him, the Proxy—the girl hollowed out to replace Kimbra—lay slumped over the velvet chaise. Her skin was a sickly violet; her breathing was a series of wet rattles. The failed assault on the Cathedral had nearly

extinguished her; the feedback from Kimbra's Seal was a deadly poison in her artificial circuit.

"She is useless to us now," he snapped. "Your little Kimmy has been snatched from us. She is no longer a source we can tune into. She has been made a fortress. The signal is dead."

Damian stepped out of the corner, his expanded physique bursting the threads of his suit, splitting down the seams. His eyes were no longer human; they were twin pools of churning, abyssal fire. He was fully charged—dangerously so. He had spent the last three days draining the secondary hearths of the minor covens, feeding on their vitality until his very marrow vibrated with a terrifying, unstable power.

"I don't care about the Shield." The floorboards beneath his boots charred, sending up thin ribbons of acrid smoke. *"Kimberly belongs to me."*

Vincent admired his son, seeing the monster he had helped create. "The Academy has stood for three hundred years, Damian. Their Co-link is a formidable anchor. You cannot whistle through that wall anymore."

"Then I'll pull the anchor up by its throat!" He tore the edge of the chaise. A surge of violent energy erupted from his palm, and the Proxy girl shrieked—not in pain, but a depleted conductor for his rage. He no longer needed her to reach his bride. He siphoned her entirely—a disposable battery to fuel his apex form.

"I'm done waiting." He turned toward the large, floor-to-ceiling window looking out across the expanse toward the Academy. In the distance, he could see the faint glow of the fortifying work they were performing on the ramparts.

“Let them fortify,” he rumbled. Cracks spider-webbed across the window pane. *“Let them build their walls. I’ll burn it all down.”*

Vincent watched his son, a slow smile spreading across his withered face. “Then go, son. Bring her home, and bring me the ashes of everyone who tried to stop you.”

Behind him, the Proxy girl released one last haunting, static-laced shriek before her body imploded into gray dust.

A violent crack of energy blew the manor windows outward. The monster transformed into a streak of violet shadow racing toward the Academy. The siege of the Legacy had begun.

THE GATES OF HELL

The South Ramparts were freezing, the frost-riven stone biting through the rubber soles of her boots with a numbing intensity.

They stood together, their palms fused by the incredible heat of the Co-link—a thermal bloom of energy holding back the biting chill of the bay. They had spent the last hour weaving the essence of the bond into the porous reinforcements, watching as the rock took on a pearlescent glow. The grueling work exacted a constant attrition of the nerves; yet, far from the illicit draining of her past, the strain triggered a miraculous overflow—a cup filling faster than it could pour.

“Stop.” Roman caught her arm, his fingers tightening over her sleeve as he felt a seismic shift in both the spiritual and physical atmosphere—a disruption in the tectonic plates of the Earth.

Kimbra felt the tremor a second later—a sudden drop in air pressure. Her ears popped. The purple mist at the edge of the forest began to boil and swirl, churned by a putrid current smelling of decay.

Above them, in the central watchtower, the massive bell began to swing in a clanging urgency—the Vesper of War—vibrating in her teeth and rattling her bones.

She forced a slow, measured breath. “Look.” She pointed toward the main gate, where the iron met the encroaching muck.

A streak of gloom moved across the expanse, a sharp tear in the fabric of the physical world. Wherever the shadow touched the ground, the consecrated salt scattered and turned to obsidian glass, cauterized by unadulterated rage.

Damian.

He slammed into the Outer Gate with the kinetic force of a falling star. The shockwave rattled the ramparts, the vibration traveling up through the soles of her boots and nearly throwing her from her feet. Roman caught her, his arm a solid bar against her waist, steadfast against the chaos.

The link flared in response to the threat, its marvelous sheen blinding—the brilliance of a midday sun. The shadow coalesced at the base of the gate into a form only passingly human. The entity stood monstrous in the center of the scorched earth, his suit tattered and smoking.

“KIMBRA!” His eyes blazed with hell fire. *“Did you really think a few drops of oil and a bit of prayer would save you? I am the Root! I am the Fire! Open the gate, or I will peel this stone back!”*

Father Manuel appeared on the walkway beside them, his face pale. He held his crucifix aloft. “The gate is consecrated, Damian Boudreaux! The Master of this house does not recognize your claim! You have no standing here!”

The entity laughed—a discordant vocalization causing the mosaic windows to spider-web in geometric patterns of stress. *“Then I’ll make Him recognize it!”*

He lunged forward, his fists striking the invisible barrier of the gate’s wards. A massive explosion erupted; the two frequencies clashed in a screech of grinding metal as the demonic tore against the divine. The ramparts groaned under the pressure of the displacement. The reinforcements they had just finished were the only things preventing the structure from collapsing into dust.

“He’s... he’s too strong. He’s burning through the secondary wards.”

“He’s burning himself out to do it.” Roman’s gaze never wavered from the gate. “He’s using the Proxy’s stolen life-force as toxic-octane fuel. It won’t last. We must be the anvil until his hammer breaks.”

Kimbra peered down at the monster. He glared back, there was a twisted longing—the look of a starving man staring at a feast he could no longer taste.

He pressed his face against the barrier, mouthing the words: *“You are mine.”*

Roman stepped in front of her, shielding her from his sight. “We are the fortification of the wall... Pour the Chalice into the fortress! Don’t look at him—focus your senses inward!”

She concentrated on the One Soul bond. She felt the Eucharist roar to life, a sun-bright energy bursting through her core and into her partner. Together, they projected a wall of celestial brilliance slamming down from the ramparts, meeting the crimson fire in a clash that lit up the wetlands

for miles, casting long, stark shadows across the cypress knees.

The blinding explosion at the gate left a ringing sensation in its wake, but the victory was short-lived. The demon did not retreat; he only pushed back a few yards, his feet buried in the scorched earth, smoking with the residue of the failed breach.

Kimbra's knees buckled. The feedback from the wards was a shocking blow to her torso. Roman caught her, his own ribs vibrating with the sheer volume of power they had channeled.

"He's tapping into the earth directly." His chest vibrated against her back. "He's pulling the power source from the swamp itself."

Below them, the monster stood up. The fire in his eyes had spread, veining his dermis like scorched alabaster. He raised his arms, and the soil responded. The trees at the edge of the marsh began to groan, their massive, gnarled roots tearing out of the muck—skeletal fingers climbing the wall. *"If the Gate will not open, then I will pull the earth from your feet!"*

The ground beneath the South Wall began to shudder with a sickening vibration. The enemy no longer attacked the infrastructure; he savaged the very soil the Academy sat upon in a brutal effort to unseat its foundation. A gaping fissure broke open.

"The Lower Bastions!" Father Manuel pointed toward the base of the wall. "He's found the open gaps in the water table!"

She could feel Roman's pulse through their link—fast, a drummer's pace, yet calm. He was the base, she was the cup, and the Chalice was overflowing with a power that demanded to be spent.

"We have to go down there—we can't reinforce the bedrock from up here. We have to meet him at the threshold."

"That's a death sentence." But his hand was already on her wrist, pulling her toward the stairs. "If the ward breaks while we're at the base, we'll be caught in the collapse of the entire bastion."

"*The gates of hell will not prevail,*" she reminded him, quoting the promise now etched into her very soul. "But they will conquer if we stay up here watching the world fall apart."

They blurred into motion, racing down the spiral stairs of the watchtower. As they landed on the lower courtyard, the outdoors smelled of sulfur, wet earth, and death. The foundation was weeping—beads of swarthy moisture seeping through the cracks where the Root was trying to penetrate.

At the base of the gate, the iron was glowing a dull, angry red. The monster was on the other side, his face pressed against the shimmering veil of the wards. He was no longer human—a starving wolf staring through a kitchen window.

"Roman, take the sponsor position!" Father Manuel ran to join them, accompanied by a group of Sentinels. "Kimberly, you are the Chalice! Project the Presence!"

Roman stepped behind her, wrapping his arms around her waist and bracing his feet against the floor. He was the

Ground—the lightning rod willing to absorb the impact of the entity's rage so she wouldn't shatter.

She ignored the horrific display at the gate, focusing into the very space between the atoms. She connected to the One Soul, the Shepherd's presence she had found in the solitude of her cell.

“Kyrie Eleison, Christe Eleison.” She remembered those words in her first battle for her own soul.

The thing at the gate growled, slamming his palms against the barrier. The fissure cracked the wall, and the stone beneath them groaned, tilting dangerously toward the swamp.

“Now!” Roman's voice vibrated directly through her collarbone.

The gold-white ignition detonated. They became a single, blinding pillar of fire shooting upward through the center of the gates, a spear of the sun. The frequency was so pure it became a physical grout, pouring into the cracks of the foundation, searing the very earth beneath them.

The entity was thrown back a hundred yards, his flames extinguished by the sheer force of the pure bond. He hit the black glass of the scorched flats and did not move, his form a dying circuit.

Kimbra slumped back against his chest, her robes scorched at the hem and covered in fine ivory dust. The wall stood. The foundation was still; the weeping had stopped. Roman's face was streaked with sweat and soot, his chest heaving as he pulled her closer, his heart beating in perfect, quiet time with her own.

Above them, the clouds settled, and the Great Bell of the South Campus Tower transitioned from the alarm to a fixed, triumphant toll signaling a battle won.

THE LOST BOY

The aftermath following the detonation of the Colink was unnatural—a dry vacuum snuffing out the insects' rasp. Beyond the gate, the smoke cleared to reveal a circle of glass where the consecrated dirt had been cauterized by the collision of opposing frequencies.

At the center of the circle lay the boy.

He was a broken silhouette against the white dust, a stain on a holy canvas. The fire was gone, replaced by a deathly pallor. He lay there, a discarded doll stripped of its monstrous majesty.

“Is he—is he dead?” She leaned against Roman’s shoulder. Her robes were still dusted with the white powder of the foundation—a ghost of the battle they had won.

“The link doesn’t kill. It rejects. It is a spiritual immune response. But the amount of power he was channeling—it’s a wonder his nervous system didn’t vaporize under the load.”

Father Manuel cautiously approached them, his boots crunching on the newly formed glass. He signaled to a team of Sentinels waiting at the entrance. “Retrieve him. Carefully. He is a child of God, however far he has strayed, and the Kingdom does not leave a soul to the crows.”

“Father, you can’t be serious.” Roman stepped off the stairs. “Bringing him inside these walls is inviting a plague into a hospital. He is a carrier for the very rot the Academy has spent centuries purging.”

“You are correct. We are a hospital.” Father Manuel kept his back to them, his gaze fixed on the approaching stretchers. “An infirmary of the spirit. If we leave him there, his father will simply scoop up the remains and restart the cycle of theft. Here, under the care and watch of our authority, we might actually see what is left of the man when the demon is evicted.”

She watched as the Sentinels approached the body. As they lifted the boy onto the stretcher, his head fell back, and the pale moonlight caught the angles of his face. He appeared younger—vulnerable—the arrogance wiped away by the leveling force of the holy link.

+ + +

The walk to the Infirmary was a funeral march through the campus. The students watched from the shadows of the cloisters, their faces pale and unmoving. To them, Damian Boudreaux was the boogeyman—the Legacy of the Root haunting their lineage for generations. Now, he was being carried through their halls on a piece of metal, a fallen prince in a city of stone.

They walked through the North Wing Infirmary—a place of sterile linens, antiseptic, and the constant chirp of medical

equipment. They placed him in a consecrated space to prevent any secondary broadcasts from leaking into the student population.

Roman stood at the foot of the bed, his arms crossed tightly, his eyes never leaving the boy's pale face. Kimbra stood beside him, the link within her stable now, no longer a roar of fire.

"He looks so small"—the words a betrayal of her own history.

"Don't be fooled, Kim. He's still the Root. The soul has memory, and the moment he wakes up, the shriek will return. It's in his blood."

Sister Marta entered, carrying a basin of holy water and a tray of sterilized instruments. She did not pay attention to them; her focus was entirely on the patient. She began to cut away the charred fabric of his sleeves, revealing deep cuts and bruises.

The nun adjusted the line of the drip. "His vitals are erratic. His internal frequency has been shattered. He is alive, but his vessel is... empty."

"Empty?" Kimbra struggled with the concept.

"Not only did the Co-Link stop him..." Father Manuel stepped to the opposite side of the bed, his hand resting lightly on the metal frame. "...It evacuated the entity he was possessing. It performed a complete exorcism of his power. For the first time in his life, the boy isn't being fueled by the demon. He is suffering from the sudden absence of the only energy he ever knew."

Damian's arms twitched—a spastic movement. His fingers, once so graceful then cruel, clawed at the white sheets,

searching for a wire no longer there. A low, broken rasp escaped his throat—not the arrogant shriek of a Master, but a thin, hollow whimper.

She felt a sharp, unexpected pang in her chest. It was not remorse for his pain—she knew he had earned every bit of it—but it was something substantial. It was a charity grieving for the brokenness of a soul. She moved toward his cold, sweat-beaded brow.

“Don’t.” Roman’s grip closed around her wrist in mid-air. “You’ve done enough, Kim. You’ve given him your life for ten years. Let Sister manage the remains.”

“I just... I want to know if he’s still in there... Or if the Root was all he ever was.”

As if answering her thought, the boy flinched. He remained submerged in the coma, but his lips moved. He managed to whisper a single word—a cold draft in the room:

“Kimmy...”

The silence in the Infirmary was more profound than it had ever been. The legacy was no longer a war of laws or a clash of spiritual realms; it was a lost boy in a white room who had called out her name.

Roman’s grip tightened on her wrist—a silent vow of protection. Outside, the swamp groaned, its trees leaning away from the Church’s victory—but inside, the true battle was for a soul at the brink of hell.

EPILOGUE

THE COST OF MERCY

Above the Academy of Our Lady of Tears, the moon had traded its blood-flush for a cold silver, stretching pale angles across the quad where the dust had settled. The Breach at the South Gate had been repaired, held together by the pearlescent substance created by the Link.

Inside the Infirmary, the sharp chirp of a life-support machine filled the ward. Damian was now anchored by crisp, linen sheets. He was trapped in a deep, comatose state—a void so vast the monitors struggled to detect any activity.

On the ramparts, Kimbra and Roman stood together. The thread between them was a soothing warmth—a bond that had survived the furnace.

“He’s stable—but our refuge won’t be the same. We’ve brought the war inside the house. He’s unconscious for now, but he’s still a Boudreaux.”

She wrapped her cloak tighter around her shoulders, her gaze fixed on the amber beacon of the chapel across the yard. “Father Manuel says the Link doesn’t merely protect; it purifies. Maybe he’s not a Boudreaux anymore. Maybe he’s waiting.”

“Waiting for what?” He turned to face her, his shoulder brushing hers in the dark.

“To see if the Light is real.” Her voice was barely a breath, her eyes reflecting the distant fire. She was not staying for the man she feared and hated; she was waiting to see if there was still a boy beneath the monster worth saving.

+ + +

Miles away, within the rotting nucleus of the manor, Vincent Boudreaux stood in his Library. Ignoring the empty dais where his Proxy had died, he was fixated on the imposing door at the end of the hall—one locked for years.

He tapped against its surface. From within the room, there was a subtle shift in the atmosphere—a faint, dry scraping.

“Patience, my child.” He pressed his palm flat against the timber. “The Priest has taken your Prince. He thinks he has won a soul, but he has only invited a guest who will open the door for us.”

He leaned his forehead against the exterior frame. “They are busy fortifying their gates. They will not be looking for a seeker. Prepare yourself. When their wall cracks, you will be the one to slip through.”

From behind the barrier, a wet vibration answered—neither shriek nor prayer, but a rattling friction:

“Ssssss...”

He smiled, a sinister expression in the moonlight. “The sanctuary is not as safe as they believe. We do not have to

attack from the outside. The Legacy of the Root will destroy it from within.”

HIGH RITE PRAYER OF THE ACADEMY:

Ave Maria

*Ave Maria, gratia plena, Dominus tecum. Benedicta
tu in mulieribus, et benedictus fructus ventris tui,
Iesus.*

*Sancta Maria, Mater Dei, ora pro nobis peccatoribus,
nunc et in hora mortis nostrae. Amen.*

Hail Mary

*Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord is with thee.
Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the
fruit of thy womb, Jesus.*

*Holy Mary, Mother of God, pray for our sinners, now
and at the hour of our death. Amen.*

Book 2

Serpent in the Sanctuary

COMING SOON...

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Author Bio



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At RedCandle Digital, our mission is simple: to create a beacon of light in the modern media landscape. Inspired by the sanctuary lamp burning ever-vigilantly beside the Tabernacle, we are a Catholic digital publishing group dedicated to producing content that gives Glory to the Most High.

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